

Sanskrit, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

Sanskrit, like Latin, is not learned for conversation. It is learned to read, to hear how much of the world’s vocabulary was assembled, and — above all — because it is a **taproot**: the classical ancestor of Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, and Bengali, whose every “hello” and “thank you” is a worn-down form of a Sanskrit word you will meet here in its full shape. And Sanskrit is at the same time a *sister* of Latin, Greek, and English — so its roots reach west (to *thee*, to Greek *eu-*, to *come*, to *no*) as surely as they reach east. Learning it ties the two halves of that inheritance together.

Sanskrit is classically written in **Devanagari**, the script you may already know from Hindi. This book teaches the reading *inside* the word lessons, with attention to the features Sanskrit needs even from a Devanagari reader — the *visarga* (ḥ), the vocalic ṛ, the conjuncts, and the *sandhi* that fuses words at their seams. (A reader new to the script learns it here from scratch; one who knows it skims the notes.)

We use standard **IAST** transliteration (the dotted ṛ, ḥ, ś, and macrons) alongside the Devanagari, and trace roots back toward Proto-Indo-European where the trail is clear — every form supplied in full. When Sir William Jones told the Asiatic Society in 1786 that Sanskrit bore to Latin and Greek “a stronger affinity... than could possibly have been produced by accident,” he launched the whole science of comparative linguistics; this book is, in miniature, a tour of the words he meant.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Sanskrit out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your*

turn are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) 👁 eyes (5) ✍ pen (3) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 9 lessons.

The Sanskrit greetings — and why they are the other **taproot** of the Indo-Aryan family. Every “thank you” and “hello” in the Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, and Bengali tracks points back here; and Sanskrit is at the same time a *sister* of Latin, Greek, and English, so its words reach west as well as east. Each lesson introduces the letters and the Sanskrit-specific reading its word needs.

1.1 नमस्ते (*namaste*) — “I bow to you”

The letters in this word

Devanagari runs **left to right** under a top line; every consonant carries a built-in “a.” न *na*, म *ma*, ते *te* (त + the *e*-sign े). A *hasanta* under स् strips its vowel so it joins the next: स् + त → स्त. Read नमस्ते as *na · ma · s · te*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्ते = *namas* (“a bow, obeisance”) + *te* (“to you”) — literally “**a bow to you.**” This is the *original*: the word every Indo-Aryan *namaste* descends from — Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, and Bengali all say a worn form of it. *Namas* comes from the root √*nam* “to bend, bow,” from Proto-Indo-European **nem-* “to allot, take.” And *te* “to you” is a family heirloom: the same Indo-European pronoun behind Latin *tē*, Greek *se*, and archaic English **thee**. Say *namas-te* and you are

speaking a word Cicero and Chaucer would each have half-recognised.

Why it's said this way

Palms pressed together (the gesture is *añjali*), a slight bow: the hands and the word say the same thing. *Namaste* greets the person before you as worthy of a bow — hello, and, when parting, goodbye. It is the greeting Sanskrit gave to half of South Asia.

1.2 नमस्कारः (*namaskārah*) — the fuller form

The letters in this word

New: का *kā* (क + the ā-sign ा), र *ra*, and the **visarga** ः — a soft breathed “h” at a word’s end, written as two dots. नमस्कारः = *namas-kā-rah*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्कारः = *namas* (“a bow”) + *kāra* (“the making, the doing,” from the root *√kr* “to do/make”). So *namaskāra* is “the **making** of a bow” — an act, where *namaste* is an address. That root *√kr* “to do” is one of the most productive in Sanskrit (it gives *karma*, “a thing done”); it is the Indo-European **k₁yer-* and a distant cousin of English *-ory/-ure* words of making. The final **visarga** *-ah* is the mark of the masculine singular — your first case-ending.

Grammar Lens

Namaste and *namaskāra* share the same first half, *namas*, but end differently because they *do* different grammatical jobs — one takes a pronoun (*te* “to you”), the other builds a noun (*-kāra* “the making of”). Sanskrit words are transparently assembled from roots and endings like this; once you see the seams, long words stop being frightening.

1.3 ढ — one character, met inside words you already say

A horizontal head-line (shirorekhā) runs across the top; letters hang beneath it like laundry on a line.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ढ

ढ — *na*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *n*, it is **na**.

What it is made of:

- a clockwise left loop joined to a rightward shoulder
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these words, and ढ is one of the shapes inside them — the rest of their shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *namaste* — hello (lit. “a bow to you”)
- *namaskāraḥ* — hello (lit. “the making of a bow”)

Writing: ढ

- **1.** start at the loop's inner-right curve, sweep down and clockwise around the small opening, then continue right along the shoulder without lifting
- **2.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the loop differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-न-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 11 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find न in it

न

- *Trace it:* न three times, saying *na* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find न once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — न? What sound does it carry? (*na*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

1.4 धन्यवादः (*dhanyavādaḥ*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ध *dha* (breathy *d*), व *va*, द *da*, and the conjunct न्य (न + य *ya*).
With the visarga again, read धन्यवादः as *dha · nya · vā · daḥ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

धन्यवादः = *dhanya* (“worthy, deserving,” from *dhana* “wealth”) + *vāda* (“a speaking, a statement,” from the root *√vad* “to speak”). Literally “a saying of ”you are worthy.” This is the *source* of the thanks you met to the east — Hindi *dhanyavād*, Marathi and Punjabi likewise — here in its full, un-worn Sanskrit shape, visarga and all.

1.5 स्वागतम् (*svāgatam*) — “welcome”

The letters in this word

New: the conjunct स्व (स् + व *va*) = *sva*, ग *ga*, and the *halant* म् *m* closing the word with no vowel. Read स्वागतम् as *svā · ga · tam*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

स्वागतम् = *su* (“well, good”) + *āgata* (“come,” from *ā* “toward” + the root *√gam* “to go/come”) — “**well come**,” which is exactly what English *welcome* means too. Two deep Indo-European threads surface here:

- *su-* “good” is the twin of **Greek *eu-*** — the *eu* of *euphoria*, *eulogy*, *euphemism*. Sanskrit *su-gata* and Greek *eu-* are the same prefix.
- the root *√gam* “to go/come” is the Indo-European **ǵwem-* — the very root of English **come** (and of Latin *venire*, hence *venue*, *convene*).

So *svāgatam* and *welcome* are not just parallel ideas but partly *cognate* ones.

1.6 द — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, one you have already met: न. Say what it does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: द

द — *da*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *d*, it is **da**.

What it is made of:

- a short top-to-bottom stem

- an outer body joined to an inward curl and down-right tail
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say this word, and ढ is one of the shapes inside it — the rest of its shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *dhanyavādaḥ* — thank you

Writing: ढ

- **1.** draw the short stem top-to-bottom
- **2.** lift at the stem's lower junction, sweep left through the upper shoulder and around the outer body, curl inward and clockwise through the loop, then continue down-right through the tail without lifting
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; another learner source stages the outer body and curl-tail separately

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ढ-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 8 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ढ in it

ढ

- *Trace it:* ढ three times, saying *da* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ढ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — द? What sound does it carry? (*da.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

1.7 आम् / न (*ām / na*) — “yes” and “no”

The letters in this word

New: आ — the **independent** vowel ā (the shape for a word-initial vowel) — closed by the halant म् *m*: आम् *ām*. And न *na*, a single consonant with its built-in “a.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आम् (*ām*, “yes”) and न (*na*, “no, not”). That *na* is a word you have already met wearing other clothes: it is Proto-Indo-European **ne* “not,” **the same negative** as the Latin *nōn* of the last track, as English **no**, **not**, **none**, as German *nein*, and as Hindi *nahīn*. Of all the words in this book, *na* may be the one that reaches furthest unchanged: one tiny syllable spoken, in some form, from Iceland to India for five thousand years.

Why it’s said this way

Classical Sanskrit, like Latin, leans on more than a bare “yes”: one often answers by echoing the verb, or with *ām*, *evam* (“so it is”), or *bāḍham* (“certainly”). The blunt yes/no habit of English is not universal — these old languages preferred to *say what they meant*.

1.8 Recap

Sanskrit		Meaning
नमस्ते	<i>namaste</i>	hello (“a bow to you”)
नमस्कारः	<i>namaskārah</i>	hello (“the making of a bow”)
धन्यवादः	<i>dhanyavādaḥ</i>	thank you
स्वागतम्	<i>svāgatam</i>	welcome (“well come”)
आम् / न	<i>ām / na</i>	yes / no

Sanskrit is the eastern taproot: *namas*, *dhanya-vāda*, and the bow that survives, worn smooth, as every Indo-Aryan hello and thank-you. But look which way its roots also point — *te* “to you” toward English *thee*, *su-* “good” toward Greek *eu-*, *√gam* toward *come*, *na* toward *no* and Latin *nōn*. When Sir William Jones noticed in 1786 that Sanskrit, Latin, and Greek were kin, *these* are the kinds of words he meant. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *mama nāma...* (“my name...”) — and Sanskrit’s astonishing verb, which marks person, number, *and* how many are speaking.

1.9 ँ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: न · द. Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ँ

ँ — *no sound of its own — it takes one away.*

It is a **vowel-killer**. Every consonant in this script arrives with an *a* already inside it — that is what an abugida is. This mark takes the *a* back, leaving the bare consonant. It is how the script writes two consonants in a row.

Where it sits: a stroke below that removes the inherent ‘a’ and forms a conjunct with the next consonant.

Worked through: न + ँ = न् — *n*.

You already say these words, and ँ is one of the shapes inside them — the rest of their shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *namaste* — hello (lit. “a bow to you”)
- *namaskāraḥ* — hello (lit. “the making of a bow”)
- *dhanyavādaḥ* — thank you
- *svāgatam* — welcome (lit. “well come”)

Writing: 𐌺 — copy what you see

Put your pen on 𐌺 and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find 𐌺 in it

𐌺

- *Trace it:* 𐌺 three times, and each time say what it does: **it kills the built-in a**
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find 𐌺 once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — 𐌺? What does it do to the consonant it sits on? (**Takes away the built-in a.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 👁️ eyes (6) ✍️ pen (4) 🗣️ **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 12 lessons.

Now a first real exchange — and, since this is Sanskrit, each atom is the *ancestor* of words across both Europe and modern India:

मम नाम अरुणः अस्ति। (mama nāma Aruṇaḥ asti — “My name is Arun.”)
तव नाम किम्? (tava nāma kim — “What is your name?”)

2.1 नाम (*nāma*) — “name,” the source of a word half the world shares

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाम (*nāma*, “name”) is from the stem *nāman*, from Proto-Indo-European **h₃nomn*. This is not a borrowing but the *ancestor*: English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**), Greek *onoma*, and, worn down, Hindi *nām*, Bengali *nām*. Saying *nāma*, you stand near the headwaters of a word that flowed to both Europe and modern India.

2.2 मम (*mama*) — “my,” the ancestor of *me* and *my*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मम (*mama*, “my, of me”) is the genitive of अहम् (*aham*, “I”), on the first-person root *ma-*, PIE **me-* — the source of English **me**, **my**, **mine**, Latin *meus*, and Hindi *merā*. Sanskrit *mama* and English *my* are the same ancient word, one still in its old form.

2.3 ः — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: न · द · ः.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ः

ः — *h*.

It is a **visarga**: not a letter, but a soft breathed *h* at the end of a syllable. It is the mark that ends a great many Sanskrit masculine nouns, so it is worth knowing on sight.

Where it sits: a pair of dots to the right of the syllable, marking a voiceless post-vocalic breath.

Worked through: न + ः = नः — *naḥ*.

You already say these words, and ः is one of the shapes inside them — the rest of their shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *namaskāraḥ* — hello (lit. “the making of a bow”)
- *dhanyavādah* — thank you

Writing: ः — copy what you see

Put your pen on ः and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find अ in it
- *Trace it:* अ three times, saying ḥ as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find अ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — अ? What does it add to the end of a syllable? (**A soft breathed ḥ.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

2.4 अस्ति (*asti*) — “is,” the ancestor of *is* and *est*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अस्ति (*asti*, “is”) is the third person of the root अस् (*as-*, “to be”), PIE *h₁es- — the source of English **is**, Latin *est*, Greek *esti*, and Hindi *hai* (from *asti* directly). Unlike its Dravidian neighbours (Tamil and Bengali drop “is”), Sanskrit *keeps* an explicit copula — the word Europe kept too.

2.5 मम नाम ...अस्ति — “my name is...”

मम (my) + नाम (name) + अस्ति (is) = “my name is...” The verb comes **last**.

Grammar Lens

Sanskrit keeps the “is.” Tamil says only *en peyar Arun*, Bengali *āmār nām Arun* — both dropping the verb. Sanskrit says *mama nāma ...asti*, with an explicit *asti* — the Indo-European way, kept by Latin and English too.

2.6 आ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ढ · ् · ँ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: आ

आ — ā.

It is an **independent vowel**: the full-size letter a vowel wears when it opens a word and has no consonant to lean on. Inside a word the same vowel is written as a small sign instead.

What it is made of:

- the joined upper-and-lower left body of *a*
- a middle shoulder
- an inner vertical stem
- a trailing vertical stem
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say this word, and आ is one of the shapes inside it — the rest of its shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- ām / na — yes / no

Writing: आ

- 1. curve around the upper bowl, then continue down and around the lower bowl without lifting
- 2. lift and sweep the middle shoulder right
- 3. lift and draw the inner stem top-to-bottom
- 4. lift and draw the trailing stem top-to-bottom
- 5. lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 4. The pen comes up 4 times and no more.

verified modern printed teaching form; other Devanagari traditions split the shared *a* body into more strokes

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Saurmandal, ‘Devanagari आ stroke order.svg’, frames 1–5, Wikimedia Commons, 5 August 2023.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find आ in it
- आ
- *Trace it:* आ three times, saying ā as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find आ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — आ? What sound does it carry? (*ā*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

2.7 भवान् and त्वम् (*bhavān*, *tvam*) — “you,” respectful and familiar

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

त्वम् (*tvam*, familiar “you”) is from PIE *tū — the ancestor of English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, Hindi *tū*. भवान् (*bhavān*, respectful) is really a third-person honorific, “your honour” (from *bhavat*), and so takes a *third-person* verb.

Grammar Lens

Politeness by grammatical person. Where Hindi makes respect *plural* (*āp ...haiṃ*), Sanskrit makes it *third-person*: you address someone as though speaking *about* them — “is your honour well?”

2.8 किम् (*kim*) — “what,” root of many question-words

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

किम् (*kim*, “what”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE *k^wo- — the ancestor of English **what**, **who**, Latin *quis*, and Hindi *kyā*. Sanskrit’s own questions all grow from this *ka-*: *kim* (what), *kaḥ* (who), *kadā* (when), *kutra* (where), *katham* (how) — the single seed of both Europe’s *qu-/wh-* and India’s *k-* words.

2.9 भ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ् · ः · आ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: भ

भ — *bha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *bh*, it is **bha**.

What it is made of:

- a clockwise upper loop joined to a descending trunk
- a clockwise lower bowl continuing through a rightward crossbar
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say this word, and भ is one of the shapes inside it — the rest of its shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *bhavān* / *tvam* — you

Writing: भ

- **1.** start at the upper loop’s lower inner tip, sweep left and clockwise around the upper loop, descend the joined trunk, curl clockwise around the lower bowl, and continue right through the crossbar without lifting
- **2.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; another learner source stages the upper and lower body parts separately

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: JackPotte, ‘Devanagari b^h भ.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 29 March 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find भ in it

भ

- *Trace it:* भ three times, saying *bha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find भ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — भ? What sound does it carry? (*bha.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

2.10 तव नाम किम्? — “what’s your name?”

तव (*tava*, “your,” genitive of *tvam*) + नाम (name) + किम् (what) = “your name what?” Here Sanskrit often drops *asti*. Respectfully: भवतः नाम किम्? (*bhavataḥ nāma kim?*). Note *mama* / *tava* / *bhavataḥ* — “my / your / your-honour’s,” all genitives.

2.11 आनन्दः (*ānandaḥ*) — “joy,” and “a joy to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

To say “pleased to meet you,” Sanskrit can say भवन्तं दृष्ट्वा आनन्दः (*bhavantaṁ dṛṣṭvā ānandaḥ*) — “seeing you, [there is] joy.” आनन्दः (*ānandaḥ*, “joy, bliss”) is *ā-* (“fully”) + नन्द् (*nand*, “to rejoice”) — the *ānanda* of *sat-cit-ānanda* (“being-consciousness-bliss”) and the name **Ānanda**, the Buddha’s disciple. A simple greeting reaches for the word Indian thought uses for the deepest happiness.

2.12 The whole exchange

Sanskrit	English
मम नाम मीरा अस्ति।	My name is Mira.
तव नाम किम्?	What’s your name?
मम नाम अरुणः अस्ति।	My name is Arun.
भवन्तं दृष्ट्वा आनन्दः।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom is a *source*: *nāma* ($\rightarrow$ name), *mama* ($\rightarrow$ my), *asti* ($\rightarrow$ is), *kim* ($\rightarrow$ what). And Sanskrit keeps the copula its Dravidian neighbours drop. Next chapter: *bhavān katham asti?* (“how are you?”).

2.13 ि — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ं · आ ·
 ऋ. Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ि

ि — *i*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a curl placed BEFORE (to the left of) the consonant, though pronounced after.

Worked through: न + ि = नि — *ni*.

You already say these words, and ि is one of the shapes inside them — the rest of their shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *asti* — is
- *mama nāma ... asti* — my name is...
- *kim* — what
- *tava nāma kim?* — what's your name?

Writing: ि — copy what you see

Put your pen on ि and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find *i* in it

i

- *Trace it:* *i* three times, saying *i* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find *i* once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — *i*? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *i* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 👁️ eyes (4) ✍️ pen (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 9 lessons.

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — carried by the copula whose forms fathered English *am* and *is*:

भवान् कथम् अस्ति? (*bhavān katham asti* — “How are you?”)
अहं कुशली अस्मि, धन्यवादः। (*ahaṁ kuśalī asmi, dhanyavādah* — “I am well, thank you.”)

3.1 कथम् (*katham*) — “how,” another of the ka-questions

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कथम् (*katham*, “how”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE *k^wo- — the root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. It heads the same *ka-* family (*kim*, *kaḥ*, *kadā*, *kutra*, *katham*), and gives the noun *kathā* (“a telling, a story”) and, worn down, Hindi’s *kaise*.

3.2 भवान् कथम् अस्ति? — “how are you?”

भवान् (*bhavān*, respectful “you”) + कथम् (how) + अस्ति (is) = “your honour how is?” Recall that *bhavān* (“your honour”) takes a **third-person** verb — so *asti* (“is”), not “are.” Familiar: त्वं कथम् असि? (*tvam katham asi?*).

Grammar Lens

The copula, three persons: अस्मि (*asmi*, “I am”), असि (*asi*, “you are”), अस्ति (*asti*, “is”) — ancestors of English **am** and (via Latin/Greek) *is/est*. “How are you?” asks after a *state*, and Sanskrit always kept a verb for it.

3.3 ा — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: आ · भ · ि. Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ा

ा — *ā*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a vertical bar to the right of the consonant.

Worked through: न + ा = ना — *nā*.

You already say these words, and ा is one of the shapes inside them — the rest of their shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *namaskārah* — hello (lit. “the making of a bow”)
- *dhanyavādah* — thank you
- *svāgatam* — welcome (lit. “well come”)
- *nāma* — name

Writing: ा — copy what you see

Put your pen on ा and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ा in it
- ा
- *Trace it:* ा three times, saying ā as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ा once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ा? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts ā on; takes the built-in a off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

3.4 अहम् (*aham*) — “I,” the ancestor of *ego* and *I*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अहम् (*aham*, “I”) is from PIE *h₁eǵ(H)om — the ancestor of Latin **ego**, Greek *egō*, and, worn all the way down, English **I**. Sanskrit *aham*, Latin *ego*, English *I* are one word across time. Its possessive is *mama* (“my”); curiously, “I” and “my” come from *different* roots (*eǵ- and *me-) — a quirk Sanskrit shares with English (*I* vs. *my*).

3.5 कुशलम् (*kuśalam*) — “well-being,” and how to answer

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कुशलम् (*kuśalam*, “well-being, welfare”) is native Sanskrit, famously from कुश (*kuśa*, the sacred grass) + a root of “cutting”: first “skilled [at gathering *kuśa* properly],” hence “adept, fit, in good order,” hence “well.” The reply: अहं कुशली अस्मि (*ahaṁ kuśalī asmi*), “I am well.”

3.6 म — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: भ · ि · ँ. Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: म

म — *ma*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *m*, it is **ma**.

What it is made of:

- a top-to-bottom left stem joined to a clockwise lower loop and rightward crossbar
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has म somewhere inside it:

- आम् / न *ām* / *na* — yes / no
- नाम *nāma* — name
- मम *mama* — my

Writing: म

- 1. descend the left stem, curl left and clockwise around the lower loop, and continue right through the crossbar without lifting
- 2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 3. lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; another learner source stages the left stem and loop-crossbar separately

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: JackPotte, ‘Devanagari म म.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 29 March 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find म in it
आम् / न · नाम · मम
- *Trace it:* म three times, saying *ma* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find म once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — म? What sound does it carry? (*ma.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

3.7 न चिन्ता (*na cintā*) — “no worry”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

न चिन्ता literally “[there is] **no worry**” — न (*na*, “not,” from Chapter 1) + चिन्ता (*cintā*, “anxious thought,” from the root *cint* “to think”). Used for “never mind / you’re welcome.” *Na* is the ancient negative, PIE *ne, behind English **no**, **not**, Latin *nōn*; *cintā* is the same worry

Writing: 3 — copy what you see

Put your pen on 3 and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find 3 in it

3

- *Trace it:* 3 three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find 3 once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — 3? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *u* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (4) ✍️ pen (2) 🖐️ **Hands-free start:** first 2 of 7 lessons.

Sanskrit has no casual “bye.” Like its daughters, it takes leave by “I go” — and promises a seeing to come:

पुनर्दर्शनाय। (*punar-darśanāya* — “Until we meet again.”)

4.1 गच्छामि (*gacchāmi*) — “I go” (taking leave)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

गच्छामि (*gacchāmi*, “I go”) is from the root गम् (*gam*, “to go”) — the root inside Chapter 1’s स्वागतम् (*svāgatam* = *su* + *āgata*, “well come”). That root is PIE *g^wem-, the ancestor of English **come**. To leave politely one says *gacchāmi* (“I go”) or *āgacchāmi* (“I shall come [back]”) — the “promise of return” the modern languages kept.

4.2 पुनः (*punaḥ*) — “again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पुनः (*punaḥ*, “again, once more”) is a native adverb (combining form *punar-*, as in *punar-janma*, “rebirth”). No single English cognate, but its work is shared: it turns a parting into “see you *again*.”

4.3 र — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ा · ण · ु.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: र

र — *ra*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *r*, it is **ra**.

What it is made of:

- a top-to-bottom stem curling clockwise around the lower loop
- a diagonal tail
- the top shirorekhā

You already say this word, and र is one of the shapes inside it — the rest of its shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *namaskārah* — hello (lit. “the making of a bow”)

Writing: र

- **1.** start at the headline junction, descend the stem, and curl left and clockwise around the lower loop to the tail junction
- **2.** lift at that junction and draw the diagonal tail down-right
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; another animated learner source joins the loop and diagonal tail

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-र-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find र in it
- र
- *Trace it:* र three times, saying *ra* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find र once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — र? What sound does it carry? (*ra*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

4.4 पुनर्दर्शनाय (*punar-darśanāya*) — “until we meet again”

पुनर् (*punar*, “again”) + दर्शनाय (*darśanāya*, “for seeing”) = “for seeing [you] again.” The word दर्शन (*darśana*, “seeing, vision”) is deep: the *darśan* one takes of a deity, and the name of the six *darśanas*, the schools of Indian philosophy (“ways of seeing”). This farewell promises a *beholding* to come.

Grammar Lens

The dative “for the sake of.” The ending -आय (-*āya*) is the dative singular — “to / for.” *Darśana* (a seeing) → *darśanāya* (for a seeing). Your first case.

4.5 श्वः (*śvaḥ*) — “tomorrow”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

श्वः (*śvaḥ*, “tomorrow”) is from PIE *kes-. Where the modern languages muddle “tomorrow” and “yesterday” into one word (Hindi *kal*, Bengali *kāl*, from *kāla* “time”), classical Sanskrit kept them *separate*: *śvaḥ* is “tomorrow,” *hyaḥ* is “yesterday.” “See you tomorrow” is श्वः पुनर्दर्शनम् (*śvaḥ punar-darśanam*).

Grammar Lens

That the daughters blurred *śvaḥ* / *hyaḥ* into a single *kal* is a window into language change: the modern tongues traded precision for economy, letting tense carry the load.

4.6 The farewells

Sanskrit	English
गच्छामि।	I go. (taking leave)
पुनर्दर्शनाय।	Until we meet again.
श्वः पुनर्दर्शनम्।	See you tomorrow.

Roots banked: *gam* “to go” (→ English **come**), *punaḥ* “again” (→ *punar-janma*), *darśana* “a beholding,” and *śvaḥ* / *hyaḥ* — “tomorrow” / “yesterday,” kept apart. Next chapter: the first real verbs — and Sanskrit’s count to *three*.

4.7 प — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: म · उ · र.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: प

प — *pa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *p*, it is **pa**.

What it is made of:

- a left stem curving around the lower bowl to its upper-right junction
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has प somewhere inside it:

- पुनः *punah* — again

Writing: प

- 1. descend the left stem, then curve right around the lower bowl and rise to its upper-right junction without lifting
- 2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 3. lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the bowl differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-प-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find प in it

पुनः

- *Trace it:* प three times, saying *pa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find प once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — प? What sound does it carry? (*pa.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (4) ✍️ pen (3) 🖱️ **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 8 lessons.

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and the most famous feature of the Sanskrit verb: it counts to **three**.

अहं संस्कृतं वदामि। (*ahaṃ saṃskṛtaṃ vadāmi* — “I speak Sanskrit.”)

5.1 वदामि (*vadāmi*) — “I speak,” and the Sanskrit verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

वदामि (*vadāmi*, “I speak”) is from the root वद् (*vad*, “to speak”) — the root of वाद (*vāda*, “a saying”) inside Chapter 1’s धन्यवादः (*dhanyavādaḥ*). The present is stem + ending: *vad-ā-mi*, where *-mi* means “I” (the same *-mi* as in *asmī*, “I am”).

Grammar Lens

Singular, dual, plural. Where English and Hindi count in two, Sanskrit counts in **three**, with a **dual** for exactly two:

number	form	meaning
singular	<i>vadāmi</i>	I speak
dual	<i>vadāvaḥ</i>	we two speak
plural	<i>vadāmaḥ</i>	we (three or more) speak

A whole number just for pairs — two eyes, two hands, a couple. Greek

had it and lost it; English never kept it; Sanskrit polished it.

5.2 य — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ङ · र · ण.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: य

य — *ya*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *y*, it is **ya**.

What it is made of:

- a clockwise inner curl
- a lower bowl rising to the right-stem junction
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these words, and य is one of the shapes inside them — the rest of their shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *dhanyavādaḥ* — thank you
- *punardarśanāya* — until we meet again (lit. “for seeing again”)

Writing: य

- **1.** start beneath the headline, curve clockwise around the inner curl, and finish at the left waist
- **2.** lift at that waist, curve down and right around the lower bowl, and rise to the right-stem junction

- **3.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **4.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified four-stroke teaching form; another animated learner source joins the inner curl and lower bowl

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-य-order.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find य in it
- य
- *Trace it:* य three times, saying *ya* as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find य once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — य? What sound does it carry? (*ya.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.3 अहं संस्कृतं वदामि — “I speak Sanskrit”

अहम् (I) + संस्कृतम् (the object) + वदामि (speak) — “I Sanskrit speak,” verb last. The name संस्कृत (*saṃskṛta*) means “**put together, perfected**” — सम् (*sa-*, “together,” cousin of English *same*, Greek *syn-*) + कृत (*krta*, “made,” from *kr*). Named in contrast to *prākṛta* (“natural, raw” — Prakrit, the everyday speech from which Hindi, Bengali, and the rest descend).

Grammar Lens

Sandhi joins the words. *aham* + *saṃskṛtam* runs together as *aham saṃskṛtam* — the *m* softening to the anusvāra. That is *sandhi*, met in Chapter 1’s *svāgatam*; it is why Sanskrit flows.

5.4 वसामि (*vasāmi*) — “I live, I dwell”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

वसामि (*vasāmi*, “I dwell, live”) is from the root वस् (*vas*, “to dwell”), PIE *wes- — the ancestor of English **was** and **were** (the past of “to be” began as “to dwell/remain”). From *vas* come *vāsa* (“a dwelling”), *nivāsa* (“a residence”), *Vārāṇasī*. “I live in the city” is अहं नगरे वसामि (*aḥaṃ nagare vasāmi*).

Grammar Lens

“In” is a case-ending. नगरे (*nagare*, “in the city”) = *nagara* in the locative (-e, “in/at”). Sanskrit has no separate word for “in” — it is folded into the noun’s ending, the ancestor of Hindi’s and Bengali’s postpositions.

5.5 ृ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: र · प · य.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ृ

ृ — *r̥*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a small hook below (the vocalic *r*, common in Sanskrit).

Worked through: न + ृ = नृ — *nr̥*.

You already say this word, and ृ is one of the shapes inside it — the rest of its shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *aḥaṃ saniskṛtāṃ vadāmi* — I speak Sanskrit

Writing: ॠ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ॠ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ॠ in it

ॠ

- *Trace it:* ॠ three times, saying *r* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ॠ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ॠ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *r* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.6 करोमि (*karomi*) — “I do,” from the root behind *karma*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

करोमि (*karomi*, “I do, make”) is from the root कृ (*kṛ*, “to do”), PIE *k^wer- — the root at the heart of this book: *namaskāraḥ* (“the making of a bow”), *karma* (“a thing done”), *saṃskṛta* (“put together”). “I work” is कार्य करोमि (*kāryaṃ karomi*) — and कार्यम् (*kāryam*, “work”) is itself from कृ. So “I work” is, at root, “*kṛ*-thing I *kṛ*-do.” Hindi’s *kām karnā* and Bengali’s *kāj karā* are its worn-down grandchildren.

5.7 Sentences about yourself

Sanskrit	English
अहं संस्कृतं वदामि।	I speak Sanskrit.
अहं नगरे वसामि।	I live in the city.
अहं कार्यं करोमि।	I work.
वदावः।	We two speak. (the dual)

Three verbs, one engine (the *-mi* “I”), the verb always last, “in” folded into a case-ending — and a whole number, the **dual**, for exactly two. Roots banked: *vad* (speak → *dhanyavāda*), *vas* (dwell → English **was**), *kṛ* (do → *namaskāra*, *karma*, *saṃskṛta*). From here, Sanskrit — the source these tracks all point back to — only opens further.

5.8 अ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: प · य · ृ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: अ

अ — *a*.

It is an **independent vowel**: the full-size letter a vowel wears when it opens a word and has no consonant to lean on. Inside a word the same vowel is written as a small sign instead.

What it is made of:

- a joined upper-and-lower left body
- a middle shoulder
- a right vertical stem
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these words, and अ is one of the shapes inside them — the rest of their shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *asti* — is
- *mama nāma ... asti* — my name is...
- *bhavān katham asti?* — how are you?
- *aham* — I

Writing: अ

- 1. curve around the upper bowl, then continue down and around the lower bowl without lifting
- 2. lift and sweep the middle shoulder right
- 3. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 4. lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified modern printed teaching form; other Devanagari traditions split the body into more strokes

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Saurmandal, ‘Devanagari अ stroke order.svg’, frames 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 5 August 2023.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find अ in it
- अ
- *Trace it:* अ three times, saying *a* as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find अ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — अ? What sound does it carry? (*a.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

Modes: ⇨ voice (2) 👁 eyes (1) ✍ pen (1) ⇨ **Hands-free start:** none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the Sanskrit numerals एक to पञ्च with their dual and gendered forms, and follow पञ्च outward into Punjab, pentagon, and the disputed history of punch.

Trace pañca out of Sanskrit: into Persian panj-āb, the five waters behind Punjab; into Greek pente in pentagon and pentathlon; and into punch, with the five-ingredients account labelled as common rather than settled.

6.1 एक, द्व, त्रि, चतुर्, पञ्च — one to five

This chapter does something the other Indic chapters can't do alone. Sanskrit preserves the **Old Indo-Aryan forms behind** the Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Gujarati and Punjabi ones — and, at the same time, these forms are **cousins** of the English ones. Learn five and you get a foothold in both directions.

You'll want to know: the five

	stem	masculine	neuter
1	éka-	एकः ékaḥ	एकम् ékam
2	dvá-	द्वौ dváu	द्वे dvé
3	tri-	त्रयः trayaḥ	त्रीणि trīṇi
4	catúr-	चत्वारः catvāraḥ	चत्वारि catvāri
5	पञ्च pañca	—	—

Three notes, and the third one matters more than it looks.

Sanskrit has a dual — a separate number for exactly two things — which is why “two” is *dváu* rather than a plural.

***Pañca* barely inflects in the nominative and accusative. It is also the one you already half-know.**

And Sanskrit numbers have gender. Look at the last column. These same words, in Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Gujarati, and Punjabi, mostly descend from the **neuter** forms — *trîṇi* and *catvāri*, not *tráyah* and *catvārah*. Keep that column in view; the daughter languages inherit from it.

What you’ve built: two directions

These five forms point in two directions. The next lesson lines them up with Latin and English and explains the sound laws. A final short lesson follows *pañca* into *Punjab*, *pentagon*, and the qualified history of *punch*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “eka, dva, tri, catur, pañca”
- the exactly-two category — dual
- the daughter-language column — neuter

Before you move on

Give one to five in Sanskrit. (*Eka, dva, tri, catur, pañca*.) Why does “two” look unusual? (Sanskrit has a **dual** — a form for exactly two.) Which column will the modern languages mostly descend from? (**The neuter** — *trîṇi, catvāri*.) Which number barely changes across gender in this table? (*Pañca*.) Next: connect the Sanskrit forms west to Latin and English.

6.2 The Sanskrit numbers are English cousins

Give the five stems: *eka, dva, tri, catur, pañca*.

What you’ve built: one family, not borrowing

Sanskrit	Latin	English
<i>éka-</i>	<i>ūnus</i>	one
<i>dvá-</i>	<i>duo</i>	two
<i>tri-</i>	<i>trēs</i>	three
<i>catúr-</i>	<i>quattuor</i>	four
<i>páñca</i>	<i>quīnque</i>	five

Sanskrit, Latin, and English inherited these from one family. Numbers resist replacement, so their relationship remains audible after millennia. The first row needs one caveat: *éka-* and *ūnus/one* use the same root with different suffixes, PIE **oy-ko-* versus **óynos*. They are relatives rather than the same complete word. The other four rows continue the same word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

PIE **k^w* was a *k* with rounded lips. In **k^wetwóres* “four,” three branches treated it differently:

branch	outcome	example
Latin	kept <i>qu-</i>	<i>quattuor</i>
Indo-Iranian	merged it with <i>k</i> , then palatalised before front vowels	<i>catvāri</i>
Germanic	shifted it to <i>hw-</i>	<i>what, who</i>

Sanskrit *c-* is therefore a regular result, not a random replacement. The same sequence helps explain *pañca*’s *ñc*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The **f**- of *five* does not come from **k^w*. It comes from initial **p*, changed to *f* by **Grimm’s law**, as in *pater* → *father* and *pēs* → *foot*. English *four* is irregular. By the sound rule it should begin *hw-* like *what*. Its *f-* is usually explained as analogy with neighbouring *five*. Counting words can reshape one another.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tri, trēs, three*
- rounded *k* — *quattuor, catvāri, what*
- initial *p* → *f* — *pañca/five*
- regular inheritance or borrowing — inheritance

Before you move on

Are the Latin and Sanskrit forms borrowed from one another? (No: they are inherited cousins.) What are the three outcomes of $*k^w$? (Latin *qu-*, Indo-Iranian *c-* after merger and palatalisation, Germanic *hw-*.) Where does *five*'s initial *f* come from? (PIE *p* by Grimm's law.) What is the usual explanation for *four* also beginning with *f*? (Analogy with neighbouring *five*.)

6.3 ञ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: य · ृ · अ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ञ

ञ — *ñā*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ñ*, it is **ñā**.

What it is made of:

- a clockwise open-left bowl
- a rightward shoulder rising to the headline
- a short descending lower stem
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these words, and अ is one of the shapes inside them — the rest of their shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *eka dva tri catur pañca* — one to five — Old Indo-Aryan ancestors preserved in Sanskrit, and cousins of the English ones
- *eka · dva · tri · catur · pañca* — the Sanskrit, Latin, and English number family and the sound laws between them

Writing: अ

1. start at the open upper-left tip and curve clockwise around the bowl to the open lower-left tip
2. lift at the bowl's right junction, sweep right through the shoulder, then curve upward along the right side to the headline
3. lift at the lower right-side junction and descend the short stem below the bowl
4. lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified four-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, 'Deva-अ-order.gif', strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find अ in it

अ

- *Trace it:* अ three times, saying *ñā* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find अ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ञ? What sound does it carry? (*ña*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

6.4 *Pañca* hiding in familiar words

Say Sanskrit “five.” (*Pañca*.) Give its English cousin. (*Five*.)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Punjab comes from Persian *panj-āb*, “five waters,” for the land of five rivers spanning India and Pakistan. Persian *panj* is the Iranian cousin of Indic *pañca*: both descend from the same Indo-Iranian and PIE number root.

The place-name is Persian, not Sanskrit, but the family resemblance is real.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Greek *pente* is another descendant of the same root. It appears in **pentagon**, a five-sided figure, and **pentathlon**, a five-event contest.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The usual account derives **punch**, the drink, from Hindi *pāñch* ← Sanskrit *pañca*, because the drink was said to contain five ingredients. That origin is not unanimous. A rival derives the word from **puncheon**, a type of cask. Keep the useful connection with a label: “the common five-ingredients account,” not an unquestioned fact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *panj* + *āb* — five waters
- Greek *pente* — pentagon, pentathlon
- *punch* — common account, not certain

Before you move on

What does *Punjab* mean? (“Five waters.”) Is Persian *panj* borrowed from Sanskrit? (No: it is an Iranian cousin.) Which Greek form hides in *pentagon*? (*Pente*.) What caution belongs with the drink *punch*? (The five-ingredients derivation is common, but *puncheon* is a rival account.)

Chapter 7

The Core Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (6) ✍ pen (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that someone is, becomes, goes, comes, eats, sees and knows in Sanskrit; I can name each verb by its dhātu rather than by its present form, say which of the three gaṇa patterns builds its stem, and point at the English word that descends from the same root.

Say जानाति, name its root ज्ञा and the syllable -ना- its class plants inside the word, run back through the chapter’s six verbs as root plus class plus ending, separate the one that is a prefixed form of another, and pair गम्, अद्, पश् and भू with come, eat, inspect and be.

7.1 अस्ति and भवति — Sanskrit’s two words for “is”

Six chapters of words. Now the machinery. A Sanskrit verb is never quoted the way an English one is, and this pair shows why.

You’ll want to know: अस्ति and भवति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
अस्ति	<i>asti</i>	he, she, or it is
भवति	<i>bhavati</i>	he, she, or it becomes

Both land in English as “is.” *Asti* states that something simply **is** there. *Bhavati* says something **comes to be** — a state arriving rather than sitting still. Sanskrit never merged the two.

The letters in this word

अ is *a*, a short neutral vowel; ति is *ti*. Inside अस्ति the *s* and *t* stack into one joined shape, स्ति — Devanagari fuses a consonant cluster into a single letter. भवति needs no fusing: भ *bha*, व *va*, ति *ti*.

Grammar Lens: the dhātu and its gaṇa

Sanskrit files a verb under its धातु (*dhātu*), its **root** — the bare syllable a dictionary lists. *Asti* is filed under अस् (*as*), *bhavati* under भू (*bhū*). A root is not yet a word. To reach the present it joins one of ten गण (*gaṇa*) classes, and the class decides what happens between root and ending. Class 2 adds nothing: *as* + *ti* → *asti*. Class 1 strengthens the root and adds a vowel: *bhū* → *bhava* + *ti* → *bhavati*. Root, then class, then ending. Every verb in this chapter is built that way.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अस् is PIE **es-*: English **is**, Latin *est*, German *ist*, barely worn. भू is PIE **bheu-*, “to grow, to come to be”: English **be** and **been**, Latin *futūrus* behind **future**, Greek *phusis* behind **physics**. Now the surprise. English “to be” is stitched from *both* — *am*, *is*, *are* from **es-*; *be*, *been*, *being* from **bheu-*. English fused two verbs into one ragged paradigm. Sanskrit left them side by side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “asti” — it is
- “bhavati” — it becomes
- the two roots — *as*, *bhū*
- the English halves — “is” from one, “been” from the other

Before you move on

Which two roots stand behind *asti* and *bhavati*? (अस् *as* and भू *bhū*.)
What does a गण class do? (**Turns a root into a present stem** —

nothing added for *as*, a vowel added for *bhū*.) Which English words descend from each? (*Is* from *as*; *be* and *been* from *bhū*.) Next: a root whose present stem you could never have guessed.

7.2 च — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ँ · अ · ञ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: च

च — *ca*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *c*, it is **ca**.

What it is made of:

- a short upper bar joined to a rounded body opening right
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has च somewhere inside it:

- पञ्च *pañca* — five inside Punjab, pentagon, and the debated history of punch

Writing: च

- 1. draw the short upper bar left-to-right, turn down and left through the shoulder, then curve around the rounded body to its open right junction without lifting
- 2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 3. lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the body differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-च-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find च in it

पञ्च

- *Trace it:* च three times, saying *ca* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find च once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — च? What sound does it carry? (*ca*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

7.3 गच्छति (gacchati) — “goes,” and why dictionaries file it elsewhere

Root, then class, then ending. Say the two roots from last time. (*As, bhū.*) Here the middle step stops being tidy.

You’ll want to know: गच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गच्छति	<i>gacchati</i>	he, she, or it goes
गच्छामि	<i>gacchāmi</i>	I go

The second form is already yours: Chapter 4 used it to take leave. Same stem, different ending — -ति *-ti* for “he, she, it,” -मि *-āmi* for “I.”

The letters in this word

ग is *ga*. ति is *ti*, already familiar. Between them sits च्छ, a doubled *ch* — one stacked shape for two *ch* sounds in a row, held slightly long: *gach-cha*. Let the middle of the word linger.

Grammar Lens: the stem that hides its root

The root here is गम् (*gam*), “to go.” The present stem is गच्छ (*gaccha*). No rule you have met turns one into the other, and no amount of staring at *gaccha* recovers *gam*.

That is the whole reason Sanskrit hangs its grammar on the root rather than on any spoken form. *Gam* is where the dictionary keeps this verb, where its past and future are built from, and where its relatives — गति *gati* “motion,” आगम *āgama* “arrival” — are visibly cousins. Learn roots, not forms.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

गम् is PIE **gwem-*. Its English descendant is **come** — the same root, turned around: what one language walks away with, another walks toward.

Latin took it as *venīre*, “to come,” and English then borrowed it back in a crowd: **venue**, **convene**, **intervene**, **advent**, **adventure**.

Sanskrit *gacchati* and English *come* are the two ends of one very old word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gacchati” — it goes
- “gacchāmi” — I go
- the root, not the stem — *gam*
- the English cousin — *come*

Before you move on

What is the root of *gacchati*? (गम् *gam*.) Could you have predicted the stem from it? (No — which is why the root is what gets

learned.) Which ending makes it “I go”? (-ामि -āmi.) Which English verb is the same root? (**Come**.) Next: the same stem, aimed the other way.

7.4 आगच्छति (āgacchati) — “comes,” or “goes” reversed

Say “it goes.” (*Gacchati*.) Now add one syllable in front and the direction reverses.

You’ll want to know: आगच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गच्छति	<i>gacchati</i>	it goes
आगच्छति	<i>āgacchati</i>	it comes

आ (*ā*) means “toward, hither.” Stick it on the front and the motion turns back to face you. Sanskrit has no separate word for “come” at all: coming is going, aimed homeward.

The letters in this word

Everything after the first letter is last lesson’s word, unchanged. The new piece is आ, the long *ā* — the same vowel as अ *a* but held roughly twice as long. Length alone carries meaning in Sanskrit, so give it its time: *aa-gach-cha-ti*.

Grammar Lens: the upasarga, Sanskrit’s aiming device

आ is an उपसर्ग (*upasarga*), a preverb. Sanskrit has about twenty, and any of them may ride in front of a root to re-aim it:

prefix	sense	on गम्
आ <i>ā</i>	toward	<i>āgacchati</i> , comes
सम् <i>sam</i>	together	<i>saṁgacchati</i> , goes together
नि <i>ni</i>	down	<i>nigacchati</i> , goes down

A handful of roots plus a handful of prefixes covers an enormous amount of vocabulary. You have met the trick already without being

told: संस्कृत (*samskr̥ta*, “Sanskrit”) is *sam* “together” on the root कृ *kr̥* “make” — put-together, and so perfected.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Latin aims *venīre* “come” with the same kind of prefix: *ad-* “toward” gives **advent**, *con-* “with” gives **convene**, *inter-* “between” gives **intervene**. English does it natively too — *come* becomes **become**, **overcome**, **income**.

Sanskrit simply runs the system harder and more openly, with the seams left visible.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gacchati ... āgacchati” — goes, comes
- the prefix and its sense — *ā*, toward
- one more prefix on the same root — *sam*, together

Before you move on

How does Sanskrit say “comes”? (आगच्छति — *ā* “toward” on “goes.”) What is such a prefix called? (An उपसर्ग, *upasarga*.) Which Sanskrit word you already knew is built the same way? (संस्कृत — *sam* plus *kr̥*.) Next: a verb whose everyday form is not the one related to English.

7.5 क — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: अ · ज · च. Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: क

क — *ka*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *k*, it is **ka**.

What it is made of:

- a counterclockwise left bowl
- a top-to-bottom central stem
- a separate right-hand arch
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has क somewhere inside it:

- किम् *kim* — what

Writing: क

- **1.** start at the bowl's upper-right junction and sweep left over the top, down around the left side, and back to the lower-right junction
- **2.** lift and draw the central stem top-to-bottom
- **3.** lift at the upper junction and sweep the right-hand arch clockwise down to its open lower tip
- **4.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified four-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the body differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-क-order.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 8 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find क in it

किम्

- *Trace it:* क three times, saying *ka* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find क once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — क? What sound does it carry? (*ka*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

7.6 खादति (khādati) — “eats,” and the cousin it is not

Name the three steps that build a Sanskrit present. (**Root, class, ending.**) This verb is the tidiest one yet — and hides a warning.

You’ll want to know: खादति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
खादति	<i>khādati</i>	he, she, or it eats
खाद्य	<i>khādyā</i>	edible , food

The root is खाद् (*khād*), and it belongs to the same class 1 as *bhū*, so the build is plain: *khād* + *a* + *ti* → *khādati*. No stacked letters, no surprises, nothing hidden.

The letters in this word

खा is *khā*: a *k* with a puff of breath after it, then the long *ā* you met last lesson. Sanskrit treats that puff as a separate letter, not an accent — क *ka* and ख *kha* are two different letters that change meaning. द is *da*, ति is *ti*.

Grammar Lens: the everyday word and the related word

English **eat**, Latin *edere* (behind **edible**), and German *essen* all descend from PIE **ed-*. Sanskrit inherited it too, as the root अद् (*ad*), class 2 — endings straight onto the root, like *asti*: *ad* + *ti* → अत्ति (*atti*), “eats.”

But *atti* is not the ordinary word. Classical Sanskrit eats with खाद्, a root with no clear European relative at all.

So the family word and the everyday word part company here.

Cognates tell you where a language came from; they do not promise to tell you what it says at dinner. Keep the two questions separate.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The pattern repeats across the family. English has native **eat** beside borrowed **consume** and **devour**; Sanskrit has inherited अद् beside ordinary खाद्.

A language keeps its old word somewhere — in a proverb, a compound, a sacred text — while daily speech moves on to another.

Khādya, “edible,” is the word you will actually meet on a menu.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*khādati*” — it eats
- the root and its class build — *khād ... a ... ti*
- the cousin of English *eat* — *ad*, *atti*

Before you move on

What is the ordinary Sanskrit verb for eating? (खादति, *khādati*, root अद्.) Which Sanskrit root is the actual cousin of English *eat*? (अद् *ad*, giving *atti*.) Which class does *ad* belong to, and how do you know? (**Class 2** — the ending goes straight onto the root, as in *asti*.) Next: a verb built out of two different roots.

7.7 पश्यति (paśyati) — “sees,” a verb with two roots

So far one root has built each verb. Here two roots share the work, and you have already met the quieter one.

You’ll want to know: पश्यति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
पश्यति	<i>paśyati</i>	he, she, or it sees
दर्शन	<i>darśana</i>	a beholding , a viewing

The present tense comes from the root पश् (paś). Every other tense of this verb comes from a different root, दृश् (dṛś) — and *dṛś* is where दर्शन was built, the word inside Chapter 4’s farewell पुनर्दर्शनाय, “until a seeing again.”

Two roots, one verb, divided by tense. English does the same with *go* and *went*, which were never the same verb either.

The letters in this word

प is *pa*. Then श्य, a stack of two letters: श *śa*, a *sh* made with the tongue high and forward, plus य *ya*. Say them glued: *pash-ya-ti*. Sanskrit has three different *s* letters, and this is the one that leans toward *sh*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पश् descends from PIE **spek-*, “to observe closely.” The *s* and the *p* swapped places on the way into Indo-Iranian, which is why the Sanskrit form begins *paś-* rather than *spaś-*.

Latin kept it straight as *specere*, and English is full of the results: **spectacle, inspect, respect, species, suspect, spy**.

Greek swapped the letters too, in its own direction, giving *skop-*: **telescope, microscope, skeptic, bishop** (from *episkopos*, an overseer).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “paśyati” — it sees

- the two roots — *paś* for the present, *dṛś* for the rest
- the Chapter 4 word from the other root — *darśana*
- the English descendants — *inspect*, *species*, *telescope*

Before you move on

Which root gives the present *paśyati*? (पश्य् *paś*.) Which root supplies the rest of the verb? (दृश् *dṛś* — the one behind *darśana*.) What PIE root is *paś* from? (**Spek-*.) Name two English words from it. (**Inspect**, **species**, **telescope** — any two.) Next: the verb that means “know,” and the class that plants a syllable in the middle.

7.8 ख — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ज · च · क.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ख

ख — *kha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *kh*, it is **kha**.

What it is made of:

- a descending left stem curling around a small loop and continuing through the broad lower bowl
- an open clockwise upper-right loop
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say this word, and ख is one of the shapes inside it — the rest of its shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *khādati* — he, she, or it eats — the everyday eat-verb, which is not the one English is related to

Writing: ख

- 1. descend the left stem, curl clockwise around the small left opening, then continue down and right around the broad lower bowl to the lower-right junction without lifting
- 2. lift at the upper-left of the right opening and sweep clockwise around its oval to the open lower-left tip
- 3. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 4. lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified four-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ख-order.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 9 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ख in it

ख

- *Trace it:* ख three times, saying *kha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ख once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ख? What sound does it carry? (*kha*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

7.9 जानाति (jānāti) — “knows,” and English *know* is the same word

Two ways a root has become a stem so far: nothing added, or a vowel added. Here is the third, and it is the boldest.

You’ll want to know: जानाति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
जानाति	<i>jānāti</i>	he, she, or it knows
ज्ञान	<i>jñāna</i>	knowledge

The root is ज्ञा (*jñā*). Its class, the ninth, does not add a vowel at the end — it plants a whole syllable -ना- (-*nā*-) between root and ending: *jā* + *nā* + *ti* → *jānāti*. The marker sits inside the word.

The letters in this word

जा is *jā*; ना *nā* and ति *ti* close it. The root’s own spelling ज्ञ is a famous stacked letter, *j* over *ñ*, said *gya* across much of India today and *jñā* in the classical description. Pick one and stay with it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ज्ञा is PIE **gno*-. English **know** is that root undisguised, and so are **can** and **cunning**, which began as “know how.”

Latin took it as *noscere*: **notice**, **notion**, **cognition**, **ignore** (“not-know”), **noble** (“well-known”). Greek took it as *gnōsis*: **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, **agnostic**.

One root, a whole shelf of English vocabulary, and Sanskrit ज्ञान *jñāna* sitting at the other end of it.

What you’ve built: six verbs, three ways to build a stem

Asti, *bhavati*, *gacchati*, *āgacchati*, *khādati*, *paśyati*, *jānāti*. Every one is a root plus a class plus an ending, and the class was the only thing that varied: nothing inserted (*as-ti*), a vowel appended (*bhava-ti*, *khāda-ti*), or a syllable planted inside (*jā-nā-ti*). Prefix one and you aim it: *ā-gacchati*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jānāti” — it knows
- the root and its planted syllable — *jñā ... nā*
- the English twin — *know*
- three roots and their English kin — *gam*/come, *ad*/eat, *paś*/inspect

Before you move on

What is the root of *jānāti*, and what does its class insert? (ज्ञा *jñā*; the syllable -ना-.) Give the six verbs of this chapter. (*Asti*, *gacchati*, *āgacchati*, *khādati*, *paśyati*, *jānāti*.) Which two are one root plus a prefix? (गच्छति and आगच्छति.) Which Sanskrit root is English *know*? (ज्ञा.) And which English words carry *gam*, *ad*, *paś*, and *bhū*? (*Come*, *eat*, *inspect*, *be* — four roots you now own in two languages.)

Chapter 8

The Mind and the Palm Leaf

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that someone thinks, understands, reads and writes in Sanskrit; I can name the class that plants -अय- inside a verb, build “understands” out of a prefix and a verb I already had, say what लिख् meant before it meant write, and tell a word worn down by speech (तद्भव) from one carried over whole (तत्सम).

Say लिखति, give the scratching sense its root carried first, run the chapter’s four verbs back as root plus class plus ending — the planted -अय- of चिन्तयति, the अव- prefix and the waking बुध् behind understanding, the plain -a- of पठति and लिखति — sort Bengali lekhā and Hindi cintā into तद्भव and तत्सम, and name the two word-histories that needed a label rather than a claim.

8.1 चिन्तयति (cintayati) — “thinks,” and a root that never reached English

Say “it knows.” (*Jānāti*, root ज्ञा — the root English *know* is made of.) Here is what you do *before* you know.

You’ll want to know: चिन्तयति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
चिन्तयति	<i>cintayati</i>	he, she, or it thinks
चिन्ता	<i>cintā</i>	a thought , a worry

The root is चिन्त् (*cint*), “to think, to turn over.” Chapter 3 already handed you the noun: न चिन्ता (*na cintā*), “no worry,” is this root saying “think nothing of it.”

The letters in this word

चि is *ci*, said *chi* as in *chip*. Then न्त, न *na* stacked with त *ta* and said as one *nt*. य is *ya*, ति is *ti*: *chin-ta-ya-ti*.

Grammar Lens: the tenth class plants अय

Three ways a गण class has turned a root into a present stem: add nothing (*as-ti*), add a vowel (*bhava-ti*), plant a syllable inside (*jā-nā-ti*). Here is the fourth.

The **tenth** class inserts -अय- (*-aya-*) between root and ending: *cint* + *aya* + *ti* → चिन्तयति. The marker is loud and always in the same position, so -*aya-* names its class on hearing.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

चिन्त् goes back to PIE **kweyt-*, “to notice” — and its च *c-* is the rounded *k* from the numbers, which Indo-Iranian merged with plain *k* and then palatalised before a front vowel.

Where it went next is the surprise. Baltic and Slavic took “notice” to “count” and then to **read**: Russian *čitat* and Lithuanian *skaityti* both mean “to read.” Sanskrit made the same root mean *think*.

And English? Nothing descends from **kweyt-*. The trail west runs out, and saying so beats inventing a cousin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “cintayati” — it thinks
- the root and its planted syllable — *cint* ... *aya*
- the Chapter 3 phrase built on the same root — *na cintā*

Before you move on

What does class 10 put between root and ending, and what is *cintayati*'s root? (-अय-; चिन्त्, the root of *na cintā*.) Why does the word begin with *c* and not *k*? (**A rounded PIE *k*, merged and then palatalised** — the numbers' rule.) Which verb of knowing came just before this one, and does *cint* have an English cousin? (जानाति; **no** — this root left English nothing.)

8.2 े — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: च · क · ख. Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: े

े — *e*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a stroke above the top bar.

Worked through: न + े = ने — *ne*.

You already say this word, and े is one of the shapes inside it — the rest of its shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *namaste* — hello (lit. “a bow to you”)

Writing: े — copy what you see

Put your pen on े and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here

until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find े in it
- *Trace it:* े three times, saying *e* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find े once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — े? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *e* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

8.3 अवगच्छति (avagacchati) — “understands,” going down into it

Say “it goes,” then “it comes.” (*Gacchati*, *āgacchati* — one उपसर्ग prefix apart.) And say “it thinks.” (*Cintayati*.) One more prefix, and thinking turns into understanding.

You’ll want to know: अवगच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गच्छति	<i>gacchati</i>	it goes
अवगच्छति	<i>avagacchati</i>	it understands

अव (*ava*) means “down.” Put it on “goes” and you get “goes down into” — and that is Sanskrit’s ordinary verb for understanding. No new root, no new stem: one more preverb on a word you already own.

Sanskrit has a second verb for it too, बुध्यते (*budhyate*), “wakes, comes to realise.” Its ending -ते *-te* belongs to Sanskrit’s second set of endings, used

when the action loops back on the doer — waking is something you do to yourself.

The letters in this word

Everything after two syllables is last chapter’s word. The new opening is अ *a* plus व *va*: *a-va-gach-cha-ti*. In बुध्यते the middle is ध्य, a stack of ध *dha* and य *ya*, said glued: *bu-dhya-te*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

गम्, under *avagacchati*, is still PIE **gwem-*, the root of English **come** and Latin *venire* behind **advent**.

बुध् is PIE **bheudh-*, “to be awake, to be aware.” Its most famous derivative is बुद्ध (*buddha*), “the awakened one” — a title, not a name. Greek made it *punthanomai*, “to learn by asking”; Russian *budit* still means “to wake.”

English got it too, worn thin: **forbid** and **bode** (as in *foreboding*) descend from Old English *bēodan*, “to announce, to offer.” Modern *bid* mixes that verb with a second, unrelated one — so keep to *forbid* and *bode* if you want the clean cousin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “gacchati ... avagacchati” — goes, understands
- the prefix and its sense — *ava*, down
- the other verb and its root — *budhyate*, *budh*
- what बुद्ध means — the awakened one

Before you move on

Build “understands” out of pieces you already had. (अव “down” + गच्छति “goes”.) Name the three verbs that share that one stem. (*Gacchati*, *āgacchati*, *avagacchati*.) What does बुध् mean before it means “understand,” and what title comes from it? (**To wake**; बुद्ध, the awakened one.) Which two English words are its clean cousins? (**Forbid** and **bode**.)

8.4 पठति (paṭhati) — “reads,” and where the word went afterwards

Say “it thinks” and “it understands.” (*Cintayati, avagacchati.*)
This next verb is the plainest build in the chapter and the richest afterlife.

You’ll want to know: पठति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
पठति	<i>paṭhati</i>	he, she, or it reads
पाठ	<i>pāṭha</i>	a lesson , a recitation

The root is पठ् (*paṭh*), class 1 — root, vowel, ending, exactly like *bhavati*. Its first meaning is not “read” but “**recite aloud, rehearse, study**”: reading was a thing done with the mouth, and Sanskrit named it that way.

The letters in this word

प is *pa*. ठ is *ṭha*, a *t* made with the tongue curled back to the roof of the mouth *and* a puff of breath after it. ति is *ti*, tongue forward. Hear the two *t*-sounds apart: *pa-ṭha-ti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

This is the verb four living languages still read with — Hindi and Urdu *paṛhnā*, Bengali *poṛa*, Marathi *paḍhṇe*. The change is regular: that curled-back ठ softens between vowels, and the old ending drops off. A word reshaped by centuries of ordinary speech is तद्भव (*tadbhava*), “become from that.”

Now set चिन्ता beside it. It sits in Hindi, Marathi and Bengali **unchanged** — lifted back out of Sanskrit by scholars rather than inherited through speech. That kind is तत्सम (*tatsama*), “the same as that.” Every claim about a Sanskrit word’s descendants is one of those two, and they are not the same claim.

Grammar Lens: where पठति itself came from

The usual account runs back through प्रथ् (*prath*), “to spread, to become widely known” — reciting as broadcasting — and behind that a root that also gives पृथिवी (*prthivī*), “the earth, the wide one.”

Some hold instead that *paṭhati* is a later, spoken form that scholars dressed up as Sanskrit. Keep the label on it, exactly as you did with *punch*: a common account, not a settled one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “paṭhati” — it reads, it recites
- a worn-down grandchild — *paṛhnā*
- a word carried whole — *cintā*

Before you move on

What did *paṭhati* mean before “read,” and which class builds it? (**Recite aloud; class 1.**) Name the two ways a Sanskrit word reaches a modern language. (तद्भव, worn down through speech; तत्सम, carried over whole.) Which is *paṛhnā*, which is *cintā*, and what label belongs on *paṭhati*’s own ancestry? (*Tadbhava*; *tatsama*; **a common account, not settled** — the caution you kept on *punch*.)

8.5 व — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: क · ख ·
े. Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: व

व — *va*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *v*, it is **va**.

What it is made of:

- a counterclockwise left loop

- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has व somewhere inside it:

- वदामि *vadāmi* — I speak

Writing: व

- **1.** start at the upper-right of the body, travel left around the top, and continue counterclockwise around the loop to the right-side junction
- **2.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: JackPotte, ‘Devanagari v व.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 29 March 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find व in it

वदामि

- *Trace it:* व three times, saying *va* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find व once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — व? What sound does it carry? (*va.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

8.6 लिखति (likhati) — “writes,” and the scratch it started as

Say “it reads.” (*Paṭhati.*) Name a language that still reads with that word. (Hindi *paṛhnā*, Bengali *poṛa*, Marathi *paḍhṇe* — any one.) Now the other half of literacy.

You’ll want to know: लिखति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
लिखति	<i>likhati</i>	he, she, or it writes
लेखनी	<i>lekhanī</i>	a pen

The root is लिख् (*likh*), class 6. Class 6 adds the same *-a-* class 1 does but leaves the root untouched: *likh* + *a* + *ti*. Two classes, one vowel, and the difference is only whether the root gets strengthened first.

The letters in this word

लि is *li*. ख is *kha*, a *k* with a puff of breath after it — the letter that opens *khādati*. ति is *ti*: *li-kha-ti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

लिख् does not mean “write” first. It means **to scratch, to scrape, to furrow**, and “write” second — because writing *was* scratching, into palm leaf and birch bark with a stylus. The older sense stays visible in रेखा (*rekhā*), “a line, a scratch,” the same root wearing an *r*. Outside Sanskrit the trail is thin but real: Greek *ereikō*, “to tear,” and Lithuanian *riekti*, “to slice.” No everyday English word descends from it — that is two roots in this chapter that left English nothing. Eastward, a different story: Hindi and Urdu *likhnā*, Bengali *lekhā*, Marathi *lihṇe* — worn down, *tadbhava*, with Marathi’s *kh* softened to *h*.

What you’ve built: four verbs, four ways to build a stem

Cintayati, *avagacchati*, *paṭhati*, *likhati*. Thinking plants -अय-; understanding is “goes” with अव in front, or बुध्यते, waking; reading and writing take a plain *-a-*, class 1 and class 6.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “likhati” — it writes
- what the root meant first — to scratch
- the chapter’s four — *cintayati*, *avagacchati*, *paṭhati*, *likhati*

Before you move on

What did लिख् mean before “write,” and what are the chapter’s four verbs? (**To scratch**; *cintayati*, *avagacchati*, *paṭhati*, *likhati*.) Which plants -अय-, and which is a prefix on a verb you already had? (*Cintayati*; *avagacchati*.) Which verb of understanding means “wakes,” and what title comes from its root? (बुध्यते; बुद्ध.) Is Bengali *lekhā* tatsama or tadbhava, and which two word-histories here needed a label rather than a claim? (**Tadbhava**; *paṭhati*’s ancestry and *likh*’s English kin — the *punch* caution, twice.)

Chapter 9

Taking, Asking, Helping, Loving

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) ✍️ pen (2) 🖐️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that someone takes, asks, helps and loves in Sanskrit; I can say संस्कृतं मम प्रियम्, build a verb by putting करोति behind a noun, and point at the English word — grab, pray, friend — that each of these four roots also produced.

Say संस्कृतं मम प्रियम्, give स्निह् its older sense of stickiness and label the disputed snow connection, follow प्रिय west into friend, free and Friday by the p-to-f change that also made pañca into five, run the chapter’s four verbs back with grab, pray and comes beside them, and sort प्रिय against Hindi piyā as तत्सम against तद्भव — then place पञ्च beside प्रिय as the other word that travelled in both directions at once.

9.1 गृह्णाति (grhṇāti) — “takes,” and English *grab*

Say “it writes,” and what its root meant first. (*Likhati*; to scratch.) Now say “it knows” and name the syllable its class plants inside the word. (*Jānāti*; -ना-.) That syllable is back.

You’ll want to know: गृह्णाति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
गृह्णाति	grhṇāti	he, she, or it takes , seizes
ग्रहण	grahaṇa	a seizing ; an eclipse

The root is ग्रह् (*grah*), class 9 — *jānāti*'s class. It plants the same syllable, and the syllable comes out -णा- rather than -ना-: a curled-back ऋ earlier in the word pulls the following *n* back to match it. Sanskrit tidies its consonants after the fact.

The letters in this word

गृ is *gr̥*: the vowel ऋ is a vowel made of *r* itself, a short buzz between *ri* and *ru* — the same vowel inside संस्कृत. Then ह्रा, *h* and curled-back ण fused with a long *ā*: *gr̥h-ṇā-ti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ग्रह् is PIE **ghrebh-*, “to seize.” The oldest Sanskrit still writes it गृह्णाति (*gr̥bhṇāti*), with the *bh* the reconstruction predicts. English kept the same root in **grab**, **grip** and **grasp**.

Say what that means carefully, though. Sanskrit built its verb with the class-9 syllable; English built its words with other endings entirely.

They are the same root wearing different suffixes — **relatives, not the same word**, exactly the caution you put on *eka* beside *one*.

Inside Sanskrit the root spreads out: ग्रह (*graha*) is a **planet**, named as the *seizer* that takes hold of a life. Eastward it wore down to Marathi घेणे (*gheṇe*), the ordinary verb for taking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*gr̥hṇāti*” — it takes
- the root and its planted syllable — *grah ... ṇā*
- the English kin — *grab, grip, grasp*
- the worn-down Marathi grandchild — *gheṇe*

Before you move on

Which class builds *gr̥hṇāti*, and which earlier verb shares it? (**Class 9; जानाति.**) Why -णा- and not -ना-? (**The curled-back ऋ pulls the *n* back to match.**) Name three English words from the same root. (**Grab, grip, grasp.**) Are they the same word as *gr̥hṇāti* or

relatives of it? (**Relatives** — same root, different suffixes, like *eka* and *one*.) Is Marathi *gheṇe* tatsama or tadbhava? (**Tadbhava**.)

9.2 त — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ख · े · व.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: त

त — *ta*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *t*, it is **ta**.

What it is made of:

- a right-to-left upper shoulder curving down to an open lower tip
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has त somewhere inside it:

- भवान् / त्वम् *bhavān / tvam* — you
- तव नाम किम्? *tava nāma kim?* — what's your name?
- न चिन्ता *na cintā* — no worry / it's nothing / you're welcome
- खादति *khādati* — he, she, or it eats — the everyday eat-verb, which is not the one English is related to

Writing: त

1. start at the body's upper-right junction, sweep left across the shoulder, then curve down around the left side and finish down-right at the open lower tip without lifting

- **2.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the body differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-त-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find त in it
भवान् / त्वम् · तव नाम किम्? · न चिन्ता
- *Trace it:* त three times, saying *ta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find त once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — त? What sound does it carry? (*ta*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

9.3 पृच्छति (pr̥cchati) — “asks,” and the prayer at the other end of it

Say “it takes” and its English kin. (*Gṛhṇāti*; **grab**.) Say “it goes.” (*Gacchati*.) Listen to the middle of that one — it comes back here.

You’ll want to know: पृच्छति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
पृच्छति	<i>pr̥cchati</i>	he, she, or it asks
प्रश्न	<i>praśna</i>	a question

The root is प्रच्छ् (*prach*), class 6 — *likhati*’s class, a plain *-a-* on an untouched root. The root’s *r* turns into the vowel ऋ, and the ending fuses into the doubled च्छ you already met in *gacchati*.

The letters in this word

पृ is *pr*, the *r*-vowel again. च्छ is the stack of two *ch* sounds held slightly long, exactly as in *gacchati*. ति closes it: *prch-cha-ti*. Let the middle linger.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

प्रच्छ् is PIE **prek-*, “to ask,” and it is one of the best-travelled roots in the family.

Latin took it as *precārī*, “to ask, to entreat” — and from that English has **pray**, **prayer**, **deprecate**, and **precarious**, which meant “held only by asking, at someone else’s pleasure.”

Germanic took the same root and turned its initial *p* into *f* by **Grimm’s law** — the very change that made *pañca* into **five**. That is why German asks with **fragen**. Persian asks with *porsidan* and Russian with *prosit*, both the same word again.

Eastward it wore down: Hindi and Urdu पूछना (*pūchnā*), Marathi पुसणे (*pusṇe*) — *tadbhava*, with the *r*-vowel flattened to *u*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*prcchati*” — it asks
- the root — *prach*
- the Latin descendant and its English children — *precārī*, *pray*
- the German cousin with *f* — *fragen*

Before you move on

Which class builds *prcchati*, and which verb shares its doubled middle? (**Class 6**; गच्छति.) What did Latin *precārī* mean, and name two English words from it. (**To entreat**; **pray**, **precarious**.) Why does German say *fragen* with an *f*? (**Grimm’s law** turned initial *p* into *f* — as in *pañca* and *five*.) And is Hindi *pūchnā* tatsama or

tadbhava? (Tadbhava.)

9.4 साहाय्यं करोति (sāhāyyaṃ karoti) — “helps,” or going along with

Say “it asks” and “it takes.” (*Pr̥cchati*, *gr̥hṇāti*.) Helping is not built like either of them. It takes two words.

You’ll want to know: साहाय्यं करोति

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
साहाय्यम्	<i>sāhāyyaṃ</i>	help , assistance
साहाय्यं करोति	<i>sāhāyyaṃ karoti</i>	he, she, or it helps

करोति (*karoti*) is “does, makes” — the root कृ (*kr*), class 8, yours since Chapter 5 as करोमि (*karomi*), “I do.” Same stem, familiar swap of ending: -ति for “he, she, it,” -मि for “I.”

So Sanskrit has no verb “to help.” It has a noun for help and puts “does” behind it — a machine you can run on almost any noun.

The letters in this word

सा *sā*, हा *hā*, then य्य, य *ya* stacked on itself and held double. The final म् *m* softens to a hum before the next word, so it is written -ः: *sāhāyyaṃ karoti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

साहाय्य is built on सहाय (*sahāya*), “a companion” — सह (*saha*), “with,” plus आय, from the root इ (*i*), “to go.” A helper is *one who goes along with you*. Sanskrit leaves such seams showing, the way संस्कृत is *saṃskṛta* “together” on कृ.

Latin names a companion by the same picture: *comes* is *com-* “with” on *ire* “to go,” the root behind **exit** and **transit**.

Bengali still helps with this very word, unchanged: *sāhājjo korā*, a *tatsama* carrying the whole Sanskrit noun plus its own “do.” Hindi and Marathi instead say *madad karnā* and *madat karṇe* — same machine, but with an **Arabic** word that reached them through Persian. Not everything modern comes from Sanskrit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sāhāyyam karoti” — it helps
- “karomi ... karoti” — I do, it does
- the two pieces of *sahāya* — *saha* “with,” *āya* “going”

Before you move on

How does Sanskrit say “helps”? (साहाय्यं करोति — a noun plus “does”.) What are the two pieces inside *sahāya*, and which Latin word for a companion is built the same way? (सह “with” + आय “going”; *comes*.) Which language still helps with this exact Sanskrit noun, and which two borrowed an Arabic one instead? (Bengali; Hindi and Marathi, with *madad*.)

9.5 ः — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: े · व · त.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ः

ः — *ṃ* (*nasal*).

It is a **nasal mark**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it sits on a syllable and sends its sound through the nose.

Where it sits: an anusvāra dot above the top bar, nasalizing the syllable.

Worked through: न + ः = नं — *naṃ*.

You already say these words, and ः is one of the shapes inside them — the rest of their shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *aham samiskṛtani vadāmi* — I speak Sanskrit
- *sāhāyyam karoti* — he, she, or it helps — a noun plus “does,” and help named as going along with someone

Writing: ँ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ँ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ँ in it

ॐ

- *Trace it:* ँ three times, saying *ṇ* (*nasal*) as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ँ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ँ? Where does it send the sound? (**Through the nose.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

9.6 स्निह्यति and प्रियम् — loving, and the word inside *friend*

Say “it helps,” “it asks,” “it takes.” (*Sāhāyyam karoti, prcchati, gṛhṇāti.*) One feeling left, named after something physical.

You’ll want to know: स्निह्यति and प्रियम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
स्निह्यति	<i>snihyati</i>	he, she, or it feels affection
मम प्रियम्	<i>mama priyam</i>	dear to me

स्निह् (*sniḥ*) means, first, **to be sticky, oily, moist**, and only then “to feel fond of.” The noun स्नेह (*sneha*) is still both: *oil* and *affection*.

For everyday liking Sanskrit reaches instead for प्रिय (*priya*), “dear.” With मम (*mama*), yours since Chapter 2: संस्कृतं मम प्रियम्, “Sanskrit is dear to me.”

The letters in this word

स्नि stacks स *sa* on न *na* over the vowel *i* — one push, *sni*, not *si-ni*. Then ह्य, *h* and *y* fused: *sniḥ-ya-ti*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

प्रिय is PIE **priHos*, “dear, beloved.” Germanic turned that *p* into *f* by Grimm’s law — the third time you have watched it happen: **friend** is “the loving one,” **free** meant “beloved of the household” before “not a slave,” and **Friday** is the day of *Frigg*, whose name is the same word. Eastward it took both roads at once: प्रिय sits unchanged in Hindi, Marathi and Bengali, a *tatsama*; worn down it is Hindi पिया (*piyā*), “beloved,” a *tadbhava*.

स्निह् is the opposite case. It may belong with the root behind **snow** — snow being what sticks — but that is argued, so keep it labelled.

What you’ve built: four verbs, and a taproot

Gṛhṇāti, *pr̥cchati*, *sāhāyāni karoti*, *snihyati* — seizing, asking, going along with, sticking. Four physical pictures, each reaching west (*grab*, *pray*, *comes*, *friend*) and east into living speech.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “saṁskṛtaṁ mama priyam” — Sanskrit is dear to me
- स्नेह, twice over — oil, and affection
- *friend*, *free*, *Friday* — all from *priya*

Before you move on

Give this chapter’s four, and what स्निह् meant before “love.” (*Gṛhṇāti*, *pr̥cchati*, *sāhāyāni karoti*, *snihyati*; **sticky, oily**.) Three

English words from प्रिय, and what turned its *p* into *f*? (**F**riend, **f**ree, **F**riday; **G**rimm's law, as in *fragen* and *five*.) Which English number's *f* is **not** that law? (**F**our, copying *five*.) Which earlier word travelled both ways as *priya* does, and is *piyā* tatsama or tadbhava? (पञ्च — east to *panj* and **P**unjab, “five waters,” west to Greek *pente*; *piyā* is tadbhava.)

Chapter 10

What You’d Ask For

Modes: 👁 eyes (3) ✍ pen (2) 🗑 Hands-free start: first 1 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water, milk and food in Sanskrit, say that food is grammatically the eaten thing, and name the three genders every Sanskrit noun carries.

Say अन्नम्, name the root अद् it shares with खादति’s cousin अत्ति, and state the three grammatical genders Sanskrit sorts every noun into, tying the neuter -म् running through the chapter back to the neuter numeral forms of Chapter 6.

10.1 पानीयम् (pānīyam) — “water,” the thing to be drunk

Say “Sanskrit is dear to me.” (*Saniskṛtani mama priyam.*) Every word so far has named an action. Now for the nouns you would actually reach for — starting with the one you would ask for first.

You’ll want to know: पानीयम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
पानीयम्	<i>pānīyam</i>	water
पिबति	<i>pibati</i>	he, she, or it drinks

पानीयम् is neuter, and its final -म् marks that — a whole family of everyday nouns ends this way, and it will keep coming back this chapter.

The letters in this word

पा is *pā*, the long-*ā* you have said since नाम. नी stacks न *na* under the long-*i* sign ी. यम् closes it: *y*, the inherent *a*, then म् with its vowel stripped by the *halant* — *pā-nī-ya-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पानीयम् is built on the root पा (*pā*), “to drink,” plus -अनीय (*-anīya*), a suffix meaning “fit to be ~ed.” Literally: **the thing that is to be drunk**.

The root is PIE **peh3-**, “to drink.” Latin took it into *potare*, and from that English has **potion** and **poison** — a drink, and a drink gone wrong.

Eastward, पानीयम् wore down through Prakrit *pāṇīya* into the everyday water-word of the daughter languages: Hindi पानी (*pānī*), Gujarati *pāṇī*, and, in the Bangladesh register of Bengali, *pani* — every one तद्भव, worn down by ordinary speech, not carried over whole. Sanskrit’s own oldest water-words, जल and उदक, took a different road entirely; this is not that word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pānīyam” — water
- the root and its suffix — *pā* “drink” plus *-anīya* “fit to be”
- the worn-down grandchildren — *pānī*, *pāṇī*, *pani*

Before you move on

What does पानीयम् literally mean, and from which two pieces? (“**The thing to be drunk**” — *pā* “drink” plus *-anīya* “fit to be”.) Name two English words from the same PIE root. (**Potion, poison.**) Is Hindi *pānī* तत्सम or तद्भव? (तद्भव.) And how did you say “dear to me” last chapter? (*Priyam.*)

10.2 स — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: व · त · ं.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: स

स — *sa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *s*, it is **sa**.

What it is made of:

- a descending left stem curling through the central hook and diagonal tail
- a left-to-right middle crossbar
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has स somewhere inside it:

- नमस्ते *namaste* — hello (lit. “a bow to you”)
- नमस्कारः *namaskārah* — hello (lit. “the making of a bow”)
- अस्ति *asti* — is
- मम नाम ... अस्ति *mama nāma ... asti* — my name is...

Writing: स

- **1.** start just below the headline, descend the left stem, curve left around the central hook, and continue diagonally down-right through the tail without lifting
- **2.** lift at the central junction and draw the middle crossbar left-to-right

- **3.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **4.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified four-stroke teaching form; the corroborating deskbook stages the left curve and diagonal tail separately

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: JackPotte, ‘Devanagari s स.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 29 March 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find स in it
नमस्ते · नमस्कारः · अस्ति
- *Trace it:* स three times, saying *sa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find स once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — स? What sound does it carry? (*sa.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

10.3 क्षीरम् (kṣīram) — “milk,” and the dessert it left behind

Say “water,” and the root it is built on. (*Pānīyam*; पा, “to drink.”) Not every drink-word in Sanskrit has so tidy an answer.

You’ll want to know: क्षीरम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
क्षीरम्	<i>kṣīram</i>	milk
क्षीर	<i>kṣīra</i>	milk — the bare stem, still living inside Hindi <i>khūr</i>

Neuter again, marked by the same -म् as पानीयम्.

The letters in this word

क्ष is a new stacked pair: क *k* fused under ष, the hissed retroflex *s* — together they say *kṣa*, one push, not two. Then the long-ī sign ी, र *ra*, and the neuter म् you already know: *kṣī-ra-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Where पानीयम्'s history is settled, क्षीरम्'s is not. One account traces it to an old Proto-Indo-European word for milk; another argues it was borrowed from a substrate language spoken where Indo-Iranian speakers first arrived in the region. Neither side has won.

What is clear is the family it sits in: Avestan **xšruidi-** and Persian *šir* say roughly the same word, but as **relatives**, not children — all three come down from one shared Proto-Indo-Iranian ancestor, the way *gr̥h̥nāti* and English *grab* are cousins rather than the same word wearing different clothes.

The word's liveliest descendant is not a drink. Hindi खीर (*khīr*) is a sweet rice pudding cooked in milk — worn down, तद्भव — and English borrowed that dessert whole, as **kheer**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kṣīram” — milk
- the two disputed accounts — an old root, or a borrowed one
- the dessert it became — *khīr*, borrowed into English as *kheer*

Before you move on

Is क्षीरम्'s own origin settled or disputed? (**Disputed** — inherited, or borrowed from a substrate.) Are Persian *šir* and Sanskrit *kṣīram* parent and child, or relatives? (**Relatives**, from one shared ancestor.) What English word for a dessert comes from Hindi *khīr*? (**Kheer**.) And what does *pānīyam* literally mean? (“**The thing to be drunk.**”)

10.4 अन्नम् (annam) — “food,” the eaten thing

Say “milk” and “water.” (*Kṣīram, pānīyam.*) One more thing you would ask for, and this one carries a root you already own.

You’ll want to know: अन्नम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
अन्नम्	<i>annam</i>	food, grain
खाद्यम् अन्नम्	<i>khādyam annam</i>	edible food — खादति’s own adjective on it

Neuter, and -म् again — the third noun running.

The letters in this word

अ opens bare, no consonant to carry it. न्न doubles न *na* onto itself, held a beat longer than one *n* would be. म् closes it, the same stripped-vowel neuter ending: *an-na-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Chapter 7 taught खादति, the everyday word for eating, and set beside it its untaken cousin: अद्, PIE *ed-*, the very root of English *eat*, which Sanskrit keeps alive as अत्ति.

अन्नम् is built on that same अद्, plus the old participle suffix -न — “eaten.” The *d* and the *n* fuse into the doubled न्न you just sounded out. Food, named this way, is not a thing but an **event**: the thing that has been eaten.

Grammar Lens: three genders, one small system

Every noun in this chapter has ended in -म्, and that is not coincidence: Sanskrit sorts every noun into one of **three genders** — masculine, feminine, and neuter — the same system that put a gendered form on the numerals back in Chapter 6, where the daughter languages inherited specifically the **neuter** forms, *trīṇi* and *catvāri*. This book teaches only the plain nominative singular of each noun, never the full run of cases and numbers behind it — but the gender is worth carrying, because it is not optional, and it is not guessable from meaning alone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “annam” — food
- the root and its participle — *ad* “eat” plus *-na* “eaten”
- the three genders — masculine, feminine, neuter

Before you move on

What does *annam* literally mean, and which root is it built on? (“**Eaten**”; अद्, the cousin of English *eat*.) Which everyday verb shares that root without being it? (*Khādati*.) Which gender have all three nouns this chapter shared? (**Neuter**, marked by -म्.) And which gendered form did the numerals hand the daughter languages back in Chapter 6? (**The neuter one** — *trīṇi*, *catvāri*.) Name this chapter’s three words. (*Pānīyam*, *kṣīram*, *annam* — the things you would ask for.)

10.5 ी — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: त · ं · स.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ी

ी — ī.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a curl to the right with a tail over the top bar.

Worked through: न + ी = नी — *nī*.

You already say these, and every one of them has ी somewhere inside it:

- पानीयम् *pānīyam* — water — “the thing to be drunk,” and the exact word your neighbors’ पानी grew from

Writing: ी — copy what you see

Put your pen on ी and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ी in it

पानीयम्

- *Trace it:* ी three times, saying ī as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ी once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ी? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts ī on; takes the built-in a off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 11

The People You'd Introduce

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ✍ pen (2) 🗣 Hands-free start: first 2 of 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a friend, a family, a brother and a sister in Sanskrit, and say which of those words travelled with English and which quietly did not.

Say भगिनी, name the share-word भग it is built on, name स्वस् as the real but non-living PIE cousin of English sister, and run the chapter's four people back together with the roads each one travelled.

11.1 मित्रम् (mitram) — “friend,” and the god of the given word

Say “food,” and its gender. (*Annam*; **neuter**.) The last three words named things you would ask for. This one names someone you would introduce.

You'll want to know: मित्रम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
मित्रम्	<i>mitram</i>	friend
मित्रम् मम	<i>mitram mama</i>	my friend

The letters in this word

मि is *mi*, a short vowel sign under म. त्र stacks त *ta* under र *ra*, said as one push, *tra*. म् closes it, neuter again: *mi-tra-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मित्रम् comes from Proto-Indo-Iranian ***mitras**, “that which causes binding” — a promise, a pact, a bond between two people. The same word names **Mithra**, the Avestan and Zoroastrian god of covenant and contract: a friendship, at the root, is a kind of oath. It travelled east with almost no change at all: Hindi and Marathi मित्र, Gujarati *mitra*, all तत्सम, lifted straight out of Sanskrit rather than worn down the way पानीयम् became *pānī*.

Grammar Lens: a person, grammatically neuter

Here is the proof that gender is not about meaning. मित्रम् names a person, and Sanskrit still marks it **neuter** — the same -म् you have now seen on water, milk, and food. A noun’s gender is a fact about the *word*, inherited with its shape, not a fact about who or what it points to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mitram” — friend
- the god it shares a name with — *Mithra*
- three languages that kept it whole — Hindi, Marathi, Gujarati

Before you move on

What does the root behind मित्रम् mean, and what god shares it? (“**To bind**”; **Mithra**, the covenant god.) Is मित्र in Hindi तत्सम or तद्भव? (तत्सम.) What gender is *mitram*, and why is that surprising? (**Neuter** — it names a person, but gender tracks the word’s class, not the person.)

11.2 कुटुम्बम् (kuṭumbam) — “family,” a word that made a round trip

Say “friend,” and its gender. (*Mitram*; **neuter**.) One person’s name, now the group everyone belongs to.

You'll want to know: कुटुम्बम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
कुटुम्बम्	<i>kuṭumbam</i>	family , household
मम कुटुम्बम्	<i>mama kuṭumbam</i>	my family

The letters in this word

कु is *ku*, a short-*u* sign under क. टु repeats it under the curled-back ट, the retroflex *t* you first met in संस्कृत's neighbours. म्ब stacks ब *ba* under a silent म्, and a final म् closes it: *ku-ṭu-mba-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Every etymology so far in this chapter has run from Sanskrit outward. This one runs the other way first. कुटुम्बम् is a loanword **into** Sanskrit from a Dravidian language, compared to Tamil **kuṭimai**, “family, lineage, allegiance,” itself built on **kuṭi**, “a hut, a settlement.” A family, on this account, is literally *those who share one roof*. From Sanskrit the finished word travelled onward as a formal, learned तत्सम — Hindi कुटुंब and Bengali *kuṭumbo* — and then made a full circle: Kannada, Telugu and Tamil today all hold this same Sanskrit-shaped form, borrowed back into languages that, on one account, lent Sanskrit the word in the first place.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kuṭumbam” — family
- which family lent Sanskrit the word — Dravidian
- the languages that later borrowed it back — Kannada, Telugu, Tamil

Before you move on

Which direction did कुटुम्बम् travel first — into Sanskrit, or out of it? (**Into it** — a Dravidian loanword.) What Tamil word is it compared to, and what does it literally build on? (**kuṭimai**, “family, lineage,” on **kuṭi**, “a hut.”) Which languages later borrowed the

Sanskrit-shaped form back? (Kannada, Telugu, Tamil.)

11.3 ह — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ं · स · ी.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ह

ह — *ha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *h*, it is **ha**.

What it is made of:

- a descending right stem joined to the leftward shoulder and clockwise hooked body
- a separate down-right outer curve and tail
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has ह somewhere inside it:

- अहम् *aham* — I
- अहं संस्कृतं वदामि *aham samiskṛtam vadāmi* — I speak Sanskrit
- स्निह्यति · प्रियम् *snihyati · priyam* — he, she, or it loves, and what is dear — affection named as stickiness, and the word behind English friend

Writing: ह

- 1. start at the right stem's headline junction, descend, sweep left through the shoulder, then curve clockwise around the hooked body to its lower-right tip without lifting

- **2.** lift at the body’s left junction and sweep down-left around the outer curve, then continue diagonally down-right through the tail
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; the corroborating deskbook stages the joined first body in more component steps

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ह-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 9 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ह in it
अहम् · अहं संस्कृतं वदामि · स्निह्यति · प्रियम्
- *Trace it:* ह three times, saying *ha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ह once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ह? What sound does it carry? (*ha*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

11.4 भ्राता (bhrātā) — “brother,” the same word, worn two ways

Say “family” and “friend.” (*Kuṭumbam, mitram*.) Now for the first person inside that family — and the plainest cousin in this book yet.

You’ll want to know: भ्राता

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
भ्राता	<i>bhrātā</i>	brother
मम भ्राता	<i>mama bhrātā</i>	my brother

Masculine — the first noun this chapter has not ended in -म्.

The letters in this word

भ्रा stacks र *ra* under भ *bha*, one push, then the long-*ā*: *bhrā*. ता closes it, *ta* plus long-*ā* again: *bhrā-tā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

भ्राता is PIE **bhrāter-**, and the descent is about as unbroken as this family gets: English **brother**, Latin **frāter**, Greek **phrātēr** are not relatives of भ्राता — they **are** भ्राता, six thousand years and three different roads later.

One of those roads runs straight through the daughter languages. भ्राता wore down through Prakrit *bhāi* into Bengali *bhāi* and Gujarati *bhāi*, both तद्भव — the same word again, just worn smooth by everyday speech rather than lifted whole like मित्र.

Grammatically, भ्राता is a fossil of its own: an old kinship word built on the stem भ्रातृ (*bhrātṛ*), whose nominative singular lengthens the final vowel to -आ instead of following the plain patterns you have seen so far.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhrātā” — brother
- its English, Latin, and Greek selves — brother, frāter, phrātēr
- its worn-down grandchildren — *bhāi*, *bhāi*

Before you move on

Is English *brother* a cousin of भ्राता, or the same word? (**The same word**, unbroken from PIE.) Which two daughter languages wore it down to *bhāi*? (**Bengali, Gujarati.**) What gender is भ्राता, unlike every noun before it this chapter? (**Masculine.**)

11.5 भगिनी (bhaginī) — “sister,” one with a share

Say “brother,” and name the English word it is not a cousin of but literally **is**. (*Bhrātā*; **brother.**) The matching word does not tell the same story.

You'll want to know: भगिनी

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
भगिनी	<i>bhaginī</i>	sister
मम भगिनी	<i>mama bhaginī</i>	my sister

Feminine — marked by the -ई you can hear at the end.

The letters in this word

भ is *bha*. गि is ग *ga* under a short-*i* sign. नी closes it, न under the long-*ī* sign — the same feminine ending you will meet again this book: *bha-gi-nī*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here the pattern breaks. भगिनी is built on भग (*bhaga*), “a share, good fortune,” plus the feminine suffix -इनी: literally, “one with a share.” Sanskrit’s actual cousin of English **sister** is a different word, स्वस् (*svasṛ*), from the same PIE root as *bhrātā*’s. It is real, attested in the old texts — but it did not become the everyday word. भगिनी did, and भगिनी is what wore down eastward: Bengali *bon* and Gujarati *bahen*, both तद्भव, both built on भग, not स्वस्.

So the honest connection to draw for “sister” is not the one nearest to English. Brother and sister do not travel the same road here — one is the same word worn down; the other took a different word entirely and left the matching one behind.

What you’ve built: four people

Mitram, *kuṭumbam*, *bhrātā*, *bhaginī* — a friend, a family, a brother, a sister. One borrowed into Sanskrit and then borrowed back out; two travelled in lockstep with their English match; one quietly swapped words along the way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “bhaginī” — sister
- what it is built on — *bhaga* “a share” plus *-inī*
- the word it is NOT built on — *svasṛ*, the real cousin of *sister*

Before you move on

What does भगिनी literally mean? (“**One with a share.**”) What is the actual PIE cousin of English *sister*, and why is it not the word we learned? (स्वसृ — attested, but never the living word.) Which two daughter languages descend from भगिनी instead? (**Bengali, Gujarati.**) Name this chapter’s four people. (*Mitram, kuṭumbam, bhrātā, bhaginī.*)

11.6 ए — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: स · ी · ह.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ए

ए — *e*.

It is an **independent vowel**: the full-size letter a vowel wears when it opens a word and has no consonant to lean on. Inside a word the same vowel is written as a small sign instead.

What it is made of:

- a long left stem joined to the descending tail
- a shorter right stem with an inward hook
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has ए somewhere inside it:

- एक द्व त्रि चतुर् पञ्च *eka dva tri catur pañca* — one to five — Old Indo-Aryan ancestors preserved in Sanskrit, and cousins of the English ones
- एक · द्व · त्रि · चतुर् · पञ्च *eka · dva · tri · catur · pañca* — the Sanskrit, Latin, and English number family and the sound laws between them

Writing: ए

- **1.** descend the left stem, curve right through the lower shoulder, and sweep down through the tail without lifting
- **2.** lift and descend the shorter right stem into its inward hook
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified modern printed teaching form; everyday handwriting may simplify the curves

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Saurmandal, ‘Devanagari ए stroke order.svg’, panels 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 5 August 2023.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ए in it
एक द्व त्रि चतुर् पञ्च · एक · द्व · त्रि · चतुर् · पञ्च
- *Trace it:* ए three times, saying *e* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ए once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ए? What sound does it carry? (*e*.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 12

The Face, Part One

Modes: 👁 eyes (3) ✍ pen (1) 🗣 Hands-free start: first 2 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name an eye, an ear and a mouth in Sanskrit, say why eyes take a dual number, and say which of the three words has a settled Western cousin and which do not.

Say मुखम्, report both scholarly accounts of its origin without choosing between them, and run अक्षि, कर्णः and मुखम् back together against their daughter-language descendants and the neuter gender most of them share.

12.1 अक्षि (akṣi) — “eye,” and the number Sanskrit built for it

Say “sister.” (*Bhaginī*.) The people you would introduce are done. Now for the face you would check on someone with.

You’ll want to know: अक्षि

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
अक्षि	<i>akṣi</i>	eye
अक्षिणी	<i>akṣiṇī</i>	the two eyes

Neuter, like most of this book’s shortest nouns.

The letters in this word

अ opens bare. क्षि is the same क्ष conjunct you sounded out in क्षीरम्, now carrying a short-*i* instead of a long one: *a-kṣi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

अक्षि is PIE **h3ekw-**, and the descent runs almost as clean as *bhrātā*’s: English **eye**, Latin **oculus** (→ *ocular*, *monocle*), Lithuanian **akis** — one root, barely disguised anywhere. It carries straight into Hindi आँख and Gujarati *āṅkh*, both inherited, not borrowed back the way मित्र was. And eyes are exactly the reason Sanskrit keeps a **dual number** at all — the exactly-two form Chapter 6 built around द्वौ, “two,” rather than an ordinary count word. A single eye is अक्षि; the two you were born with are not a small plural, they are अक्षिणी — grammar built for a body that comes in pairs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “akṣi” — eye
- its English and Latin selves — eye, oculus
- the dual form for two of them — *akṣiṇī*

Before you move on

Name two English words from the same root as अक्षि. (**Eye**, and, through Latin, **ocular** or **monocle**.) What is the dual form for “two eyes,” and what grammatical number is that? (अक्षिणी; the **dual**, the same category as *dvau*.) And what did you learn just before this? (*Bhaginī*, sister.)

12.2 कर्णः (karṇaḥ) — “ear,” a word without a settled parent

Say “eye,” and its dual form for two of them. (*Akṣi*; **akṣiṇī**.)
The next sense is one Sanskrit itself never traced to its source.

You'll want to know: कर्णः

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
कर्णः	<i>karnah</i>	ear
कर्णौ	<i>karnau</i>	the two ears — dual again

Masculine, unlike अक्षि.

The letters in this word

कर् is *kar*, the *r* you have sounded since संस्कृत. ण is the curled-back retroflex *n*, familiar from गुह्यति. The final ः, a *visarga*, breathes the word out on an echo of its own vowel: *kar-ṇa-h*, the same puff first heard closing नमस्ते.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Where अक्षि (*akṣi*)'s ancestry runs clean back to PIE, कर्णः's does not run anywhere agreed. Proposed roots mean “a defect,” “a point,” “a handle,” and “to hear” — and no single account has won out over the others.

What is certain is where it went. कर्णः wore down through Prakrit **kaṇṇa** into Gujarati *kān* — and changed gender on the way: masculine in Sanskrit, feminine in Gujarati. A word can cross a language boundary and lose the very grammar that first classified it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “karnah” — ear
- the four disputed guesses — a defect, a point, a handle, to hear
- the daughter word and its new gender — *kān*, now feminine

Before you move on

Is कर्णः's root settled or disputed? (**Disputed** — four guesses, no winner.) What ending marks it masculine, and where did you meet that sound before? (-अः, a *visarga*, first heard on नमस्ते.) What gender does the Gujarati descendant *kān* take, and is that the same

as Sanskrit's? (**Feminine — it changed.**)

12.3 ठ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ी · ह · ए.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ठ

ठ — *ṭha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ṭh*, it is **ṭha**.

What it is made of:

- a short top-to-bottom central stem
- a separate counterclockwise closed round body
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has ठ somewhere inside it:

- पठति *paṭhati* — he, she, or it reads — reading as reciting aloud, and the two ways a Sanskrit word survives into a modern language

Writing: ठ

- **1.** draw the short central stem top-to-bottom
- **2.** lift at the stem's lower junction and sweep left, then counterclockwise around the closed round body back to the junction without lifting
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ठ-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ठ in it

पठति

- *Trace it:* ठ three times, saying *ṭha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ठ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ठ? What sound does it carry? (*ṭha*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

12.4 मुखम् (mukham) — “mouth,” a word two families both claim

Say “ear” and “eye.” (*Karṇah, akṣi*.) One more, and this one’s ancestry is argued over by two whole language families, not just two scholars.

You’ll want to know: मुखम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
मुखम्	<i>mukham</i>	mouth , face
सम्मुखम्	<i>sammukham</i>	face to face — सम् “together” plus मुखम्

Neuter, back to the family’s usual ending.

The letters in this word

मु is म under a short-*u* sign. ख is the aspirated *kha* you met in खादति — a *k* with a puff of breath, distinct from plain क. म् closes it: *mu-kha-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मुखम् is genuinely contested territory. One line of scholarship derives it from Dravidian; another argues for an Indo-European source, pointing to its presence in the Rigveda and in Iranian languages. Neither claim has settled the question, and this book takes no side either.

What is not contested is where it lives now. Bengali *mukh* keeps it whole, a तत्सम — while Gujarati holds a worn-down तद्भव doublet, **moḍhū**, alongside its own formal **mukh**. That is the same shape this book already showed with चिन्ता and पठति: one word, two roads into the same daughter language, once carried whole and once worn down by speech. मुखम् closes this chapter neuter, like every noun here but *bhrātā*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mukham” — mouth, face
- the two disputed families — Dravidian, or Indo-European
- its two Gujarati faces — *mukh*, and worn-down *moḍhū*

Before you move on

Which two language families both claim मुखम्? (**Dravidian, and Indo-European** — unsettled.) Name मुखम्’s two Gujarati descendants and which is तत्सम, which तद्भव. (**mukh, तत्सम; moḍhū, तद्भव.**) Name this chapter’s three words for the face. (*Akṣi, karṇaḥ, mukham.*)

Chapter 13

The Face, Part Two

Modes: 👁 eyes (2) ✍ pen (1) 🗣 Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a nose and a heart in Sanskrit, say which daughter-language nose-word नासिका is a relative of rather than a parent of, and close the chapter's twelve nouns against the cousin words this book has already shown.

Say हृदयम्, name the PIE root it shares with heart, cor and kardia, place हृदयम् beside the same root's other independent inheritances, and run all twelve of this tranche's nouns back together by group and by gender.

13.1 नासिका (nāsikā) — “nose,” kin to two words but parent of neither

Say “mouth.” (*Mukham.*) One more part of the face — and a chance to correct a connection this book has not yet made carefully enough.

You'll want to know: नासिका

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
नासिका	<i>nāsikā</i>	nose
मम नासिका	<i>mama nāsikā</i>	my nose

Feminine, marked by the same -आ you will hear again.

The letters in this word

ना is *nā*, न under the long-*ā* sign. सि is स under a short-*i*. का closes it, क under long-*ā* again: *nā-si-kā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नासिका is built on an older word, नासा (*nāsā*), “nose,” plus the diminutive suffix -इका. नासा itself, and the still-older root नस् (*nas*) behind it, go back to PIE **nehas-**, the unbroken root of English **nose** and Latin **nasus** (→ *nasal*).

Here is the correction worth making carefully: नासिका is *not* the ancestor of Bengali *nāk* or Gujarati *nāk*. Both of those wore straight down from नस् itself, through Prakrit **ṇakka**, by adding a completely different suffix. नासिका and नाक share a root, the way ग्रह and English *grab* share one — **relatives, not parent and child**. Reaching for the nearest-looking Sanskrit word is not always reaching for the right ancestor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nāsikā*” — nose
- the older word and root beneath it — *nāsā*, *nas*
- the word नासिका is NOT the parent of — *nāk*

Before you move on

What PIE root is नासिका’s family from, and name two of its Western cousins. (**nehas-**; **nose**, **nasus**/*nasal*.) Is नासिका the ancestor of Bengali *nāk*, or its relative? (**Relative** — both descend from नस्, neither from the other.) What did you learn just before this? (*Mukham*, mouth.)

13.2 ध — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ह · ए · ठ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ध

ध — *dha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *dh*, it is **dha**.

What it is made of:

- an upper spiral ending in a rightward shoulder
- a separate lower bowl
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has ध somewhere inside it:

- धन्यवादः *dhanyavādah* — thank you

Writing: ध

- **1.** start at the upper spiral's inner crossing, curl around the small opening, widen left and down around the outer loop, then sweep right through the shoulder without lifting
- **2.** lift at the left waist and sweep down and around the lower bowl to its right junction
- **3.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **4.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified four-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the loops differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, 'Deva-ध-order.gif', strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ध in it
- धन्यवादः
- *Trace it:* ध three times, saying *dha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ध once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ध? What sound does it carry? (*dha*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

13.3 हृदयम् (hṛdayam) — “heart,” a root barely disguised anywhere

Say “nose,” “eye,” and “mouth.” (*Nāsikā, akṣi, mukham.*) One last word, and it names what this whole chapter has been checking on.

You’ll want to know: हृदयम्

Sanskrit	sound	meaning
हृदयम्	<i>hṛdayam</i>	heart
मम हृदयम्	<i>mama hṛdayam</i>	my heart

Neuter — the family this whole chapter keeps returning to.

The letters in this word

हृ is *hṛ*: ह *ha* carrying the vocalic ऋ, the same buzzing vowel you first sounded out in गृह्णाति. द is *da*, य is *ya*, म् closes it neuter: *hṛ-da-ya-m*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

हृदयम् is PIE **kerd-**, and almost nothing about it has changed shape on the way anywhere: English **heart**, Latin **cor**, genitive **cordis** (→ *cordial, courage, accord*), Greek **kardia** (→ *cardiac*) — one root, four languages, all still recognisable. The same root anchors Italian **cuore**, Portuguese **coração**, and Russian *serdtse*, each an independent

inheritance of the identical PIE ancestor rather than a loan from any of the others.

Eastward, Bengali *hriday* keeps हृदयम् whole, a तत्सम; its worn-down twin *hiya* survives only in poetry and song, not everyday speech — the rarer pairing, where the carried-whole word is the common one and the worn-down word is the rare one.

What you’ve built: twelve words, three rooms

Three groups, twelve nouns: what you would ask for (*pānīyam*, *kṣīram*, *annam*), who you would introduce (*mitram*, *kuṭumbam*, *bhrātā*, *bhagini*), and your own face (*akṣi*, *karṇaḥ*, *mukham*, *nāsikā*, *hṛdayam*). Almost every one of them ended in the neuter -म् you first named beside अन्नम् — and almost every one pointed at a word some other language in this project already teaches as its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “hṛdayam” — heart
- four cousins across four languages — heart, cor, kardia, cuore
- the Bengali twin kept whole, and the one kept only in poetry — *hriday*, *hiya*

Before you move on

Name three languages, besides English, whose word for heart shares हृदयम्’s root. (Any three of **Latin**, **Greek**, **Italian**, **Portuguese**, **Russian**.) Which Bengali form of “heart” is everyday, and which survives only in poetry? (*hriday*, everyday; *hiya*, poetry.) What gender has run through nearly this entire chapter’s nouns? (**Neuter**.) And what was the very first word of this chapter? (*Pānīyam*, water.)

Chapter 14

Pointing, and Asking

Modes: ⇄ voice (7) ✍ pen (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 11 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Sanskrit and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

14.1 एतत् (etat) — this one — the thing near me

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: एतत्

एतत् — *etat* — this one — the thing near me.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is तत् *tat*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “एतत्” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *etat*? (this one — the thing near me.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**a** — near.)

14.2 ढ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ढ · ढ · ढ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ढ

ढ — *ṭa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ṭ*, it is **ṭa**.

What it is made of:

- a descending central stem joined to a counterclockwise open round body
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say this word, and ढ is one of the shapes inside it — the rest of its shapes are still ahead of you, so here the character stands on its own:

- *kuṭumbam* — family, household — a word Sanskrit itself borrowed, before other languages borrowed it back

Writing: ढ

- **1.** start at the central stem's headline junction, descend, turn left through the upper shoulder, and sweep counterclockwise around the open round body to its up-right tip without lifting

- **2.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 1. The pen comes up 1 times and no more.

verified two-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-त-order.gif’, strokes 1–2, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find त in it

त

- *Trace it:* त three times, saying *ta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find त once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — त? What sound does it carry? (*ta*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

14.3 तत् (tat) — that one — the thing over there

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You’ll want to know: तत्

तत् — *tat* — that one — the thing over there.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is एतत् *etat*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **t-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “तत्” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *tat*? (that one — the thing over there.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**t** — far.)

14.4 अत्र (atra) — here — where I am

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You’ll want to know: अत्र

अत्र — *atra* — here — where I am.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is तत्र *tatra*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “अत्र” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *atra*? (here — where I am.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**a-** — near.)

14.5 ल — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ठ · ध · ट.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ल

ल — *la*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *l*, it is **la**.

What it is made of:

- a clockwise open left loop
- an up-right diagonal arm
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has ल somewhere inside it:

- लिखति *likhati* — he, she, or it writes — a root that means “scratch,” and the chapter’s four verbs gathered up

Writing: ल

- 1. start at the open lower-left tip, curve up and clockwise around the left loop, and finish at the inner junction
- 2. lift at that junction and sweep the diagonal arm up-right to the right stem
- 3. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 4. lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified four-stroke teaching form; another animated learner source writes the same parts in a stem-first order

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ल-order.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 11 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ल in it
- लिखति
- *Trace it:* ल three times, saying *la* as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ल once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ल? What sound does it carry? (*la.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

14.6 तत्र (tatra) — there — where I am not

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You’ll want to know: तत्र

तत्र — *tatra* — there — where I am not.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is अत्र *atra*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **t-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “तत्र” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *tatra*? (there — where I am not.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**t-** — far.)

14.7 कः (kaḥ) — who? — asking about a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: कः

कः — *kaḥ* — who? — asking about a person.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is कुत्र *kutra*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **k-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “कः” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *kaḥ*? (who? — asking about a person.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**k-** — ask.)

14.8 ो — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: थ · ट · ल.

Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ो

ो — *o*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: the ā bar on the right plus a stroke above.

Worked through: न + ो = नो — *no*.

You already say these, and every one of them has ो somewhere inside it:

- करोमि *karomi* — I do, I make
- साहाय्यं करोति *sāhāyyam karoti* — he, she, or it helps — a noun plus “does,” and help named as going along with someone

Writing: ो — copy what you see

Put your pen on ो and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ो in it
करोमि · साहाय्यं करोति
- *Trace it:* ो three times, saying *o* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ो once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ो? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts o on;**

takes the built-in *a* off.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

14.9 कुत्र (kutra) — where? — asking about a place

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: कुत्र

कुत्र — *kutra* — where? — asking about a place.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is कः *kah*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **k-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “कुत्र” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *kutra*? (where? — asking about a place.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**k-** — ask.)

14.10 a- / t- / k- — six words, one machine

Say the six words from this chapter out loud, in order. Listen to how they begin.

Grammar lens: one slot changes

You did not learn six words. You learned **three beginnings** and reused them.

meaning	word
near	अत्र <i>atra</i>
far	तत्र <i>tatra</i>
question	कुत्र <i>kutra</i>

Sanskrit is where Hindi's k- comes from: अत्र, तत्र, कुत्र.

Change the front, and the meaning walks from **near** to **far** to a **question**. Nothing else in the word moves.

The same three beginnings run the thing-words too: एतत् *etat* and तत् *tat* start exactly like the first two rows. This chapter did not teach you the matching question word for things — that one arrives later, and when it does you will already know what it has to start with.

This is worth more than the six words are. When you meet a new word in this family later, you will not have to be taught all three of it — you will be taught one and work out the others.

Your turn

- *Say it*: the near word, then the far word, then the question word
- *Say it*: them again for place, not for things
- *Notice*: the part that did NOT change

Before you move on

Which beginning means near? (a-) Far? (t-) And which one turns the word into a question? (k-)

14.11 थ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ट · ल · ो.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: थ

थ — *tha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *th*, it is **tha**.

What it is made of:

- an upper spiral joined continuously to a broad lower bowl
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has थ somewhere inside it:

- कथम् *katham* — how
- भवान् कथम् अस्ति? *bhavān katham asti?* — how are you?

Writing: थ

1. start at the upper spiral's inner-right tip, curl clockwise around the small opening and outward to the left waist, then continue down and clockwise around the broad lower bowl to the right-stem junction without lifting
2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
3. lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, 'Deva-थ-order.gif', strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find थ in it

कथम् · भवान् कथम् अस्ति?

- *Trace it:* थ three times, saying *tha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find थ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — थ? What sound does it carry? (*tha*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 15

Describing Things

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) ✍️ pen (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Sanskrit and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

15.1 महत् (mahat) — big

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: महत्

महत् — *mahat* — big.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “महत्” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *mahat*? (**big**.) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before**.)

15.2 अल्प (alpa) — small

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: अल्प

अल्प — *alpa* — small.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met महत् *mahat* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “अल्प” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *alpa*? (**small**.) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before**.)

15.3 ब — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ल · ो · थ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ब

ब — *ba*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *b*, it is **ba**.

What it is made of:

- a counterclockwise oval body
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- a down-right inner diagonal
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has ब somewhere inside it:

- कुटुम्बम् *kuṭumbam* — family, household — a word Sanskrit itself borrowed, before other languages borrowed it back

Writing: ब

- 1. start at the body's upper-right junction and circle counterclockwise around the oval to its lower-right junction
- 2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 3. lift at the body's upper-left interior and draw the inner diagonal down-right
- 4. lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified four-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the oval differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: JackPotte, 'Devanagari b ब.gif', strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 29 March 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ब in it

कुटुम्बम्

- *Trace it:* ब three times, saying *ba* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ब once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ब? What sound does it carry? (*ba.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

15.4 उत्तम (uttama) — good

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: उत्तम

उत्तम — *uttama* — good.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met अल्प *alpa* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “उत्तम” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *uttama*? (*good.*) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (*Before.*)

15.5 नव (nava) — new

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: नव

नव — *nava* — new.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met उत्तम *uttama* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “नव” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *nava*? (**new.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

15.6 उ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ो · थ · ब.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: उ

उ — *u*.

It is an **independent vowel**: the full-size letter a vowel wears when it opens a word and has no consonant to lean on. Inside a word the same vowel is written as a small sign instead.

What it is made of:

- a joined upper bowl and lower loop
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has उ somewhere inside it:

- उत्तम *uttama* — good

Writing: उ

- **1.** start at the headline junction, curve down and left around the upper bowl, then sweep back through the waist and around the lower loop without lifting
- **2.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 1. The pen comes up 1 times and no more.

verified modern printed teaching form; everyday handwriting may simplify the curves

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Saurmandal, ‘Devanagari उ stroke order.svg’, panels 1–2, Wikimedia Commons, 5 August 2023.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find उ in it

उत्तम

- *Trace it:* उ three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find उ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — उ? What sound does it carry? (**u.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

15.7 पुरातन (purātana) — old — of a thing, not of a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: पुरातन

पुरातन — *purātana* — old — of a thing, not of a person.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met नव *nava* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “पुरातन” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *purātana*? (**old — of a thing, not of a person.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

15.8 before the noun, and it AGREES — five words, one rule

Say the five words from this chapter out loud, then say each one in front of a noun you already know.

Grammar lens: where an adjective goes

You did not learn five separate words. You learned **where an adjective goes**, and five words that go there.

meaning	word
big	महत् <i>mahat</i>
small	अल्प <i>alpa</i>
good	उत्तम <i>uttama</i>

Sanskrit agrees too, and in more ways than Hindi does — this is where Hindi's habit comes from.

This is worth more than the five words are. Every noun you already know — your name, the house, the water, the day — can now take any of them in front, and every adjective you meet from here goes in the same place.

Your turn

- *Say it*: each of the five in front of a noun you already know
- *Say it*: two of them with the same noun, one after the other
- *Notice*: whether the adjective changed shape when the noun did

Before you move on

Where does an adjective go in this language? (**In front of the noun.**) Does it change shape to match the noun? (and it AGREES.)

15.9 ष — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: थ · ब · उ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ष

ष — *ṣa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not ṣ, it is **ṣa**.

What it is made of:

- a U-shaped body drawn from the left side around the lower bowl and up the right side
- a retraced top-to-bottom right stem
- a down-right inner diagonal
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has ष somewhere inside it:

- क्षीरम् *kṣīram* — milk — an origin scholars still argue over, and the dessert word it left behind
- अक्षि *akṣi* — eye — unbroken from Sanskrit to English, and the reason eyes get their own grammatical number

Writing: ष

1. descend the left side, curve counterclockwise around the lower bowl, and rise along the right side to the headline without lifting
2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom, retracing its upper body-side segment before continuing below the bowl
3. lift at the upper-left interior and draw the inner diagonal down-right to the bowl junction
4. lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 3. The pen comes up 3 times and no more.

verified four-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ष-order.gif’, strokes 1–4, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ष in it

क्षीरम् · अक्षि

- *Trace it:* ष three times, saying *ṣa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ष once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ष? What sound does it carry? (*ṣa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

15.10 ौ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ब · उ · ष.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ौ

ौ — *au*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: the ā bar plus a double stroke above.

Worked through: न + ौ = नौ — *nau*.

No word in this book has put ौ in front of you yet, and that is worth saying plainly rather than hiding: this one is here because it is built from two shapes you already know, and because the running text of later chapters uses it.

Writing: ौ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ौ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ौ in it

ौ
- *Trace it:* ौ three times, saying *au* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ौ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ौ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *au* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 16

Places — and the Two Noun Families

Modes: ⇌ voice (6) ✍ pen (3) ⇌ Hands-free start: first 2 of 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five places in Sanskrit, put a known adjective in front of any of them, and hear from a noun’s ending whether it is neuter or masculine.

Complete SA-C16-noun-families: sort the chapter’s five places into the -am and -aH families and say a known adjective before each.

16.1 गृहम् (gr̥ham) — house, home

You can describe a thing now — big, small, new, old. This chapter gives you places to put those things.

You’ll want to know: गृहम्

गृहम् (gr̥ham) — “house, home.”

The traditional derivation ties it to the root √ग्रह् (grah), “to seize, to hold.” A house is *the thing that holds you* — the grasp you live inside. That is how Sanskrit’s own grammarians heard the word, and it is worth hearing that way.

You can already stack an adjective in front of it: महत् गृहम्, “a big house”; नव गृहम्, “a new house.” The adjective comes first, as you have already seen it do.

What you've built

This is your first **place**. Everything in this chapter is somewhere you can be, and every one of them takes the adjectives you already own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gr̥ham* — “house”
- “a big house” — *mahat gr̥ham*
- “a new house” — *nava gr̥ham*

Before you move on

What root is गृहम् traditionally tied to? ($\sqrt{\text{ग्रह्}}$, “to seize, to hold.”)
Where does the adjective go? (Before the noun.)

16.2 ग्रामः (grāmaḥ) — village

One house is a home. Many of them together are this.

You'll want to know: ग्रामः

ग्रामः (*grāmaḥ*) — “village.”

Its oldest sense is not “village” but “**a collection, a troop**” — a gathering of people considered as one body. The settlement took its name from the group, not the group from the settlement, which tells you how the word's first speakers saw the place: people first, buildings after.

Notice the ending. गृहम् ends in *-am*; ग्रामः ends in *-aḥ*. Sanskrit sorts its nouns into families, and that final syllable is the badge. You do not need the system yet — only the observation that the endings differ, and that the difference is not random.

What you've built

Two places now, and your first glimpse of the noun families — the *-am* ending and the *-aḥ* ending, sitting side by side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *grāmaḥ* — “village”
- “a big village” — *mahat grāmaḥ*
- the two endings back to back — *gr̥ham, grāmaḥ*

Before you move on

What did ग्रामः mean before it meant “village”? (A collection, a troop.) Which two endings have you now seen? (*-am* and *-aḥ*.)

16.3 ण — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: उ · ष · ी.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ण

ण — *ṇa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ṇ*, it is **ṇa**.

What it is made of:

- a joined left stem, clockwise lower bowl, and inner right stem
- a separate top-to-bottom outer right stem
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has ण somewhere inside it:

- कर्णः *karnah* — ear — a word Sanskrit itself never settled the origin of

Writing: ण

- **1.** start at the left stem's headline junction, descend, curve clockwise around the lower bowl, and rise along the inner right stem back to the headline without lifting
- **2.** lift and draw the outer right stem top-to-bottom
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ण-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ण in it

कर्णः

- *Trace it:* ण three times, saying ṇa as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ण once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ण? What sound does it carry? (ṇa.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

16.4 मार्गः (mārgaḥ) — road, path

Two places, and no way between them. Here is the way.

You'll want to know: मार्गः

मार्गः (*mārgaḥ*) — “road, path, way.”

From the root √मृग् (*mṛg*), “to track, to hunt, to search out.” A road is a **tracking** — the line left by someone who went looking. The same root gives मृगः (*mṛgaḥ*), “deer”: the animal that gets tracked.

So the word does not name a built thing at all. It names the trace of a search, and only later the paved version of it. English keeps that metaphor alive when it speaks of a *line of enquiry*.

What you've built

मार्गः takes the same *-aḥ* ending as ग्रामः. That is the second word in its family, and the pattern is becoming visible rather than asserted.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mārgaḥ* — “road”
- “the old road” — *purātana mārgaḥ*
- the related animal — *mṛgaḥ*, “deer”

Before you move on

What does √मृग् mean? (To track, to hunt.) What animal shares the root? (मृगः, the deer.) Which ending does मार्गः take? (*-aḥ*.)

16.5 वनम् (vanam) — forest, wood

Follow the road far enough out of the village and you reach this.

You'll want to know: वनम्

वनम् (*vanam*) — “forest, wood, wilderness.”

In the older literature it carries a weight that “forest” does not quite catch: वनम् is where the settled world stops. To go to the वनम् is to leave the ग्रामः behind, and a great deal of Sanskrit narrative turns on somebody doing exactly that.

Its ending is *-am*, so it belongs with गृहम् — which gives the chapter a neat symmetry: the two *-am* words so far are the house you live inside and the wild you do not.

What you’ve built

Four places, and the two endings now have two words each. That is a pattern you have observed, not one you have been handed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vanam* — “forest”
- “a big forest” — *mahat vanam*
- the two *-am* words together — *grham, vanam*

Before you move on

What does वनम् mean beyond “forest”? (Where the settled world stops.) Which other word shares its ending? (गृहम्.)

16.6 ग — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ष · ौ · ण.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ग

ग — *ga*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *g*, it is **ga**.

What it is made of:

- a counterclockwise left loop joined to an ascending stem

- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has ग somewhere inside it:

- स्वागतम् *svāgatam* — welcome (lit. “well come”)
- गृह्णाति *grhṇāti* — he, she, or it takes, seizes — the ninth class again, and the root English grabs with
- भगिनी *bhaginī* — sister — not built on English “sister”’s root at all, but on “one with a share”
- गृहम् *grham* — house, home

Writing: ग

1. start at the loop’s upper-right junction and sweep left over the top, down around the left side, back to the lower-right junction, and continue up the joined stem to the headline
2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
3. lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; everyday handwriting may join or simplify the body differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ग-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 9 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ग in it
स्वागतम् · गृह्णाति · भगिनी
- *Trace it:* ग three times, saying *ga* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ग once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ग? What sound does it carry? (*ga.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

16.7 नगरम् (nagaram) — city

The last of the five places, and the biggest.

You'll want to know: नगरम्

नगरम् (*nagaram*) — “city, town.”

Its origin is **genuinely unsettled**, and that is worth saying plainly rather than inventing a story. Sanskrit offers no agreed root for it. Some scholars have proposed that it came into the language from outside — one of a handful of everyday words that may record a borrowing from languages spoken in the subcontinent before Sanskrit arrived. Others resist that reading. The honest position is that nobody knows.

Whatever its history, it ends in *-am*, like गृहम् and वनम्.

What you've built

Five places: house, village, road, forest, city. Three take *-am* and two take *-ah*, and the next lesson says what that division actually is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nagaram* — “city”
- “a new city” — *nava nagaram*
- all three *-am* words — *grham*, *vanam*, *nagaram*

Before you move on

Why is नगरम् unusual among this chapter's words? (Its origin is unsettled; it may be a borrowing.) Which ending does it take? (*-am.*)

16.8 -अम् · -अः (-am · -aḥ) — the two noun endings, side by side

You have met five places and noticed their endings differ. This lesson names what you noticed.

You'll want to know: -अम् · -अः

Sanskrit sorts its nouns into **genders**, and the ending you have been hearing is the clue:

गृहम्, वनम्, नगरम् end in -अम् — these are **neuter**. ग्रामः, मार्गः end in -अः — these are **masculine**.

This is the same machinery the adjectives used without naming it: they change to match. महत् गृहम् and महान् ग्रामः are one adjective agreeing with two different families.

You do not need to produce that agreement yet. What you need is the ear for it — when you hear -अम् or -अः closing a word, you are hearing which family it belongs to, and Sanskrit will keep using that information for everything that follows.

What you've built

You can now hear a noun's family from its ending, which is the single most useful thing to know about a Sanskrit noun.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three neuters — *grham, vanam, nagaram*
- the two masculines — *grāmaḥ, mārgaḥ*
- which family a new word ending in *-am* belongs to

Before you move on

Which ending marks the neuter? (-अम्.) Which marks the masculine? (-अः.) What else in the sentence responds to a noun's family? (The adjective.)

16.9 ज — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ौ · ण · ग.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ज

ज — *ja*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *j*, it is **ja**.

What it is made of:

- an open left hook curling clockwise around the lower bowl and continuing through the middle bar
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has ज somewhere inside it:

- जानाति *jānāti* — he, she, or it knows — the root ज्ञा, the class that plants a syllable inside the verb, and the chapter's six roots gathered up

Writing: ज

- **1.** start at the open upper-left tip, sweep down and clockwise around the lower bowl, then rise through the inner shoulder and continue right along the middle bar to the right-stem junction without lifting
- **2.** lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-ज-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ज in it

जानाति

- *Trace it:* ज three times, saying *ja* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ज once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ज? What sound does it carry? (*ja.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 17

Time — Day, Night, and When Things Happen

Modes: ⇄ voice (6) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 2 of 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the parts of a day in Sanskrit, say today, yesterday and always, and place a time word in a sentence.

Complete SA-C17-time-words and demonstrate the chapter promise.

17.1 दिनम् (dinam) — day

You have places. Now you need times to put in them.

You'll want to know: दिनम्

दिनम् (*dinam*) — “day.”

It belongs to one of the oldest word-families in the language. The Indo-European root for the bright sky, **dyew-*, gave Sanskrit द्यौः (*dyauh*), the sky itself, and it is the same root standing behind Latin *diēs*, “day,” and the god names *Iuppiter* and *Zeus*. A day, to the people who coined the word, was simply *the bright*.

Its ending is *-am*, so you already know its family without being told: neuter, like गृहम् and वनम्.

What you've built

Your first time word, and it arrived with its family badge already legible. That is what the ending work bought you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dinam* — “day”
- “a good day” — *uttama dinam*
- which family it belongs to, from the ending alone

Before you move on

What did the root behind दिनम् originally mean? (The bright sky.)
Which family does it belong to, and how do you know? (Neuter — the *-am* ending.)

17.2 रात्रिः (rātriḥ) — night

The other half of the day.

You'll want to know: रात्रिः

रात्रिः (*rātriḥ*) — “night.”

Where दिनम् is the bright, रात्रिः is its opposite, and the pair is one of the oldest ways any language divides the world. In the hymns it is a name as much as a noun: Rātrī is addressed directly, a presence rather than an absence of light.

The ending here is *-iḥ*, which is neither of the two you have met. Sanskrit has more than two families, and this is your first sight of a third. You do not need it yet — only the honest note that the system is bigger than the part you have seen.

What you've built

Day and night, and a quiet warning: the *-am* / *-aḥ* division you learned is real but not the whole map.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *rātriḥ* — “night”
- the pair together — *dinam, rātriḥ*
- which ending is new to you here

Before you move on

What is रात्रिः in the hymns, beyond a noun? (A presence addressed by name.) What does its ending tell you? (That there are more than two noun families.)

17.3 श — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ण · ग · ज.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: श

श — *śa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ś*, it is **śa**.

What it is made of:

- a joined upper loop, descending outer curve, lower loop, and diagonal tail
- a top-to-bottom right stem
- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has श somewhere inside it:

- कुशलम् *kuśalam* — well-being — and the reply “अहं कुशली अस्मि”

- पुनर्दर्शनाय *punardarśanāya* — until we meet again (lit. “for seeing again”)
- श्वः *śvaḥ* — tomorrow — and “see you tomorrow”
- पश्यति *paśyati* — he, she, or it sees — a verb assembled from two different roots, one of which you already met

Writing: श

- 1. start at the upper loop’s lower inner tip, sweep left and clockwise around the upper loop, descend the outer curve, curl around the lower loop, and continue down-right through the diagonal tail without lifting
- 2. lift and draw the right stem top-to-bottom
- 3. lift and draw the top shirorekḥā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-श-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find श in it

कुशलम् · पुनर्दर्शनाय · श्वः

- *Trace it:* श three times, saying *śa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find श once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — श? What sound does it carry? (*śa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

17.4 अद्य (adya) — today

Naming the day you are standing in.

You'll want to know: अद्य

अद्य (*adya*) — “today.”

Take it apart and the older shape shows: *a-* (“this”) plus the same *dy-* that sits inside दिनम् and द्यौः. **This day** — said so often that the two halves fused and stopped being separable for ordinary speakers.

This is how a great many everyday words are built, in Sanskrit and elsewhere. English *today* is *to* + *day*, and *tomorrow* is *to* + *morrow*: the same trick, a thousand years later, in a different family.

What you've built

A word you can now see through. When a short everyday word looks unanalysable, it is usually a fused phrase that got worn smooth.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *adya* — “today”
- the two pieces inside it — *a-* and *dy-*
- the English word built the same way (*today*)

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of अद्य? (*A-*, “this,” and the *dy-* of “day.”)
What English word is built the same way? (*Today*.)

17.5 ह्यः (hyaḥ) — yesterday

The day behind you — and a word with relatives you already speak.

You'll want to know: ह्यः

ह्यः (*hyah*) — “yesterday.”

This one is a gift, because its cousins are everywhere. The same ancestral word gave Latin *heri*, which became Spanish *ayer* and French *hier*; and it gave Germanic *gester-*, which is the **yester-** still sitting inside English *yesterday*.

So ह्यः, *heri*, *ayer* and *yester-* are four survivals of one word for “the day before this one,” spoken continuously for as long as any of these languages have existed. Very few words let you see that far back this clearly.

What you've built

A word that is genuinely easier to keep because of what it is related to. When a Sanskrit word has a visible European cousin, learn them as one thing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hyah* — “yesterday”
- its Latin cousin — *heri*
- the English word that still carries it (*yesterday*)

Before you move on

Which Latin word is ह्यः related to? (*Heri*.) What English word still carries the same root? (*Yesterday*.) What does the family all mean? (The day before this one.)

17.6 छ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ग · ज · श.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: छ

छ — *cha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ch*, it is **cha**.

What it is made of:

- a continuous upper-left loop, lower bowl, outer-right rise, and inner loop
- a short upper stem
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has छ somewhere inside it:

- गच्छामि *gacchāmi* — I go
- गच्छति *gacchati* — he, she, or it goes — the verb whose present stem you could never guess from its root
- आगच्छति *āgacchati* — he, she, or it comes — the same verb as “goes” with a prefix pointing it homeward
- अवगच्छति · बुध्यते *avagacchati* · *budhyate* — he, she, or it understands — “goes down into” a thing, or wakes up to it

Writing: छ

- **1.** start at the upper loop’s open right tip, sweep counterclockwise around the upper-left loop, continue clockwise around the broad lower bowl, rise along the outer right side, and curl counterclockwise around the inner loop to its down-right tip without lifting
- **2.** lift and draw the short upper stem top-to-bottom
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, ‘Deva-छ-order.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find छ in it

गच्छामि · गच्छति · आगच्छति

- *Trace it:* छ three times, saying *cha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find छ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — छ? What sound does it carry? (*cha*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

17.7 सदा (sadā) — always

Today, yesterday — and the word for every day there is.

You’ll want to know: सदा

सदा (*sadā*) — “always, ever.”

It carries the sense of *sa-*, “together, whole, the same” — the element behind Sanskrit सम (*sama*), “same, equal,” and behind English **same** itself. Always is the whole of time taken at once.

Where the other four words in this chapter point at one particular time, सदा refuses to. That is what makes it useful with the verbs you already have: सदा पठति, “he reads always.”

What you’ve built

Five time words: two nouns, three that simply attach to a verb and say when.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sadā* — “always”
- “he always reads” — *sadā paṭhati*
- the English word related to its first piece (*same*)

Before you move on

What does the *sa-* in सदा carry? (Together, whole, the same.)
Which English word shares it? (*Same*.)

17.8 कालशब्दाः (kāla-śabdāḥ) — where a time word stands

You have five time words. This is where they go.

You’ll want to know: कालशब्दाः

Three of this chapter’s words — अद्य, ह्यः, सदा — are not nouns at all. Look for an *-am* or *-aḥ* or *-iḥ* on them and you will not find one. They attach to a sentence, say *when*, and keep the same shape wherever they land.

Sanskrit lets them stand almost anywhere. सदा पठति and पठति सदा both say “he always reads,” and neither is more correct than the other. You have been given a lot of attention to endings, and this is the payoff: they are carrying the work that word order carries in English.

The two that *are* nouns, दिनम् and रात्रिः, behave like any other noun, and take adjectives in front of them the way गृहम् does.

What you’ve built

You can now say when something happens, and you have met the single most important fact about Sanskrit word order: it is loose because the endings are strict.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “he always reads,” both ways round
- “a good day” — *uttama dinam*
- which three of the five never change

Before you move on

Which three words never change their ending? (अद्य, ह्यः, सदा.) Why can Sanskrit move words around freely? (Because the endings carry the grammar, not the order.)

Chapter 18

Asking — Every Question Begins with K

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask when, why, how many and from where in Sanskrit, and I can see that every question word is built on one stem.

Complete SA-C18-k-words and demonstrate the chapter promise.

18.1 कदा (kadā) — when?

You can say when. This chapter is for asking when.

You'll want to know: कदा

कदा (kadā) — “when?”

Set it beside the word you just learned and something jumps out:

सदा — always. कदा — when?

One letter apart, and the difference is the whole of this chapter. Sanskrit builds its question words on क् (k-), and it builds several of its answering words on स् (s-) or त् (t-). Ask with k-, answer with t-.

What you've built

Your first k- word met deliberately. There are four more in this chapter, and by the end the pattern will be doing the remembering for you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kadā* — “when?”
- it against its answer — *kadā, sadā*
- “when does he read?” — *kadā paṭhati*

Before you move on

What single letter separates कदा from सदा? (*K-* against *s-*.) Which letter opens a Sanskrit question word? (*K-*.)

18.2 किमर्थम् (kimartham) — why?

The hardest question in any language, and Sanskrit builds it out of two words you can almost read.

You’ll want to know: किमर्थम्

किमर्थम् (*kimartham*) — “why?”

It is transparently two pieces:

किम् (“what”) + अर्थम् (“for the purpose of, for the sake of”)

— literally “**for what purpose?**” Sanskrit does not have a single opaque word for *why*; it asks what the aim was, and lets the shape of the question show.

अर्थ (*artha*) is worth keeping on its own. It means purpose, aim, meaning, and wealth all at once, and it is one of the four goals of life in the classical scheme. A word for “why” built on it is asking, quite seriously, *what is this for?*

What you’ve built

A compound you can take apart on sight — and *k-* again at the front, exactly as promised.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kimartham* — “why?”
- its two pieces — *kim* and *artham*
- what अर्थ means on its own (purpose, aim, meaning, wealth)

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of किमर्थम्? (*Kim*, “what,” and *artham*, “for the purpose of.”) What does अर्थ mean by itself? (Purpose, aim, meaning, wealth.)

18.3 कति (kati) — how many?

You can count to five. This asks how many there are.

You’ll want to know: कति

कति (*kati*) — “how many?”

K- at the front again, and this time the relatives are visible outside Sanskrit too: Latin *quot*, “how many,” is the same word, and it survives in English **quota** and **quotient** — both of them, at root, answers to *how many*.

Pair it with the numbers you already have and it is immediately useful: कति गृहाणि, “how many houses?”

What you’ve built

Three *k-* words now, and one of them has handed you two English words as a souvenir.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kati* — “how many?”
- its Latin cousin — *quot*
- the two English words built on it (*quota*, *quotient*)

Before you move on

Which Latin word is कति related to? (*Quot.*) Which English words carry it? (*Quota, quotient.*)

18.4 कुतः (kutaḥ) — from where?

You can ask where something is. This asks where it came from.

You'll want to know: कुतः

कुतः (*kutaḥ*) — “from where? whence?”

You already have कुत्र (*kutra*), “where?” Now compare the two endings:

कुत्र — where, at what place. कुतः — from where, out of what place.

The *-tas* ending means “from,” and Sanskrit uses it far beyond question words. English once had this distinction too and has mostly lost it: *where* against *whence*, *there* against *thence*. Sanskrit keeps them working.

What you've built

Four *k-* words, and a distinction English has let go of. When a language keeps a difference yours has dropped, that is worth noticing rather than flattening.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kutaḥ* — “from where?”
- it against *kutra*, “where?”
- the English pair that used to make the same distinction (*where*, *whence*)

Before you move on

What does the *-tas* ending add? (“From.”) Which English word matches कुतः? (*Whence.*)

18.5 क-शब्दाः (ka-śabdāḥ) — every question begins with k-

Every question word you have met, gathered in one place, so you can see they are one word wearing different endings.

You'll want to know: क-शब्दाः

Line them up:

कः — who? · किम् — what? · कुत्र — where? · कुतः — from where? · कथम् — how? · कदा — when? · कति — how many?

Seven questions, one opening consonant. Sanskrit builds them all on a single interrogative stem क- and distinguishes them entirely by what follows.

The family reaches much further than Sanskrit. That *k-* is the ancestral **k^w-*, which became Latin *qu-* — *quis*, *quid*, *quando*, *quot* — and, by a regular sound change, Germanic *hw-*, which English writes **wh-**: *who*, *what*, *where*, *when*, *how*.

So कः and *who*, किम् and *what*, कदा and *when* are not lookalikes. They are the same words, separated by five thousand years.

What you've built

You now hold every basic question in Sanskrit, and one fact that makes them nearly impossible to forget: if it opens with क्, it is asking you something.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all seven, in a row
- the English *wh-* word for each
- what the *k-* became in Latin (*qu-*)

Before you move on

What do all seven share? (An opening क्.) What did that consonant become in Latin, and in English? (*Qu-*, and *wh-*.) Are कः and *who* related? (Yes — the same word, five thousand years apart.)

Chapter 19

Counting On — Six to Ten, and What They Prove

Modes: ⇄ voice (6) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count to ten in Sanskrit and explain why the numbers are evidence that Sanskrit, Latin and English are related.

Complete SA-C19-number-family and demonstrate the chapter promise.

19.1 षट् (ṣaṭ) — six

You can count to five. The next five are where the family resemblance becomes impossible to miss.

You'll want to know: षट्

षट् (ṣaṭ) — “six.”

Say it beside its relatives: Latin *sex*, Greek *hex*, English *six*. The Sanskrit form looks least like the others on the page, because ṣ is a retroflex sound English has no letter for — but it is the same word.

This chapter is the clearest evidence a beginner can be shown that Sanskrit, Latin and English are relatives rather than neighbours. The numbers are the proof, because numbers are borrowed less often than almost anything else.

What you've built

One number, and a claim you are about to see supported four more times.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ṣaṭ* — “six”
- its Latin and English cousins — *sex*, *six*
- one to six, in order

Before you move on

What are the Latin and English cousins of षट्? (*Sex* and *six*.) Why are numbers good evidence of relatedness? (They are rarely borrowed.)

19.2 सप्त (sapta) — seven

The second of the five, and the resemblance is now visible without squinting.

You'll want to know: सप्त

सप्त (*sapta*) — “seven.”

Latin *septem*. Greek *hepta*. English *seven*. Line them up and the shape is one shape: *s-p-t* under the vowels, with Greek turning the initial *s* into a rough breathing and English softening the *-pt-* to *-v-*.

The Sanskrit form is not the ancestor of the others — that is a common misunderstanding worth heading off. All four descend from a **shared parent nobody wrote down**. Sanskrit is simply an old, well-recorded cousin.

What you've built

Two numbers, and one correction that matters: Sanskrit is a cousin of Latin and English, not their ancestor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sapta* — “seven”
- *septem*, *hepta*, *seven* after it
- whether Sanskrit is the parent of English (it is not — a cousin)

Before you move on

Which consonants survive across all four forms? (*S*, *p*, *t*.) Is Sanskrit the ancestor of Latin and English? (No — a cousin; the parent was never written down.)

19.3 अष्ट (aṣṭa) — eight

Eight — and a word that still shows its seams.

You’ll want to know: अष्ट

अष्ट (*aṣṭa*) — “eight.”

Latin *octo*, Greek *okto*, English *eight* (whose silent *-gh-* is the ghost of a consonant that used to be pronounced).

There is an old and appealing observation about this one: the form behaves like a **dual** — the grammatical number Sanskrit uses for things that come in pairs. Eight would then be “two fours,” counted on two hands with the thumbs left out. It is a hypothesis rather than a settled fact, and it is offered here as one, because a good story is not the same as evidence.

What you’ve built

Three numbers, and a reminder about how to hold an etymology that is attractive but unproven: enjoy it, label it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aṣṭa* — “eight”

- *octo*, *eight*
- whether the “two fours” story is fact or hypothesis

Before you move on

Which English word is अष्ट related to, and what is its silent *-gh*? (*Eight* — the ghost of a pronounced consonant.) Is the “two fours” reading established? (No — a hypothesis.)

19.4 नवन् (navan) — nine

Nine — and a word you have met before meaning something else entirely.

You’ll want to know: नवन्

नवन् (*navan*) — “nine.” Latin *novem*, English *nine*.

Now the catch, and it is worth meeting deliberately rather than tripping over. You already learned नव (*nava*) meaning “**new**.” They look nearly identical and they are **not** the same word:

नव (*nava*) — new. Latin *novus*, English *new*. नवन् (*navan*) — nine. Latin *novem*, English *nine*.

Two distinct ancient words that drifted into near-identical shapes. Latin kept them apart (*novus* against *novem*) and so did English (*new* against *nine*). Sanskrit did not, quite — and a reader who assumes one word here will misread sentences.

What you’ve built

A pair of look-alikes, separated on purpose. This is the most common way to get a word wrong: assuming that similar shape means shared origin.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *navan* — “nine”
- *nava* — “new”

- which Latin word goes with each (*novem*, *novus*)

Before you move on

What is the difference between नव and नवन्? (New, and nine.) Are they the same word? (No — two ancient words that drifted into similar shapes.)

19.5 दश (daśa) — ten

The last of them, and the one hiding inside words you use every week.

You'll want to know: दश

दश (*daśa*) — “ten.” Latin *decem*, Greek *deka*, English *ten*.

The Latin form is the one that pays. *Decem* gives English **decimal**, **decade**, **December** — which was the *tenth* month before the calendar was rearranged and left the name stranded two months out of place.

So दश, *decem* and *ten* are one word, and a fossil of the old counting survives in the name of the wrong month.

What you've built

You can count to ten in Sanskrit, and every one of the second five arrived attached to a word you already knew.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *daśa* — “ten”
- one to ten, straight through
- why December is misnamed

Before you move on

Which English words carry Latin *decem*? (*Decimal*, *decade*, *December*.) Why is December's name wrong? (It was the tenth)

month before the calendar changed.)

19.6 सङ्ख्याशब्दाः (saṅkhyā-śabdāḥ) — the numbers, and what they prove

Ten numbers is enough to see something no single word could have shown you.

You'll want to know: सङ्ख्याशब्दाः

Set the ten side by side with Latin and English and the correspondence is not occasional — it is regular:

एक one · द्व two · त्रि three · चतुर् four · पञ्च five · षट् six · सप्त seven
· अष्ट eight · नवन् nine · दश ten

Where Sanskrit has *p*, Latin often has *p* and English often has *f*. Where Sanskrit has *d*, English often has *t*. Those are not impressions; they are **regular correspondences**, and their regularity is what turned the study of language into something testable in the nineteenth century.

That is what the numbers prove. Not that these languages borrowed from each other, but that they inherited from something older — and that the inheritance followed rules consistent enough to predict.

What you've built

You can count to ten, and you have seen the single piece of evidence that founded historical linguistics.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all ten, in order
- the English cousin of each
- what the regularity proves — inheritance, not borrowing

Before you move on

What makes the correspondences evidence rather than coincidence? (They are regular.) What do they show? (Common inheritance from an older language.)

Chapter 20

People — and the Four Noun Endings

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 👁️ eyes (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five kinds of person in Sanskrit and hear which of the four noun families each one belongs to.

Complete SA-C20-people and demonstrate the chapter promise.

20.1 नरः (naraḥ) — man, person

Places, times, numbers — and nobody in them yet. This chapter supplies the people.

You'll want to know: नरः

नरः (naraḥ) — “man, person, human being.”

It is old enough to sit inside names you may already have heard: *Narasimha*, “man-lion,” and *Nārāyaṇa*. Its Greek cousin is *anēr* (genitive *andros*), the element inside English **android** and the name **Andrew**.

Ending in *-aḥ*, so you already know its family: masculine, like ग्रामः and मार्गः.

What you've built

Your first person, and the ending told you what it was before the lesson did.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *narah* — “man”
- “a good man” — *uttama nah*
- the English word built on its Greek cousin (*android*)

Before you move on

Which family does नरः belong to, and how do you know? (Masculine — the -*ah*.) Which English words carry its Greek cousin? (*Android*, *Andrew*.)

20.2 नारी (nārī) — woman

And the ending you have not met yet.

You’ll want to know: नारी

नारी (*nārī*) — “woman.”

Look at it beside नरः and the relationship is visible: the same *nar-*, a different ending. Sanskrit builds a great many feminine nouns with a long -ई (*-ī*), and this is your first.

So the map has grown again: *-am* neuter, *-ah* masculine, *-ih* a third family, and now *-ī* feminine. Four endings, four families. You are not being asked to produce them — only to hear them, because everything Sanskrit does with a noun starts here.

What you’ve built

A second person and a fourth ending. The system is bigger than two, exactly as the night lesson warned.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nārī* — “woman”

- it against *narah*, and name the shared piece
- the four endings you have now met

Before you move on

What do नरः and नारी share? (The stem *nar-*.) Which ending marks this feminine? (Long *-ī*.)

20.3 बालः (bālah) — child, boy

The youngest person in the chapter.

You'll want to know: बालः

बालः (*bālah*) — “child, boy, a young one.”

It carries a sense wider than English “boy”: *bāla* is anything in its early state, and the word is used of young animals and of the newly-risen sun as readily as of a child. The feminine बाला (*bālā*) is a girl.

Notice that the feminine here is *-ā*, not the *-ī* you just met. Sanskrit has more than one way to make a feminine, which is inconvenient and true.

What you've built

Three people, and an honest complication: the feminine endings are not a single rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bālah* — “child”
- the feminine — *bālā*
- the two different feminine endings you have now seen

Before you move on

What does बाल cover beyond “boy”? (Anything in its early state.) Which two feminine endings have you met? (*-ī* and *-ā*.)

20.4 वृद्धः (vr̥ddhaḥ) — an old person, an elder

The oldest person in the chapter — and a word that is careful in a way English is not.

You'll want to know: वृद्धः

वृद्धः (vr̥ddhaḥ) — “an old person, an elder, one who has grown.”

You already have पुरातन (purātana), which was glossed “old — of a thing, not of a person.” Here is the other half of that pair, and the distinction is the point.

पुरातन is old as in *ancient*: it has existed a long time. वृद्धः is old as in *grown*: from the root √वृध् (vr̥dh), “to grow, increase.” An elder is not a thing that has lasted; an elder is someone who has grown.

English flattens both into “old” and loses the compliment.

What you've built

Four people — and a pair of words that shows why a one-word gloss is sometimes a lie by omission.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- vr̥ddhaḥ — “an elder”
- which of purātana and vr̥ddha you would use for a temple
- what √वृध् means (to grow)

Before you move on

What root is वृद्धः built on? (√वृध्, “to grow.”) Which word would you use of an old building? (Purātana.)

20.5 जनः (janaḥ) — people, folk

All of them at once.

You'll want to know: जनः

जनः (*janah*) — “people, folk, a person, a race.”

From the root √जन् (*jan*), “to be born, to beget” — the same root behind *janma*, “birth.” Its Latin cousin is *gens* (“clan, people”) and *genus*, and through them English has **genus**, **gene**, **generate**, **genesis** and **nation** (from *natio*, “a being born”).

So जनः does not mean a crowd. It means *those who were born* — kinship rather than quantity.

What you've built

Five people: man, woman, child, elder, folk — and every one of them arrived with its ending legible and a European cousin attached.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *janah* — “people”
- three English words from its Latin cousin
- all five people, in order

Before you move on

What does √जन् mean? (To be born.) Which English words share it? (*Gene*, *genesis*, *generate*, *nation*.)

Chapter 21

More Everyday Verbs

Modes: ⇌ voice (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that someone drinks, laughs, stands and remembers in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C21-remember and say all four verbs in order.

21.1 नृत्यति (nṛtyati) — he, she or it dances

A short run of everyday verbs, one at a time.

You'll want to know: नृत्यति

नृत्यति (nṛtyati) — “he, she or it dances”.

From √नृत् (nṛt), ‘to dance’. It gives nṛtya, the danced half of the classical performing arts, as against nāṭya, the acted half — a distinction Sanskrit draws that English does not.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- nṛtyati
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway

Before you move on

What does नृत्यति mean? (“he, she or it dances”.) Say it once more.

21.2 हसति (hasati) — he, she or it laughs

Before the new one: what did *nṛtyati* mean?

You’ll want to know: हसति

हसति (*hasati*) — “he, she or it laughs”.

From √हस् (*has*). It is the word inside *hāsyā*, the comic mood in the classical theory of drama — one of the nine *rasas*, so laughter here is a category of art, not only a noise.

What you’ve built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hasati*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *nṛtyati*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does हसति mean? (“he, she or it laughs”.) Say it once more.

21.3 तिष्ठति (tiṣṭhati) — he, she or it stands

Before the new one: what did *hasati* mean?

You'll want to know: तिष्ठति

तिष्ठति (*tiṣṭhati*) — “he, she or it stands”.

From √स्था (*sthā*), ‘to stand’ — the same root as Latin *stare* and English **stand, stable, status**. The *ti-* at the front is reduplication again, exactly as in *nṛtyati*.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tiṣṭhati*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *hasati*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does तिष्ठति mean? (“he, she or it stands”.) Say it once more.

21.4 स्मरति (*smarati*) — he, she or it remembers

Before the new one: what did *tiṣṭhati* mean?

You'll want to know: स्मरति

स्मरति (*smarati*) — “he, she or it remembers”.

From √स्मृ (*smṛ*), ‘to remember’. It gives *smṛti*, ‘that which is remembered’ — the name for a whole class of texts, as against *śruti*, ‘that which is heard’. A memory word doing bibliographic work.

What you've built

One more everyday action. That closes the run: four everyday actions, each met on its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *smarati*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *tiṣṭhati*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does स्मरति mean? (“he, she or it remembers”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 22

Verbs of Mind and Motion

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 4 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that someone hears, leads, plays and asks in Sanskrit, and name the root behind each.

Complete SA-C22-burn and say all four verbs in order.

22.1 शृणोति (śṛṇoti) — he, she or it hears

A short run of everyday verbs, one at a time.

You'll want to know: शृणोति

शृणोति (śṛṇoti) — “he, she or it hears”.

From शृ (śru), ‘to hear’ — the same root as Latin *clueo* and Greek *kleos*, ‘fame’, which is what gets heard about you. It gives श्रुति (śruti), ‘that which is heard’: the Vedas, as against स्मृति, ‘that which is remembered’.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- शृणोति
- it once more, slowly

Before you move on

What does शृणोति mean? (“he, she or it hears”.) Say it once more.

22.2 नयति (nayati) — he, she or it leads

Before the new one: what did *śṛṇoti* mean?

You’ll want to know: नयति

नयति (*nayati*) — “he, she or it leads”.

From √नी (*nī*), ‘to lead’. It is inside *netṛ*, ‘leader’, and *naya*, ‘polity’ — the art of leading people, which Sanskrit treats as a subject with a name.

What you’ve built

One more everyday action. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nayati*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *śṛṇoti*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does नयति mean? (“he, she or it leads”.) Say it once more.

22.3 क्रीडति (krīḍati) — he, she or it plays

Before the new one: what did *nayati* mean?

You'll want to know: क्रीडति

क्रीडति (*krīḍati*) — “he, she or it plays”.

From √क्रीड् (*krīḍ*). The noun *krīḍā* covers a child's game, a sport, and divine play — *līlā*'s plainer cousin — so the word does not separate the trivial from the cosmic.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *krīḍati*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *nayati*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does क्रीडति mean? (“he, she or it plays”.) Say it once more.

22.4 दहति (dahati) — he, she or it burns

Before the new one: what did *krīḍati* mean?

You'll want to know: दहति

दहति (*dahati*) — “he, she or it burns”.

From √दह् (*dah*), and its distant English cousin is **day** — by way of a Germanic word for the burning warmth of the sky, not the daylight itself.

What you've built

That closes the run: four more actions, each met on its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dahati*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *krīḍati*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does दहति mean? (“he, she or it burns”.) Say it once more.

22.5 ढ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ज · श · छ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ढ

ढ — ḍa.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not ḍ, it is **ḍa**.

What it is made of:

- a descending stem joined to an upper-left loop and broad open lower bowl
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has ढ somewhere inside it:

- क्रीडति *krīḍati* — he, she or it plays

Writing: ङ

- **1.** start at the stem's headline junction, descend, turn left across the upper shoulder, sweep counterclockwise around the upper-left loop, then continue clockwise around the broad lower bowl to its open up-left tip without lifting
- **2.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 1. The pen comes up 1 times and no more.

verified two-stroke teaching form fitted to the bundled printed outline

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Opiaterein, 'Deva-ङ-order.gif', strokes 1–2, Wikimedia Commons, 10 May 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ङ in it
क्रीडति
- *Trace it:* ङ three times, saying *ḍa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ङ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ङ? What sound does it carry? (*ḍa.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 23

The Four Oldest Kinship Words

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 4 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a father, a mother, a son and a daughter in Sanskrit, and name a cousin of each outside India.

Complete SA-C23-daughter and say all four words in order.

23.1 पिता (pitā) — father

Before the new one: what did *dahati* mean?

You'll want to know: पिता

पिता (*pitā*) — “father”.

The stem behind it is पितृ (*pitṛ-*), and its family reaches further than that of any word you have met: Latin *pater*, Greek *patēr*, Gothic *fadar*, Old Irish *athir*, English *father*. The people lesson laid out four noun endings; this is a fifth family, the *-r* stems, and most of Sanskrit's kinship words live in it.

What you've built

The first of the four oldest words in the family. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pitā*

- it once more, slowly
- it beside *pater* and *father*, and hear the one word underneath

Before you move on

What does पिता mean? (“father”.) Say it once more.

23.2 माता (mātā) — mother

Before the new one: what did *pitā* mean?

You’ll want to know: माता

माता (*mātā*) — “mother”.

The stem is मातृ (*mātr-*) — the same *-r* family as पिता, and the same long reach: Latin *māter*, Greek *mētēr*, Old English *mōdor*, English *mother*, Russian *mat*. Put the father-word into the dual and Sanskrit gives you *pitarau*, ‘the two parents’, with the mother folded silently inside it.

What you’ve built

Two of the four, and one ending family carrying both.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mātā*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *pitā*, and name the ending they share

Before you move on

What does माता mean? (“mother”.) Say it once more.

23.3 सूनुः (sūnuḥ) — son

Before the new one: what did *mātā* mean?

You'll want to know: सूनुः

सूनुः (*sūnuḥ*) — “son”.

From √सू (*sū*), ‘to bring forth, to give birth’ — so the word means the one who was brought forth. Its cousins are Gothic *sunus*, Old English *sunu*, English *son*, Lithuanian *sunus*, Russian *syn*. Sanskrit’s other son-word, *putraḥ*, is far commoner in the texts and has no such relatives; this quieter one is the inherited word.

What you’ve built

Three of the four, and a root that names a person by what happened to them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sūnuḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- it beside *sunus* and *son*, and hear the one word underneath

Before you move on

What does सूनुः mean? (“son”.) Say it once more.

23.4 दुहिता (*duhitā*) — daughter

Before the new one: what did *sūnuḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: दुहिता

दुहिता (*duhitā*) — “daughter”.

Back to the *-r* family: the stem is दुहित् (*duhitr-*), standing beside पिता and माता. Its cousins are English *daughter*, Greek *thugatēr*, Gothic *dauhtar*, Persian *duxtār*. Indian tradition read it as ‘the one who milks’, from √दुह् (*duh*) — a tidy story about a daughter’s work in the house, which comparative linguists do not accept, because the cousins are older than the pun. Keep the story, and keep the fact that it is one.

What you've built

That closes the run: father, mother, son, daughter — the four words the family kept longest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *duhitā*
- it once more, slowly
- all four in order, and name the ending three of them share

Before you move on

What does दुहिता mean? (“daughter”.) Say it once more.

23.5 ँ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: श · छ · ड.

Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ँ

ँ — *ū*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a longer hook below the consonant.

Worked through: न + ँ = नू — *nū*.

You already say these, and every one of them has ँ somewhere inside it:

- सूनः *sūnuḥ* — son

Writing: ॠ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ॠ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ॠ in it

सूतः

- *Trace it:* ॠ three times, saying $\bar{u}$ as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ॠ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ॠ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts $\bar{u}$ on; takes the built-in a off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 24

Things You Ask For

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) ✍️ pen (2) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 3 of 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five everyday things I might ask someone for in Sanskrit, and say which noun family each one belongs to.

Complete SA-C24-lamp and demonstrate the chapter promise.

24.1 जलम् (jalam) — water (the stuff, not the drink)

Before the new word: what did *duhitā* mean?

You'll want to know: जलम्

जलम् (*jalam*) — “water (the stuff, not the drink)”.

You already have one water-word: पानीयम् (*pānīyam*), which names water by what you do with it — “the thing to be drunk”. जलम् names the stuff. Rain is *jalam*; the river is full of *jalam*; nobody offers you a cup of it in that word.

Sanskrit keeps several words here — *jalam*, *pānīyam*, *udakam*, *āpah* — and a poet chooses between them the way an English poet chooses between water, drink, and the waters. The ending puts जलम् in the neuter family you met with अन्नम् and गृहम्: -अम्.

What you've built

Two words for water now, and a reason to prefer one over the other.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *jalām*
- it once more, slowly
- *pānīyam*, then *jalām*, and say which one you would ask for at a table

Before you move on

What does जलम् mean? (“water (the stuff, not the drink).”) Say it once more.

24.2 ओदनः (odanaḥ) — cooked rice

Before the new word: what did *jalām* name, and what did *pānīyam* name?

You’ll want to know: ओदनः

ओदनः (*odanaḥ*) — “cooked rice”.

अन्नम् (*annam*) was food in general — “the eaten thing”. ओदनः is narrower and warmer: the grain after it has met the water. Cooked rice, on a plate, now.

The traditional derivation takes it from a root meaning “to wet”, which reads the word as *grain that has been moistened* — a description of cooking rather than of rice. Its ending -अः puts it in the masculine family beside मार्गः and ग्रामः, so ओदनः and अन्नम् sit in different families while naming the same meal.

What you’ve built

A general word for food, and a particular thing on the plate.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *odanaḥ*

- it once more, slowly
- *annam*, then *odanah*, and name the ending each one carries

Before you move on

What does ओदनः mean? (“cooked rice”.) Say it once more.

24.3 फलम् (phalam) — fruit (and the result of anything)

Before the new word: what did *odanah* mean?

You’ll want to know: फलम्

फलम् (*phalam*) — “fruit (and the result of anything)”.

फलम् is the fruit on the tree. It is also, in the same breath and with no metaphor felt, the fruit of an action — the result, the reward, the yield. A Sanskrit sentence about the *phalam* of your work is not reaching for a poetic image; it has one word where English has two.

The root behind it means “to burst, to bear fruit”, which is the fruit split open at the moment it is ripe. Neuter -अम्, like जलम् and अन्नम् before it.

What you’ve built

A word that carries an orchard and a consequence at once.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *phalam*
- it once more, slowly
- *phalam*, and then *jalam* and *phalam* together, naming the ending they share

Before you move on

What does फलम् mean? (“fruit (and the result of anything)”). Say it once more.

24.4 ओ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: छ · ड · ू.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ओ

ओ — o.

It is an **independent vowel**: the full-size letter a vowel wears when it opens a word and has no consonant to lean on. Inside a word the same vowel is written as a small sign instead.

What it is made of:

- the joined upper and lower bowls of अ
- a separately swept middle shoulder
- the inner stem
- the trailing stem
- a separate upper arc
- the top shirorekḥā

You already say these, and every one of them has ओ somewhere inside it:

- ओदनः *odanaḥ* — cooked rice

Writing: ओ

- 1. curve right around the upper bowl and continue down and around the lower bowl without lifting
- 2. lift and sweep the middle shoulder right
- 3. lift and descend the inner stem
- 4. lift and descend the trailing stem
- 5. lift at the trailing stem's headline junction and sweep the upper arc upward and left
- 6. lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: 5. The pen comes up 5 times and no more.

verified modern printed teaching form; traditional and everyday handwriting may divide or simplify the curves differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Saurmandal, 'Devanagari ओ stroke order.svg', panels 1–6, Wikimedia Commons, 5 August 2023.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ओ in it
- ओदनः
- *Trace it:* ओ three times, saying *o* as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ओ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ओ? What sound does it carry? (*o*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

24.5 वस्त्रम् (vastram) — cloth, a garment

Before the new word: what did *phalam* mean — both of its meanings?

You'll want to know: वस्त्रम्

वस्त्रम् (*vastram*) — “cloth, a garment”.

You know वसामि (*vasāmi*), “I dwell”, from the root *vas*. वस्त्रम् looks like it belongs to that root and does not. Sanskrit has two roots spelled *vas*: one for dwelling, one for wearing. वसामि belongs to the first, वस्त्रम् to the second, and no amount of staring at the letters will separate them — only the meanings do.

The wearing one travelled. Latin *vestis*, and through it English *vest*, *vestment*, *invest* — which originally meant to clothe someone in the robes of an office. Neuter -अम्.

What you've built

A word that warns you: same letters, different root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vastram*
- it once more, slowly
- *vasāmi*, then *vastram*, and say which root each one belongs to

Before you move on

What does वस्त्रम् mean? (“cloth, a garment”.) Say it once more.

24.6 दीपः (dīpaḥ) — a lamp

Before the last word of this run: what did *vastram* mean, and what did *odanaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: दीपः

दीपः (*dīpaḥ*) — “a lamp”.

दीपः is a lamp — the small clay one with oil and a wick. Its root means “to blaze”, so the word names the burning rather than the vessel.

Put दीप together with a word meaning “a row” and you get *dīpāvalī*, “a row of lamps” — the festival English writes as Diwali. Masculine -अः, like ओदनः.

What you’ve built

Five things you might ask for: water, rice, fruit, cloth, a lamp.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dīpah*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, and sort them into the two noun families

Before you move on

What does दीपः mean? (“a lamp”.) Say it once more.

24.7 फ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ड · ू · ओ.
Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: फ

फ — *pha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ph*, it is **pha**.

What it is made of:

- a left stem joined through the lower bowl to a rising and retraced central stem
- a separate clockwise right arch

- the top shirorekha

You already say these, and every one of them has फ somewhere inside it:

- फलम् *phalam* — fruit

Writing: फ

- **1.** descend the left stem, curve right around the lower bowl, rise along the central side to the headline, then retrace down the central stem without lifting
- **2.** lift at the central junction and sweep clockwise over and down through the open right arch
- **3.** lift and draw the top shirorekha left-to-right

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

verified three-stroke teaching form; another learner source stages the components differently

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: JackPotte, ‘Devanagari p^h फ.gif’, strokes 1–3, Wikimedia Commons, 29 March 2009.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find फ in it

फलम्

- *Trace it:* फ three times, saying *pha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find फ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — फ? What sound does it carry? (*pha.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 25

The Hand and the Foot

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five more parts of the body in Sanskrit, and name the sound law that ties three of them to their English cousins.

Complete SA-C25-hair and demonstrate the chapter promise.

25.1 हस्तः (hastah) — hand

Before the new word: what did *dīpaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: हस्तः

हस्तः (*hastah*) — “hand”.

You have अक्षि, कर्णः, मुखम्, नासिका and हृदयम् (*akṣi, karṇah, mukham, nāsikā, hṛdayam*). हस्तः adds the hand.

Its cousins run west rather than into Europe: Avestan *zasta*, Old Persian *dasta*, and modern Persian *dast*, all “hand”. Latin went its own way with *manus* and shares nothing with this word at all — a reminder that the family tree branches, and that two languages can both be cousins of Sanskrit without being cousins of each other in any given word.

What you’ve built

A sixth part of the body, and a cousin found next door rather than in Rome.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hastah*
- it once more, slowly
- *hastah*, then *akṣi* and *hastah* together

Before you move on

What does हस्तः mean? (“hand”.) Say it once more.

25.2 पादः (pādaḥ) — foot

Before the new word: what did *hastah* mean?

You’ll want to know: पादः

पादः (*pādaḥ*) — “foot”.

पादः is one of the most travelled words in this book. Latin *pēs*, in its other forms *pedem* — whence *pedal*, *pedestrian*, *biped*. Greek *pous*, *podos* — whence *podium*, *tripod*, *octopus*, the eight-foot.

And English *foot*, which looks unlike the rest until you apply the same sound law you met at पिता and *father*: an old *p* becomes *f* in the Germanic branch. *Pādaḥ* and *foot* are the same word, worn differently. Masculine -अः, like हस्तः.

What you’ve built

A word whose cousins you can now predict rather than be told.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pādaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *pādaḥ*, then *pitā*, and name the sound law both share with their English cousins

Before you move on

What does पादः mean? (“foot”.) Say it once more.

25.3 शिरः (śiraḥ) — head

Before the new word: what did *pādaḥ* mean, and what did *hastāḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: शिरः

शिरः (*śiraḥ*) — “head”.

शिरः is the head. The old family it belongs to gathered around a sense of “head, horn”: Greek *kara*, “head”, and Latin *cerebrum*, “brain”, sit in it, and so — further out — does English *horn*.

Sanskrit has a second head-word, *mūrdhan*, for the top or the summit of a thing. शिरः is the ordinary one: the head you nod, the head you bow when you say नमस्ते.

What you’ve built

Three of five, and the bow you already knew has a body part in it now.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śiraḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *śiraḥ*, then say *namaste* and name what bends

Before you move on

What does शिरः mean? (“head”.) Say it once more.

25.4 दन्तः (dantaḥ) — tooth

Before the new word: what did *śiraḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: दन्तः

दन्तः (*dantaḥ*) — “tooth”.

दन्तः is a tooth, and its family is as secure as पादः. Latin *dens*, in its other forms *dentem* — whence *dentist*, *dental*, *trident*, the three-tooth. Greek *odous*, *odontos* — whence *mastodon*.

English *tooth* belongs here too, by the same Germanic shift that turned *p* into *f*: an old *d* becomes *t*. So दन्तः, *dens* and *tooth* are three worn copies of one word, and you have now seen the same machinery produce पिता/*father*, पादः/*foot* and दन्तः/*tooth*.

What you've built

A third demonstration of one sound law, on a word you can point at.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dantaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *dantaḥ*, then *pādaḥ*, then *pitā* — three words, one shift

Before you move on

What does दन्तः mean? (“tooth”.) Say it once more.

25.5 केशः (*keśaḥ*) — hair (of the head)

Before the last word of this run: what did *dantaḥ* mean, and what did *śiraḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: केशः

केशः (*keśaḥ*) — “hair (of the head)”.

केशः is the hair on the head — the hair that grows out of शिरः.

And here the trail stops. No secure cousin has been found for केशः outside India: scholars have proposed several and settled on none. That is worth meeting on purpose, because the last four lessons made travel look easy.

Some words have a history we can reconstruct in detail; some have one we cannot reconstruct at all. कर्णः, the ear, was the same case. Masculine -अः.

What you've built

Five more parts of the body: hand, foot, head, tooth, hair.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *keśaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, and name the one with no known cousins

Before you move on

What does केशः mean? (“hair (of the head)”). Say it once more.

Chapter 26

Naming Who Someone Is

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone’s role is in Sanskrit — teacher, student, king, guest, physician — and name the everyday meaning hiding inside two of those words.

Complete SA-C26-physician and demonstrate the chapter promise.

26.1 गुरुः (guruḥ) — a teacher, and the word for heavy

Before the new word: what did *keśaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: गुरुः

गुरुः (*guruḥ*) — “a teacher, and the word for heavy”.

गुरुः reached English on its own, so you already say it. What English lost on the way is the ordinary meaning: *guru* first of all means **heavy**. A heavy stone is *guru*; a teacher is *guru* because a teacher has weight.

The heavy-word travelled: Latin *gravis* — whence *grave*, *gravity*, *aggravate* — and Greek *barus*, whence *barometer*, the weight-measurer. So गुरुः, *gravity* and *barometer* all descend from one word for heaviness, and only Sanskrit made a person out of it.

What you’ve built

A word you already knew in English, returned to its first meaning.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *guruḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *guruḥ*, and say both of its meanings

Before you move on

What does गुरुः mean? (“a teacher, and the word for heavy”.) Say it once more.

26.2 शिष्यः (śiṣyaḥ) — a student, a disciple

Before the new word: what did *guruḥ* mean, and what did it mean before that?

You’ll want to know: शिष्यः

शिष्यः (*śiṣyaḥ*) — “a student, a disciple”.

शिष्यः stands opposite गुरुः. It is built from a root meaning “to instruct”, in a form that means *one who is to be taught* — not a person who studies, but a person who is owed teaching. The obligation points at the teacher.

English arrived at the same idea by another road: *disciple* is from Latin *discere*, “to learn”. Two languages, two independent words, one relationship. Masculine -अः, like गुरुः.

What you’ve built

The pair: the one with weight, and the one who is owed teaching.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śiṣyaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *guruḥ*, then *śiṣyaḥ*, and say which one is owed something

Before you move on

What does शिष्यः mean? (“a student, a disciple”.) Say it once more.

26.3 राजा (rājā) — a king

Before the new word: what did *śiṣyaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: राजा

राजा (*rājā*) — “a king”.

राजा is a king, and it belongs to the same -*र*-shaped family as पिता and माता — the stem is *rājan-*.

Its cousin in Rome is *rēx*, in its other forms *rēgem*: *regal*, *royal*, *regent*, *rex*. In Gaul, chieftains’ names ended in *-rēx* — Vercingetorix. English borrowed *raj* and *maharaja* back from India in the nineteenth century, so the word has now entered English twice, three thousand years apart, by two different doors.

What you’ve built

One word, two arrivals in English, with millennia between them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *rājā*
- it once more, slowly
- *rājā*, then *pitā*, and name the family both stems share

Before you move on

What does राजा mean? (“a king”.) Say it once more.

26.4 अतिथिः (atithiḥ) — a guest

Before the new word: what did *rājā* mean, and what did *guruḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: अतिथिः

अतिथिः (*atithiḥ*) — “a guest”.

अतिथिः is a guest. Tradition reads the word as *a-tithi*, “one without a date” — the visitor who arrives unannounced, on no appointed day, and must be fed anyway. Linguists prefer a root meaning “to wander” and derive it as “the wanderer”.

Keep the traditional reading; keep also the fact that it is a reading. Either way the famous line अतिथिदेवो भव — “be one to whom the guest is a god” — tells you how much weight the word carries.

What you've built

Four roles, and one of them arrives without warning.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *atithiḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *atithiḥ*, and say what the traditional reading claims

Before you move on

What does अतिथिः mean? (“a guest”.) Say it once more.

26.5 वैद्यः (vaidyaḥ) — a physician

Before the last word of this run: what did *atithiḥ* mean, and what did *śiṣyaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: वैद्यः

वैद्यः (*vaidyaḥ*) — “a physician”.

वैद्यः is a physician — literally *one who has the knowledge*, built on *vidyā*, knowledge, from a root *vid*, “to know”.

That root is one of the great travellers: Latin *vidēre*, “to see” — *video*, *evident*; Greek *idea*; English *wit*, *wise*, *wisdom*. And Sanskrit already gave

you a second knowing-verb, जानाति, from a different root altogether. Sanskrit keeps two ways of knowing apart, and वैद्यः belongs to the one that also means seeing — the doctor as the one who has looked.

What you've built

Five roles: teacher, student, king, guest, physician.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vaidyāḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, and name the two that make a pair

Before you move on

What does वैद्यः mean? (“a physician”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 27

Answering With More Than Yes

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer in Sanskrit with more than yes and no, and hear the be-verb sitting inside three of the answers.

Complete SA-C27-thus and demonstrate the chapter promise.

27.1 अस्तु (astu) — so be it, all right

Before the new word: what did *vaidyāḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: अस्तु

अस्तु (*astu*) — “so be it, all right”.

You have had आम् and न for yes and no since the first chapter, and they are blunt. अस्तु is the agreeable middle: *let it be so, all right, fine*.

It is not a new word so much as a new face on one you know. अस्ति (*asti*), “is”, was the third person of the root *as*, “to be”. अस्तु is the same verb in the commanding form: **let it be**. Sanskrit answers a request by ordering the world to comply.

What you've built

A reply softer than yes, built out of the be-verb you already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *astu*
- it once more, slowly
- *asti*, then *astu*, and say what changed between them

Before you move on

What does अस्तु mean? (“so be it, all right”.) Say it once more.

27.2 ञ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ू · ओ · ऋ. Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ञ

ञ — *ai*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Where it sits: a double stroke above the top bar.

Worked through: न + ञ = नै — *nai*.

You already say these, and every one of them has ञ somewhere inside it:

- वैद्यः *vaidyaḥ* — a physician

Writing: ञ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ञ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find ै in it

वैद्यः

- *Trace it:* ै three times, saying *ai* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ै once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ै? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *ai* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

27.3 साधु (sādhū) — well done, good

Before the new word: what did *astu* mean, and which verb was it built on?

You'll want to know: साधु

साधु (*sādhū*) — “well done, good”.

साधु is what you call out when something has been done well — *good*, *well said*, the Sanskrit *bravo*. An audience says it aloud at a concert.

Its root means “to accomplish, to reach the goal”, so the word praises a thing for having arrived where it was going. The same word, standing on its own as a noun, names a holy man: a *sādhū* is someone who has accomplished. English borrowed that sense and left the everyday one behind, exactly as it did with गुरु.

What you've built

A second borrowed word restored to its ordinary use.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sādhū*
- it once more, slowly
- *sādhū*, then *guruḥ*, and say what English kept of each

Before you move on

What does साधु mean? (“well done, good”.) Say it once more.

27.4 अलम् (alam) — enough

Before the new word: what did *sādhū* mean?

You'll want to know: अलम्

अलम् (*alam*) — “enough”.

अलम् is *enough*. Enough food, enough talking, enough of that. It is short, common, and does a lot of work for its size.

Set beside it a small word you have not been given yet and will hear constantly — *alam* can also mean *able, equal to the task*. So the same two syllables cover “that will do” and “that is up to it”, which is roughly the distance English travels between *enough* and *sufficient*. No secure cousin outside India, so this one sits with केश.

What you've built

A one-word answer, and a second word with no travel history.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *alam*

- it once more, slowly
- *alam*, then *keśaḥ*, and name what those two have in common

Before you move on

What does अलम् mean? (“enough.”) Say it once more.

27.5 सत्यम् (satyam) — true; the truth

Before the new word: what did *alam* mean, and what did *astu* mean?

You’ll want to know: सत्यम्

सत्यम् (*satyam*) — “true; the truth”.

सत्यम् answers a claim: *true*. As a noun it is *the truth*, and it is the word on the national emblem of India — *satyam eva jayate*, “truth alone conquers”.

Look at what it is made of. *Sat-* is the being-form of that same root *as* you met in अस्ति and अस्तु: *what is*. Add an ending and truth is simply **the state of being what is**. English has a cousin, well hidden: *sooth*, as in *soothsayer* — a truth-sayer — and *forsooth*.

What you’ve built

A third word from the be-verb, and truth defined as what is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *satyam*
- it once more, slowly
- *asti*, *astu*, *satyam* — three from one root, in that order

Before you move on

What does सत्यम् mean? (“true; the truth.”) Say it once more.

27.6 एवम् (evam) — thus, so

Before the last word of this run: what did *satyam* mean, and what did *sādhū* mean?

You'll want to know: एवम्

एवम् (*evam*) — “thus, so”.

एवम् means *thus, so, in this way*. On its own it answers a question: *just so*.

Its real value is that it combines. Put it in front of the first word of this run and you get एवम् अस्तु (*evam astu*) — “so be it”, the whole formula, made of two words you now own separately. That is what a small vocabulary buys: not five answers, but the joins between them.

What you've built

Five replies past yes and no: so be it, well done, enough, true, thus.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *evam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *evam astu* as one phrase

Before you move on

What does एवम् mean? (“thus, so”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 28

Taking Your Leave

Modes: 🗣 voice (5) ✍ pen (1) 🗣 Hands-free start: first 2 of 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can take my leave in Sanskrit, wish someone a good journey, and take the old farewell apart into the two words that built it.

Complete SA-C28-svasti and demonstrate the chapter promise.

28.1 इदानीम् (idānīm) — now

Before the new word: what did *evam* mean?

You'll want to know: इदानीम्

इदानीम् (*idānīm*) — “now”.

इदानीम् is *now*. It belongs with सदा, अद्य and ह्यः — always, today, yesterday — and it is the sharpest of them: not this day, this moment.

It is built on the near-pointing stem you met with एतत्, “this one”. The pointing system runs *a-* / *t-* / *k-*, and इदानीम् is the near end of it applied to time rather than to place: *this-time*. गच्छामि इदानीम् — “I am going now” — is a way to take your leave that reuses the verb you learned for exactly that purpose.

What you've built

A time word built out of the pointing system, and a way to leave.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *idānīm*
- it once more, slowly
- *idānīm*, then *gacchāmi idānīm* as one phrase

Before you move on

What does इदानीम् mean? (“now”.) Say it once more.

28.2 परश्चः (paraśvaḥ) — the day after tomorrow

Before the new word: what did *idānīm* mean?

You’ll want to know: परश्चः

परश्चः (*paraśvaḥ*) — “the day after tomorrow”.

You have श्चः (*śvaḥ*), “tomorrow”. परश्चः is *para* + *śvaḥ*: the further tomorrow, the day after it.

English needs four words for this and Sanskrit needs one, because *para* — “beyond, further” — can be bolted onto the front of a time word. The same trick runs backwards from ह्यः, yesterday, to give the day before it. So this is not really a new word to memorise; it is one you can assemble, which is the cheapest kind of vocabulary there is.

What you’ve built

A word you could have built yourself out of two you had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paraśvaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *śvaḥ*, then *paraśvaḥ*, and say what *para* contributes

Before you move on

What does परश्च mean? (“the day after tomorrow”.) Say it once more.

28.3 इ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one, the ones you have already met: ओ · फ · ै. Say what each of them does.

One character this time. One only — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: इ

इ — *i*.

It is an **independent vowel**: the full-size letter a vowel wears when it opens a word and has no consonant to lean on. Inside a word the same vowel is written as a small sign instead.

What it is made of:

- a descending upright joined to an upper bowl
- a lower bowl and diagonal tail in the same run
- the top shirorekhā

You already say these, and every one of them has इ somewhere inside it:

- इदानीम् *idānīm* — now

Writing: इ

- **1.** descend the upright from the headline, turn left around the upper bowl, sweep right through the waist and around the lower bowl, then finish down-right through the tail without lifting
- **2.** lift and draw the top shirorekhā left-to-right

Pen lifts: **1.** The pen comes up 1 times and no more.

verified modern printed teaching form; everyday handwriting may simplify the curves

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Saurmandal, ‘Devanagari इ stroke order.svg’, panels 1–2, Wikimedia Commons, 5 August 2023.

Your turn

- *Look:* at this, and find इ in it

इदानीम्

- *Trace it:* इ three times, saying *i* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find इ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — इ? What sound does it carry? (*i*.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

28.4 यात्रा (yātrā) — a journey

Before the new word: what did *paraśvah* mean, and what did *śvah* mean?

You’ll want to know: यात्रा

यात्रा (yātrā) — “a journey”.

यात्रा is a journey — a going, and by long custom a going somewhere holy. Modern Indian languages kept it whole: a *yatra* is a pilgrimage.

It comes from a root *yā*, “to go”, which is not the root behind गच्छति. Sanskrit keeps several going-verbs apart, and this one leans toward setting out and travelling rather than the plain act of moving. Feminine, ending in -आ, like माता and नारी.

What you’ve built

A second going-root, and a noun made from it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *yātrā*
- it once more, slowly
- *gacchati*, then *yātrā*, and say which one sounds like setting out

Before you move on

What does यात्रा mean? (“a journey”.) Say it once more.

28.5 शुभम् (śubham) — good, auspicious

Before the new word: what did *yātrā* mean?

You’ll want to know: शुभम्

शुभम् (*śubham*) — “good, auspicious”.

You have उत्तम (*uttama*) for good in the sense of best. शुभम् is good in the sense of *auspicious* — bright, lucky, well-omened. Its root means “to shine, to be beautiful”, so the word praises a thing for looking well rather than for being best.

It is a wishing word, and it goes in front of what you wish for. शुभा यात्रा — a good journey. शुभा रात्रिः — a good night. Both halves are already yours.

What you’ve built

A wish you can attach to a journey or to a night.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śubham*
- it once more, slowly
- *śubhā yātrā*, then *śubhā rātriḥ*

Before you move on

What does शुभम् mean? (“good, auspicious”.) Say it once more.

28.6 स्वस्ति (svasti) — well-being (may it go well)

Before the last word of this run: what did *śubham* mean, and what did *idānīm* mean?

You’ll want to know: स्वस्ति

स्वस्ति (*svasti*) — “well-being (may it go well)”.

स्वस्ति is the oldest farewell in this book, and you can take it apart with what you already have. *Su-* means “well” — it is the *su-* inside स्वागतम्, “well-come”. *Asti* means “is”. So स्वस्ति is, exactly, **it is well** — said as a wish over someone leaving.

Add the little ending *-ka* and you have *svastika*, “the mark of well-being”, a good-luck sign that was drawn on doorways for thousands of years before the twentieth century took it and made it unusable in the West. The word is not the thing; but the word means what it means.

What you’ve built

Five ways to leave: now, the day after tomorrow, a journey, a good wish, and well-being itself.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *svasti*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then take *svasti* apart into its two pieces

Before you move on

What does स्वस्ति mean? (“well-being (may it go well)”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 29

Courtesy Words

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can be polite in Sanskrit — please, pardon, a bow, a favour — and say what is inside the thank-you I learned on the first day.

Complete SA-C29-fortunate and demonstrate the chapter promise.

29.1 कृपया (kṛpayā) — please

Before the new word: what did *svasti* mean, and what were its two pieces?

You’ll want to know: कृपया

कृपया (*kṛpayā*) — “please”.

कृपया is *please*, and like most polite words in most languages it is not really a word for “please” at all. It is the noun *kṛpā*, “compassion, kindness”, put into the case that means *by means of*. You are saying **by your kindness**.

English does the same thing and hides it just as well: *please* was once *if it please you*. Two languages, two buried sentences, one small polite noise.

What you’ve built

A polite word with a whole clause folded inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kṛpayā*
- it once more, slowly
- *kṛpayā*, and say what it literally claims

Before you move on

What does कृपया mean? (“please”.) Say it once more.

29.2 क्षम्यताम् (kṣamyatām) — pardon me; let it be forgiven

Before the new word: what did *kṛpayā* literally claim?

You’ll want to know: क्षम्यताम्

क्षम्यताम् (*kṣamyatām*) — “pardon me; let it be forgiven”.

क्षम्यताम् is the apology. It is longer than *sorry* and it is doing more work: the root means “to be patient, to bear with, to forgive”, and the form is a command addressed to nobody in particular. *Let it be forgiven.*

Notice that Sanskrit has now given you three of these impersonal commands: अस्तु, “let it be”, क्षम्यताम्, “let it be forgiven”, and स्वस्ति, “may it be well”. A polite language often prefers to leave the person out.

What you’ve built

An apology that never names who should do the forgiving.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kṣamyatām*
- it once more, slowly
- *astu*, then *kṣamyatām*, and say what both leave out

Before you move on

What does क्षम्यताम् mean? (“pardon me; let it be forgiven”.) Say it once more.

29.3 प्रणामः (praṇāmaḥ) — a bow, a respectful salutation

Before the new word: what did *kṣamyatām* mean?

You’ll want to know: प्रणामः

प्रणामः (*praṇāmaḥ*) — “a bow, a respectful salutation”.

प्रणामः is a bow — the act, named as a thing. It is *pra* + *nam*, “to bend forward”.

And you have met that *nam* twice already without being told. नमस्ते is *namas* + *te*, “a bow to you”. नमस्कारः is *namas* + *kāra*, “the making of a bow”. Now प्रणामः the same bending root, a third time, with a prefix. Three of the first words in this book turn out to be one gesture described three ways.

What you’ve built

A root you had used twice, finally named.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *praṇāmaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *namaste*, *namaskāraḥ*, *praṇāmaḥ* — and name what all three share

Before you move on

What does प्रणामः mean? (“a bow, a respectful salutation”.) Say it once more.

29.4 उपकारः (upakārah) — a favour, a good turn

Before the new word: what did *praṇāmaḥ* mean, and which root was inside it?

You'll want to know: उपकारः

उपकारः (*upakārah*) — “a favour, a good turn”.

उपकारः is a favour — something done for someone. Take it apart: *upa*, “near, toward”, plus *kāra*, “a doing”, from the root behind करोमि, “I do”.

So a favour is *a doing-toward*. And you have already seen *kāra* once, in नमस्कारः, “the making of a bow” — the same piece, in a word you have said since the first chapter. Prefixes and pieces are how Sanskrit builds, and by now you can watch it happen.

What you've built

A second word built from the doing-root you already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *upakārah*
- it once more, slowly
- *karomi*, then *namaskārah*, then *upakārah*

Before you move on

What does उपकारः mean? (“a favour, a good turn”.) Say it once more.

29.5 धन्यः (dhanyah) — fortunate, blessed

Before the last word of this run: what did *upakārah* mean, and what did *kṛpayā* mean?

You'll want to know: धन्यः

धन्यः (*dhanyaḥ*) — “fortunate, blessed”.

धन्यः means *fortunate, blessed, rich in what matters*. It is built on *dhana*, wealth.

And it closes a circle. The very first thank-you in this book was धन्यवादः — and that word is *dhanya* + *vāda*, **a saying of “you are fortunate”**. Sanskrit does not thank you by reporting your gift; it thanks you by calling you lucky. You said the word on the first day and could not see inside it. You can now.

What you've built

Five courtesies, and the first word of this book opened up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dhanyaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then take *dhanyavādaḥ* apart into its two pieces

Before you move on

What does धन्यः mean? (“fortunate, blessed”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 30

Welcoming a Guest

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the five steps of a Sanskrit welcome, from the door to the hands that make the greeting.
Complete SA-C30-anjali and demonstrate the chapter promise.

30.1 द्वारम् (dvāram) — a door, a gate

Before the new word: what did *dhanyah* mean, and what was inside *dhanyavādah*?

You'll want to know: द्वारम्

द्वारम् (*dvāram*) — “a door, a gate”.

A guest is met at the द्वारम् — the door, the gate.

This is one of the securest cousins in the book. Latin *foris* and *forēs*, “door” — whence *forum*, the space outside the door, and *foreign*, what is out of doors. Greek *thura*. English *door*, German *Tür*, Russian *dver*. The word for the opening of a house survived every migration intact, which is what you would expect of a word every generation says every day. Indian place names keep it too: *Haridwar* is Hari’s gate.

What you’ve built

A door, and a word that reached every branch of the family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dvāram*
- it once more, slowly
- *dvāram*, and name two of its cousins outside India

Before you move on

What does द्वारम् mean? (“a door, a gate”.) Say it once more.

30.2 आसनम् (āsanam) — a seat

Before the new word: what did *dvāram* mean?

You’ll want to know: आसनम्

आसनम् (*āsanam*) — “a seat”.

Having met the guest at the door, you offer an आसनम् — a seat. The root means “to sit”, and the ending makes it the thing you sit on.

English borrowed the word without the furniture: an *āsana* in yoga is a posture, a way of being seated. Both senses live in the one Sanskrit word, and the ordinary one is the older. Neuter -अम्, like द्वारम् before it.

What you’ve built

The second step of a welcome, and a third borrowed word restored.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āsanam*
- it once more, slowly
- *dvāram*, then *āsanam*, in the order a guest meets them

Before you move on

What does आसनम् mean? (“a seat”.) Say it once more.

30.3 पुष्पम् (puṣṣam) — a flower

Before the new word: what did *āsanam* mean, and what did *dvāram* mean?

You’ll want to know: पुष्पम्

पुष्पम् (*puṣṣam*) — “a flower”.

पुष्पम् is a flower. Its root means “to bloom, to thrive, to nourish”, so the word names the opening rather than the petals.

You already have फलम्, the fruit, and now the flower that precedes it — and in Sanskrit the pair *puṣpa-phala* travels together as a set phrase, flower-and-fruit, the way English says *bricks and mortar*. Neuter -अम्, like फलम् itself.

What you’ve built

A flower to set beside the fruit you already had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *puṣṣam*
- it once more, slowly
- *puṣṣam*, then *phalam*, and say them as one pair

Before you move on

What does पुष्पम् mean? (“a flower”.) Say it once more.

30.4 माला (mālā) — a garland

Before the new word: what did *puṣṣam* mean?

You'll want to know: माला

माला (*mālā*) — “a garland”.

Threaded, the flowers become a माला — a garland, put over the head of a guest of honour, and also the string of beads counted through in prayer. English borrowed the second sense as *mala*.

Its own history is unsettled: no agreed cousin outside India, like केशः and अलम् before it. Feminine, ending in -आ, like यात्रा and माता.

What you've built

A third word with no proven travels, and a garland made of the last one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mālā*
- it once more, slowly
- *puṣṣam*, then *mālā*, and name what turns one into the other

Before you move on

What does माला mean? (“a garland”.) Say it once more.

30.5 अञ्जलिः (añjaliḥ) — the two hands cupped together

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *mālā* mean, and what did *dvāram* mean?

You'll want to know: अञ्जलिः

अञ्जलिः (*añjaliḥ*) — “the two hands cupped together”.

अञ्जलिः is the two hands brought together, palms cupped — the gesture your hands make when you say नमस्ते.

The root means “to anoint, to smear”, and the cupped hands were first of all a vessel: the shape you make to carry water, or an offering. The gesture

of greeting began as the shape of giving something away. So the welcome closes where the book opened, on the first word you learned, with the hands finally named.

What you've built

Five steps of a welcome — door, seat, flower, garland, and the hands themselves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *añjaliḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say *namaste* and name what your hands are doing

Before you move on

What does अञ्जलिः mean? (“the two hands cupped together”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 31

The Sky and Its Lights

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five things overhead in Sanskrit — sky, moon, star, wind and snow — and take apart the name of the mountain range built on the last of them.

Complete SA-C31-snow and demonstrate the chapter promise.

31.1 आकाशः (ākāśaḥ) — the sky, open space

Before the new word: what did *añjaliḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: आकाशः

आकाशः (*ākāśaḥ*) — “the sky, open space”.

आकाशः is the openness overhead. It is built on a piece meaning “to shine, to be visible”, with आ in front — so the sky is named as the bright open place where things can be seen at all, rather than as a lid over the world.

This one stayed home. Hindi, Marathi, Bengali and Telugu all keep it as *ākāś* or *ākāśam*, and traders carried it east, where Malay and Indonesian say *angkasa* for the sky to this day. Ends in -अः, like दीपः and हस्तः.

What you’ve built

A new set of words, and the space that everything else in this chapter sits in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ākāśaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *añjaliḥ*, then *ākāśaḥ*

Before you move on

What does आकाशः mean? (“the sky, open space”.) Say it once more.

31.2 चन्द्रः (candraḥ) — the moon

Before the new word: what did *ākāśaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: चन्द्रः

चन्द्रः (*candraḥ*) — “the moon”.

Sanskrit names the moon by what it does: the root behind चन्द्रः means “to shine, to glitter”. The moon is simply the shining one.

Latin kept that root in *candēre*, “to glow white”, and English is full of its children — *candle*, *candid*, *incandescent*, and the *candidate*, who once wore a bleached white toga to be seen in a crowd. Sanskrit called the moon the glowing thing; Latin called a candle the same thing.

What you’ve built

A second word overhead, and a candle lit from the same root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *candraḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *ākāśaḥ*, then *candraḥ*

Before you move on

What does चन्द्रः mean? (“the moon”). Say it once more.

31.3 तारा (tārā) — a star

Before the new word: what did *candraḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: तारा

तारा (tārā) — “a star”.

तारा is a star, and it is among the most travelled words in the family. English *star*, German *Stern*, Latin *stella*, Greek *astēr* — behind *astronomy* and *asterisk* and *disaster*, “a bad star” — and Persian *setāre* are all the same word, from a shape like ***ster-**.

Sanskrit dropped the *s-* at the front and kept the rest. Ends in -आ, like माला and यात्रा.

What you’ve built

A third light overhead, and a word that reached every branch of the family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- tārā
- it once more, slowly
- tārā, and one of its cousins outside India

Before you move on

What does तारा mean? (“a star”). Say it once more.

31.4 वायुः (vāyuh) — wind, air

Before the new word: what did *tārā* mean?

You'll want to know: वायुः

वायुः (*vāyuh*) — “wind, air”.

वायुः is the wind, and also the air it is made of. Its root means “to blow”, so the word says what the thing does.

English *wind* is the same word worn down, and so are German *Wind*, Gothic *winds* and Latin *ventus*, which gives *vent* and *ventilate*. Ends in *-uh*, the ending you had on गुरुः.

What you've built

A fourth thing overhead — the one you feel rather than the one you look for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vāyuh*
- it once more, slowly
- *candraḥ, tārā,* then *vāyuh*

Before you move on

What does वायुः mean? (“wind, air”.) Say it once more.

31.5 हिमम् (himam) — snow, frost

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *vāyuh* mean, and what did *ākāśaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: हिमम्

हिमम् (*himam*) — “snow, frost”.

हिमम् is snow, and cold generally: the word covers the frost on a field and the season it belongs to.

Its cousins name the season rather than the snow: Greek *kheimōn* and Latin *hiems*, both “winter”, the second giving English *hibernate*. And the mountains carry it: *Himālaya* is हिमम् joined to *ālaya*, “a dwelling” — the abode of snow. Neuter -अम्, like वस्त्रम्.

What you've built

Five things overhead, and a mountain range whose name you can now take apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *himam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say what *Himālaya* means

Before you move on

What does हिमम् mean? (“snow, frost”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 32

The Tree and What Grows

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a tree and four things that grow in Sanskrit, and name the two English words that are cousins of grass and of wood.

Complete SA-C32-wood and demonstrate the chapter promise.

32.1 तरुः (taruḥ) — a tree

Before the new word: what did *himam* mean?

You'll want to know: तरुः

तरुः (taruḥ) — “a tree”.

You have had वनम्, a forest, for a long while now. तरुः is one tree standing in it.

Sanskrit keeps several names for a tree — *vrkṣa*, *druma*, and this one — and तरुः is the shortest and the easiest to say. It ends in *-uḥ*, like गुरुः and वायुः, so you already know how it behaves.

What you've built

One tree, picked out of a forest you already know.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *taruḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *himam*, then *taruḥ*

Before you move on

What does तरुः mean? (“a tree”.) Say it once more.

32.2 पत्रम् (patram) — a leaf

Before the new word: what did *taruḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: पत्रम्

पत्रम् (*patram*) — “a leaf”.

पत्रम् is a leaf. It is also a wing, and also a written page — one word for all three, because the root under it means “to fly”. A leaf is the flying thing on a branch; a page is a leaf of another kind.

Greek *pteron*, “wing”, is its cousin, behind *helicopter* and *pterodactyl*; so is Latin *penna*, “feather”, behind *pen* and *pinnate*; and so is English *feather* itself. Neuter -अम्, like वस्त्रम् and आसनम्.

What you’ve built

A leaf, a wing and a page, all carried by one word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *patram*
- it once more, slowly
- *taruḥ*, then *patram*

Before you move on

What does पत्रम् mean? (“a leaf”.) Say it once more.

32.3 तृणम् (tṛṇam) — grass, a blade of grass

Before the new word: what did *patram* mean?

You'll want to know: तृणम्

तृणम् (tṛṇam) — “grass, a blade of grass”.

तृणम् covers a single blade and a whole field of it. It is the low green stuff a तरुः stands in.

English *thorn* is the same word: Old English *thorn*, Gothic *thaurmus*, from a shape like ***trnus**, “a stiff thing that grows up out of the ground”. Sanskrit kept the mild end of that meaning and Germanic kept the sharp end, which is a common way for one word to become two things.

What you've built

A third growing thing, and the reason grass and a thorn are the same word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tṛṇam*
- it once more, slowly
- *patram*, then *tṛṇam*

Before you move on

What does तृणम् mean? (“grass, a blade of grass”.) Say it once more.

32.4 लता (latā) — a creeper, a climbing plant

Before the new word: what did *tṛṇam* mean?

You'll want to know: लता

लता (latā) — “a creeper, a climbing plant”.

लता is anything that climbs rather than stands: a vine, a creeper, a trailing branch.

Sanskrit poetry pairs it with तरुः so often that the two almost arrive together — the creeper and the tree it climbs. Unlike most of this chapter it has no European cousin worth naming; it is homegrown, and it went on to become one of the commonest given names in India. Ends in -आ, like तारा.

What you've built

A fourth growing thing, and a name half of India answers to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *latā*
- it once more, slowly
- *taruḥ*, then *latā*, in the order they grow

Before you move on

What does लता mean? (“a creeper, a climbing plant”.) Say it once more.

32.5 दारु (dāru) — wood, timber

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *latā* mean, and what did *taruḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: दारु

दारु (*dāru*) — “wood, timber”.

दारु is the substance a तरुः is made of.

It is one of the securest cousins in this book. English *tree* is it, and so are Gothic *triu*, Greek *drus* “oak”, Welsh *derwen* and Russian *derevo*; through a Celtic word for one who knows the oak comes *druid*. English *true* and *trust* belong to the same family, on the old idea that to be true is to be as firm as a tree. Ends in short -u, like साधु.

What you've built

Five growing things, and the tree standing inside the English word *true*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dāru*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then name the English word hiding in *dāru*

Before you move on

What does दारु mean? (“wood, timber”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 33

The River and the Road

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a river, a bridge, a mountain, a town and the sea in Sanskrit, and say which of them is a cousin of the Greek word behind *police*.

Complete SA-C33-sea and demonstrate the chapter promise.

33.1 नदी (nadī) — a river

Before the new word: what did *dāru* mean?

You’ll want to know: नदी

नदी (*nadī*) — “a river”.

नदी says what a river does rather than what it is: the root behind it means “to roar, to sound”. A river is the noisy one.

It ends in long *-ī*, like नारी and भगिनी, and it has outlasted almost everything around it — Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Gujarati and Nepali all still say *nadī*, and every river name ending in *-nadi* on an Indian map carries it whole.

What you’ve built

A river, and a word that survived every one of its neighbours.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nadī*
- it once more, slowly
- *dāru*, then *nadī*

Before you move on

What does नदी mean? (“a river”.) Say it once more.

33.2 सेतुः (setuḥ) — a bridge, a causeway

Before the new word: what did *nadī* mean?

You’ll want to know: सेतुः

सेतुः (*setuḥ*) — “a bridge, a causeway”.

सेतुः is literally “the binding”, from a root meaning “to bind, to tie”. A bridge is what ties two banks to each other, and Sanskrit names it for the tying rather than for the crossing.

The causeway between India and Lanka is the *Rāma-setu*, and that is this word, unchanged, on a modern map. Ends in *-uḥ*, like तरुः, वायुः and गुरुः.

What you’ve built

A bridge, and a word that means the tying rather than the crossing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *setuḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *nadī*, then *setuḥ*

Before you move on

What does सेतुः mean? (“a bridge, a causeway”.) Say it once more.

33.3 पर्वतः (parvataḥ) — a mountain

Before the new word: what did *setuḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: पर्वतः

पर्वतः (*parvataḥ*) — “a mountain”.

पर्वतः is built on *parvan*, “a knot, a joint” — the same word for the joints of a bamboo cane and for the sections of a long poem. A mountain is the knotted, jointed land, and a range of them is a knotted spine.

Hindi, Marathi and Nepali keep *parvat*. You met one range of them last chapter, in the snow.

What you’ve built

A mountain, named for the knots in it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *parvataḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *setuḥ*, then *parvataḥ*

Before you move on

What does पर्वतः mean? (“a mountain”.) Say it once more.

33.4 पुरम् (puram) — a town, a walled town

Before the new word: what did *parvataḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: पुरम्

पुरम् (*puram*) — “a town, a walled town”.

You already have नगरम् for a city. पुरम् is the older word, and it meant a stronghold first: a place with a wall around it.

Its Greek cousin is *polis*, behind *police*, *policy*, *politics* and every *-polis* on a map. Sanskrit's own -पुरम् is on the map just as thickly, worn down to *-pur*: *Jaipur*, *Nagpur*, *Kanpur*, and *Singapore*, which began as *Simhapura*, the lion town. Neuter -अम्.

What you've built

A town, and the reason *police* and *Nagpur* are relatives.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *puram*
- it once more, slowly
- *parvataḥ*, then *puram*

Before you move on

What does पुरम् mean? (“a town, a walled town”.) Say it once more.

33.5 समुद्रः (samudraḥ) — the sea

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *puram* mean, and what did *nadī* mean?

You'll want to know: समुद्रः

समुद्रः (*samudraḥ*) — “the sea”.

समुद्रः is *sam*, “together”, joined to *udra*, “water”: the sea is the gathering of the waters, which is where a नदी ends up.

That *sam-* at the front is the one inside संस्कृतम्, “put together, made complete”, the name of the language you have been saying since you first said you speak it. And *udra* has cousins everywhere: Greek *hudōr* behind

hydrant and *hydrogen*, English *water*, Russian *voda*, and the *otter*, who is nothing more than the water animal.

What you've built

Five pieces of country, and the place a river finishes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *samudrah*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say where a *nadī* ends

Before you move on

What does समुद्रः mean? (“the sea”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 34

More of the Body

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name an arm, a neck, a bone, blood and the body itself in Sanskrit, and name the Latin word for bone that is a cousin of one of them.

Complete SA-C34-body and demonstrate the chapter promise.

34.1 बाहुः (bāhuḥ) — an arm

Before the new word: what did *samudraḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: बाहुः

बाहुः (bāhuḥ) — “an arm”.

You already have हस्तः, the hand. बाहुः is the arm above it.

Its English cousin is *bough* — the arm of a tree, which is exactly the picture Sanskrit had. Greek *pēkhus*, “forearm”, is the same word again, and it named the cubit that measured out temples and ships. Ends in *-uḥ*, like तरुः and सेतुः.

What you've built

A sixth part of the body, and the branch of a tree hiding inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bāhuḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *samudraḥ*, then *bāhuḥ*

Before you move on

What does बाहुः mean? (“an arm”.) Say it once more.

34.2 ग्रीवा (grīvā) — the neck

Before the new word: what did *bāhuḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: ग्रीवा

ग्रीवा (*grīvā*) — “the neck”.

ग्रीवा is the neck, and its family kept the swallowing that the old root began with.

Latin *gula*, “throat”, is a cousin, behind *gullet*; Russian *griva* is a mane, the hair along a neck; and Latin *vorāre*, “to devour”, belongs to the same wide family, giving *devour*, *voracious* and *carnivore*. Ends in -आ, like तारा and लता.

What you’ve built

A neck, and a throat full of English words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *grīvā*
- it once more, slowly
- *bāhuḥ*, then *grīvā*

Before you move on

What does ग्रीवा mean? (“the neck”.) Say it once more.

34.3 अस्थि (asthi) — a bone

Before the new word: what did *grīvā* mean?

You'll want to know: अस्थि

अस्थि (*asthi*) — “a bone”.

अस्थि is short, neuter and very old — the same shape as *akṣi*, “eye”, which you have already had.

Its cousins line up letter for letter: Latin *os*, *ossis*, behind *osseous* and *ossify*; Greek *osteon*, behind *osteopath*; Avestan *ast*; Hittite *hastai*. Hittite was written down three and a half thousand years ago, which makes this one of the oldest words you can still say out loud.

What you've built

A bone, and one of the oldest words anyone has written down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *asthi*
- it once more, slowly
- *grīvā*, then *asthi*

Before you move on

What does अस्थि mean? (“a bone”.) Say it once more.

34.4 रक्तम् (raktam) — blood

Before the new word: what did *asthi* mean?

You'll want to know: रक्तम्

रक्तम् (*raktam*) — “blood”.

रक्तम् began as a description rather than a name: it means “reddened, dyed”, from a root *rañj*, “to colour”. Sanskrit names blood by its colour and lets the colour word do the work.

The same root gives राग (*rāga*), which is a colour, a passion and a mode of music all at once — a thing that has been dyed a particular way. Neuter -अम्, like हिमम्.

What you've built

Blood, named for its colour rather than for what it is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *raktam*
- it once more, slowly
- *asthi*, then *raktam*

Before you move on

What does रक्तम् mean? (“blood”.) Say it once more.

34.5 देहः (*dehaḥ*) — the body

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *raktam* mean, and what did *bāhuḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: देहः

देहः (*dehaḥ*) — “the body”.

देहः is the whole of it — the thing the other four belong to. Its root means “to knead, to shape, to plaster”, so a body is a moulded thing, formed the way clay is formed.

English *dough* is the plain cousin. Latin *ingere*, “to shape”, gives *figure*, *fiction* and *effigy*. And an Old Persian relative, a wall of kneaded clay, sits inside *paradise*: *pairi-daēza*, a walled garden.

What you've built

Ten parts of the body between this chapter and the earlier one, and a single word for all of them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dehaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say what *paradise* was built out of

Before you move on

What does देहः mean? (“the body”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 35

In the House

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five things in a house in Sanskrit, and say which one of them came into the language from Persian.

Complete SA-C35-bed and demonstrate the chapter promise.

35.1 दुग्धम् (dugdham) — milk

Before the new word: what did *dehaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: दुग्धम्

दुग्धम् (*dugdham*) — “milk”.

Sanskrit has two words for milk. You met *kṣīram* early on; दुग्धम् is the other one, and it is the one the modern languages kept.

It comes from *duh*, “to milk”, so दुग्धम् is “the milked thing” — the action first, the drink second. Hindi and Gujarati say *dūdh*, Punjabi *duddh*, and you can hear the whole word still inside them. Neuter -अम्.

What you've built

The second word for milk, and the one you would be handed today.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dugdham*
- it once more, slowly
- *dehah*, then *dugdham*

Before you move on

What does दुग्धम् mean? (“milk”.) Say it once more.

35.2 मधु (madhu) — honey

Before the new word: what did *dugdham* mean?

You’ll want to know: मधु

मधु (*madhu*) — “honey”.

मधु is honey, and sweetness in general.

Almost nothing in this book has cousins this far-flung. English *mead* is the same word; Greek *methu* is wine, and *amethyst* — *a-methystos*, “not drunk” — is the stone that was thought to keep you sober; Lithuanian *medus* and Old Irish *mid* are honey and mead again. Even Chinese *mì*, “honey”, was borrowed from an early Indo-European neighbour. Ends in short *-u*, like साधु and दारु.

What you’ve built

Honey, and a word that reached from Ireland to China.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *madhu*
- it once more, slowly
- *dugdham*, then *madhu*

Before you move on

What does मधु mean? (“honey”.) Say it once more.

35.3 लवणम् (lavaṇam) — salt

Before the new word: what did *madhu* mean?

You'll want to know: लवणम्

लवणम् (*lavaṇam*) — “salt”.

लवणम् is salt, and salty as a taste.

Here Sanskrit went its own way: Latin *sal* and English *salt* come from a different old word altogether, and लवणम् has no cousin among them. It stayed at home instead — *lavaṇa* still names the salty one among the six tastes of Indian cooking, while everyday Hindi took *namak* from Persian for the thing in the jar. Neuter -अम्.

What you've built

Salt, and a word with no European relatives at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *lavaṇam*
- it once more, slowly
- *madhu*, then *lavaṇam*

Before you move on

What does लवणम् mean? (“salt”.) Say it once more.

35.4 पुस्तकम् (pustakam) — a book

Before the new word: what did *lavaṇam* mean?

You'll want to know: पुस्तकम्

पुस्तकम् (*pustakam*) — “a book”.

पुस्तकम् is a traveller. It came into Sanskrit from Persian *post*, “hide, skin” — what a book was written on before paper — and then India handed it back out again.

Hindi *pustak*, Bengali *pustak*, Kannada *pustaka*, Telugu *pustakam* and Tamil *puttakam* are all this word. Most of what you have learned here was inherited; this one was borrowed, and you can tell, because its relatives live outside the language rather than inside it.

What you've built

A book, and the one borrowed word in the chapter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pustakam*
- it once more, slowly
- *lavaṇam*, then *pustakam*

Before you move on

What does पुस्तकम् mean? (“a book”.) Say it once more.

35.5 शय्या (śayyā) — a bed

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *pustakam* mean, and what did *dugdham* mean?

You'll want to know: शय्या

शय्या (*śayyā*) — “a bed”.

शय्या comes from *śī*, “to lie down”, so a bed is simply the lying-down place.

Its cousins settle rather than sleep: Greek *keitai*, “he lies”; Latin *civis*, a citizen — one who lies down in a place instead of moving on — behind *city*, *civil* and *civilian*; and English *home*, and *hide*, once a measure of land a single family could settle. A bed and a city turn out to be one idea at two sizes. Ends in -आ, like लता.

What you've built

Five things in a house, and a bed with a city inside it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śayyā*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then say which one came in from Persian

Before you move on

What does शय्या mean? (“a bed”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 36

More Short Replies

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say also, all, likewise, slowly and rightly in Sanskrit, and use any of the five on its own as a reply.

Complete SA-C36-rightly and demonstrate the chapter promise.

36.1 अपि (api) — also, too

Before the new word: what did *śayyā* mean?

You'll want to know: अपि

अपि (*api*) — “also, too”.

अपि adds what you have just said to what came before. Put it after a word and you have piled that word on top: *dugdham api*, “milk as well”.

Greek *epi-* is the same small word, and it fronts *epidemic*, *epilogue*, *epicentre* and *epitaph*. Latin *ob* is a cousin too. It is short, it never changes shape, and it does a great deal of work.

What you've built

A small word that adds one thing to another.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *api*

- it once more, slowly
- *śayyā*, then *dugdham api*

Before you move on

What does अपि mean? (“also, too”.) Say it once more.

36.2 सर्वम् (sarvam) — all, the whole of it

Before the new word: what did *api* mean?

You’ll want to know: सर्वम्

सर्वम् (*sarvam*) — “all, the whole of it”.

सर्वम् answers “how much?” with “all of it”, and it can stand alone as that answer.

Its cousins lean on *whole* rather than on *every*: Greek *holos*, behind *holistic* and *catholic*; Latin *sollus*, “entire”, and *salvus*, “safe and whole”, behind *save*, *salvage* and *salute*. सर्वम्, *holistic* and *salvage* all start from one idea — nothing missing.

What you’ve built

A reply that says nothing has been left out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sarvam*
- it once more, slowly
- *api*, then *sarvam*

Before you move on

What does सर्वम् mean? (“all, the whole of it”.) Say it once more.

36.3 तथा (tathā) — so, in that way, likewise

Before the new word: what did *sarvam* mean?

You'll want to know: तथा

तथा (*tathā*) — “so, in that way, likewise”.

कथम्, which you have had for a long time, asks “how?”. तथा answers it: “that way”.

The *t-* at the front is the one you met on तत् and तत्र, and it does the same job here — it points back at what has just been said. On its own, as a reply, तथा means “just so”, and doubled it agrees warmly: *tathā tathā*.

What you've built

The answer that matches a question you have had since early on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tathā*
- it once more, slowly
- *katham*, then *tathā*, as question and answer

Before you move on

What does तथा mean? (“so, in that way, likewise”.) Say it once more.

36.4 मन्दम् (mandam) — slowly, gently

Before the new word: what did *tathā* mean?

You'll want to know: मन्दम्

मन्दम् (*mandam*) — “slowly, gently”.

मन्दम् asks for less speed. Doubled — *mandam mandam* — it means “slowly now, slowly”, which is how it is most often said.

This is the word you want when somebody is talking faster than you can follow, and it goes well with कृपया: *kṛpayā mandam*, “slowly, please”. Said kindly, it repairs a conversation instead of stopping it.

What you’ve built

The repair word for a conversation moving too fast.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mandam*
- it once more, slowly
- *kṛpayā mandam*, said kindly

Before you move on

What does मन्दम् mean? (“slowly, gently”.) Say it once more.

36.5 सम्यक् (samyak) — rightly, properly, exactly so

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *mandam* mean, and what did *api* mean?

You’ll want to know: सम्यक्

सम्यक् (*samyak*) — “rightly, properly, exactly so”.

सम्यक् confirms that a thing has been done right.

It is *sam*, “together” — the *sam*- inside समुद्रः and संस्कृतम् — joined to a piece meaning “turned, directed”: turned the right way, all of a piece. Beside साधु it is the cooler of the two. साधु praises the person; सम्यक् confirms the thing.

What you’ve built

Five short replies, and the difference between praising and confirming.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *samyak*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *sādhū* and *samyak* one after the other

Before you move on

What does सम्यक् mean? (“rightly, properly, exactly so”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 37

More Courtesy

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone peace, speak respectfully, call a host gracious, congratulate a friend and give a blessing in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C37-blessing and demonstrate the chapter promise.

37.1 शान्तिः (śāntiḥ) — peace, stillness

Before the new word: what did *samyak* mean?

You'll want to know: शान्तिः

शान्तिः (śāntiḥ) — “peace, stillness”.

शान्तिः is peace of a particular kind: not the absence of war so much as the settling of something that had been disturbed. It comes from śam, “to grow calm, to come to rest”.

A great many Sanskrit texts close on it, said three times over, once for each of the troubles a person can meet. You already have स्वस्ति for a wish of wellbeing; शान्तिः is the quieter one, and the one you would say last.

What you've built

A word for peace, and the way Sanskrit texts stop.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śāntiḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *samyak*, then *śāntiḥ*

Before you move on

What does शान्तिः mean? (“peace, stillness”.) Say it once more.

37.2 सादरम् (sādaram) — respectfully, with respect

Before the new word: what did *śāntiḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: सादरम्

सादरम् (*sādaram*) — “respectfully, with respect”.

सादरम् is *sa-*, “with”, joined to *ādara*, “regard, esteem” — so, “with regard”.

It goes at the front of a request, where English would put its politeness at the end of a letter. Set beside कृपया it makes a request about as courteous as Sanskrit gets: *sādaram kṛpayā*.

What you’ve built

A politeness that goes at the front rather than the end.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sādaram*
- it once more, slowly
- *śāntiḥ*, then *sādaram kṛpayā*

Before you move on

What does सादरम् mean? (“respectfully, with respect”.) Say it once more.

37.3 प्रसन्नः (prasannah) — pleased, gracious, clear

Before the new word: what did *sādaram* mean?

You’ll want to know: प्रसन्नः

प्रसन्नः (*prasannah*) — “pleased, gracious, clear”.

प्रसन्नः describes a face that has cleared. The one word covers still water, a settled mind and a kindly host, because it is *pra-*, “forth”, with *sad*, “to settle”: what was cloudy has dropped its silt.

To say that a guest left you प्रसन्नः is to say they left you at ease. The offering handed back from a temple, *prasāda*, is this same word — grace, given a physical form.

What you’ve built

A word for water, a mind and a host, all at once.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *prasannah*
- it once more, slowly
- *sādaram*, then *prasannah*

Before you move on

What does प्रसन्नः mean? (“pleased, gracious, clear”.) Say it once more.

37.4 अभिनन्दनम् (abhinandanam) — congratulation, a greeting of delight

Before the new word: what did *prasannah* mean?

You'll want to know: अभिनन्दनम्

अभिनन्दनम् (*abhinandanam*) — “congratulation, a greeting of delight”.

अभिनन्दनम् is what you offer when something has gone well for somebody else. It is *abhi*, “towards”, with *nand*, “to rejoice” — gladness turned towards another person rather than kept.

That *nand* is the piece inside आनन्दः, the joy you met near the beginning of this book. The two words are the same delight, one held and one given away. Neuter -अम्.

What you've built

Joy from the beginning of this book, turned outwards towards somebody else.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *abhinandanam*
- it once more, slowly
- *ānandaḥ*, then *abhinandanam*

Before you move on

What does अभिनन्दनम् mean? (“congratulation, a greeting of delight”.) Say it once more.

37.5 आशीर्वादः (*āśīrvādaḥ*) — a blessing

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *abhinandanam* mean, and what did *śāntiḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: आशीर्वादः

आशीर्वादः (*āśīrvādaḥ*) — “a blessing”.

आशीर्वादः is a blessing spoken aloud: *āśīs*, “a wish, a prayer”, joined to *vāda*, “a speaking”.

That second piece is the one inside धन्यवादः, the thanks you learned on your very first page — thanks is a speaking too. An elder gives आशीर्वादः;

you answer with धन्यवादः; and the two are built the same way, out of a wish and a word for saying it.

What you've built

Five courtesies, and the piece shared by a blessing and a thanks.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āśīrvādaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *āśīrvādaḥ* and *dhanyavādaḥ* together

Before you move on

What does आशीर्वादः mean? (“a blessing”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 38

Fire and Stone

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name fire, ash, a stone, sand and soil in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C38-soil and demonstrate the chapter promise.

38.1 अग्निः (agniḥ) — fire

Before the new word: what did *āśīrvādaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: अग्निः

अग्निः (*agniḥ*) — “fire”.

अग्निः is fire itself — the flame on a hearth, and the fire an offering is poured into.

You have had the doing-word for a while: दहति, “burns”. अग्निः is the thing that does it.

Latin *ignis* is the very same word, and English carries it in *ignite* and *igneous*; Russian *ogon'* is another of its brothers. It went west almost unchanged, and in Sanskrit it stands as the first word of the oldest hymn there is.

What you've built

Fire, named as a thing rather than as an action.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *agniḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *āśīrvādaḥ*, then *agniḥ*

Before you move on

What does अग्निः mean? (“fire”.) Say it once more.

38.2 भस्म (bhasma) — ash

Before the new word: what did *agniḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: भस्म

भस्म (*bhasma*) — “ash”.

भस्म is what अग्निः leaves behind — ash, and the grey line of it drawn across a forehead.

It stands on *bhas*, “to chew, to grind small”, so ash is the ground-down thing: what is left when fire has finished eating.

Hindi and Marathi keep *bhasm* with the meaning untouched.

What you’ve built

Fire, and what fire leaves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bhasma*
- it once more, slowly
- *agniḥ*, then *bhasma*

Before you move on

What does भस्म mean? (“ash”.) Say it once more.

38.3 शिला (śilā) — a stone, a slab of rock

Before the new word: what did *bhasma* mean?

You’ll want to know: शिला

शिला (śilā) — “a stone, a slab of rock”.

शिला is a stone large enough to sit on: a slab, a flat rock, the piece a step is cut from.

Beside पर्वतः, which is the whole raised land, शिला is one piece of it you can put a hand on.

Its history outside India is unsettled — nobody has agreed a cousin for it, the way nobody has for केशः or माला. Feminine, ending in -आ.

What you’ve built

One piece of the mountain, small enough to touch.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- śilā
- it once more, slowly
- *bhasma*, then śilā

Before you move on

What does शिला mean? (“a stone, a slab of rock”.) Say it once more.

38.4 सिकता (sikata) — sand

Before the new word: what did śilā mean?

You'll want to know: सिकता

सिकता (*sikatā*) — “sand”.

सिकता is sand — the grit of a bank, and the bank itself where it piles up.

It has long been tied to *sic*, “to pour, to sprinkle”: sand is the stuff that pours.

Set it beside नदी and you have the two halves of a bank — the water, and what the water leaves at its edge.

What you've built

What a river puts down at its edge.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sikatā*
- it once more, slowly
- *śilā*, then *sikatā*

Before you move on

What does सिकता mean? (“sand”). Say it once more.

38.5 मृत्तिका (*mṛttikā*) — soil

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *śilā* mean, and what did *sikatā* mean?

You'll want to know: मृत्तिका

मृत्तिका (*mṛttikā*) — “soil”.

मृत्तिका is soil — damp, workable, the stuff a potter digs and a wall is plastered with.

It stands on *mṛd*, and Latin *mordēre*, “to bite”, is its cousin: the sense underneath both is pressing something soft until it gives. English took *mordant* from that Latin side.

Eastward it wore down into Hindi *mittī*, still the ordinary word for the ground you dig.

What you've built

Five things underfoot and in the hearth: fire, ash, stone, sand, soil.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mṛttikā*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *agnih* and *mṛttikā* together

Before you move on

What does मृत्तिका mean? (“soil”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 39

Animals

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a cow, a bird, a fish, a dog and a snake in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C39-snake and demonstrate the chapter promise.

39.1 धेनुः (dhenuḥ) — a cow

Before the new word: what did *mṛttikā* mean?

You'll want to know: धेनुः

धेनुः (*dhenuḥ*) — “a cow”.

धेनुः is a cow, and first of all a cow in milk.

It stands on *dhe*, “to suckle” — a root that reaches a long way west: Latin *fēmina*, the one who nurses, and *filius*, the one nursed, and English *fecund* behind them both.

दुग्धम्, the milk you already ask for, comes from a different root altogether, the one that means to draw milk off. The animal is named for the giving, the drink for the taking.

What you've built

The animal behind the milk word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dhenuḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *mṛttikā*, then *dhenuḥ*

Before you move on

What does धेनुः mean? (“a cow”.) Say it once more.

39.2 विहगः (vihagaḥ) — a bird

Before the new word: what did *dhenuḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: विहगः

विहगः (*vihagaḥ*) — “a bird”.

विहगः is a bird, and the word says how it moves: *vi-*, “apart, across”, with *ga*, “going”.

That going-piece is the one inside गच्छति, the first doing-word in this book. A विहगः is simply the one that goes across.

Across what is unsaid, and does not need saying: आकाशः, the open sky, is the only place it could be.

What you’ve built

A bird named for crossing the sky.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vihagaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *dhenuḥ*, then *vihagaḥ*

Before you move on

What does विहगः mean? (“a bird”.) Say it once more.

39.3 मत्स्यः (matsyaḥ) — a fish

Before the new word: what did *vihagaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: मत्स्यः

मत्स्यः (*matsyaḥ*) — “a fish”.

मत्स्यः is a fish, in a नदी or in a market basket.

It wore down eastward into *machh*, which is why the fish on a Hindi menu is *machhlī* and the Bengali one is *machh*.

Westward there is nothing to point at: no agreed European cousin has been found. A fish seems to be one of the things each family named for itself.

What you’ve built

A fish, and a word that travelled east but not west.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *matsyaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *vihagaḥ*, then *matsyaḥ*

Before you move on

What does मत्स्यः mean? (“a fish”.) Say it once more.

39.4 शुनकः (śunakaḥ) — a dog

Before the new word: what did *matsyaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: शुनकः

शुनकः (*śunakaḥ*) — “a dog”.

शुनकः is a dog — an affectionate little form of an older and much bigger word, *śvan*.

That *śvan* is one of the unbroken ones. Greek *kuōn* is behind *cynic*; Latin *canis* is behind *canine* and *kennel*; English *hound* and German *Hund* are the same word worn down the Germanic way.

The small ending on शुनकः is the difference between naming a species and naming the animal at your द्वारम्.

What you've built

A dog, in the small friendly form of a very old word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śunakaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *matsyaḥ*, then *śunakaḥ*

Before you move on

What does शुनकः mean? (“a dog”.) Say it once more.

39.5 सर्पः (sarpah) — a snake

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *matsyaḥ* mean, and what did *śunakaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: सर्पः

सर्पः (*sarpah*) — “a snake”.

सर्पः is a snake, named for what it does: *srp*, “to creep, to glide”.

Latin has the same root, showing up as *serpere*, and *serpent* comes to English straight out of it. *Reptile* arrives by a parallel road from a Latin word meaning much the same thing.

A सर्पः belongs in the तृणम् rather than on the शिला, and that is where the old texts usually put it.

What you've built

Five creatures: one in milk, one across the sky, one in the river, one at the door, one in the grass.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sarpaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *dhenuḥ* and *sarpaḥ* together

Before you move on

What does सर्पः mean? (“a snake”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 40

In the Kitchen

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name curd, sugar, fresh butter, a vegetable and a sweet in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C40-sweet and demonstrate the chapter promise.

40.1 दधि (dadhi) — curd

Before the new word: what did *sarpah* mean?

You'll want to know: दधि

दधि (*dadhi*) — “curd”.

दधि is curd — दुग्धम् set thick, the *dahī* of every kitchen in India.

The word is a doubled thing: *da-dh-i*, the root *dhā*, “to set, to place”, said twice over. Curd is milk that has been set, and the name says so twice for emphasis.

Hindi *dahī*, Marathi *dahī*, Gujarati *dahī* — the word barely moved.

What you've built

Milk, set thick.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *dadhi*

- it once more, slowly
- *sarpah*, then *dadhi*

Before you move on

What does दधि mean? (“curd”.) Say it once more.

40.2 शर्करा (śarkarā) — sugar

Before the new word: what did *dadhi* mean?

You’ll want to know: शर्करा

शर्करा (*śarkarā*) — “sugar”.

शर्करा is sugar, and before that it was grit and gravel — then the sweet grit that comes off boiled cane.

This one word is behind every sugar in Europe. It went into Arabic as *sukkar*, into Latin as *saccharum*, and from there into Italian *zucchero*, French *sucre*, German *Zucker* and English *sugar* and *saccharine*.

Feminine, ending in -आ, like माला and शिला.

What you’ve built

The Sanskrit word inside every European sugar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śarkarā*
- it once more, slowly
- *dadhi*, then *śarkarā*

Before you move on

What does शर्करा mean? (“sugar”.) Say it once more.

40.3 नवनीतम् (navanītam) — fresh butter

Before the new word: what did *śarkarā* mean?

You’ll want to know: नवनीतम्

नवनीतम् (*navanītam*) — “fresh butter”.

नवनीतम् is butter just off the churn, and both of its pieces are already yours.

The first piece, *nava*, is “new” — the word you learned beside महत् and अल्प. *nīta* is “brought, led”, from the same *nī* that stands inside नयति. Butter is the newly-brought thing — what has just been led up out of the दधि.

It is the butter of the Kṛṣṇa stories, stolen by the handful, and Hindi *navnīt* is still a name people give a child.

What you’ve built

Butter, named as the new thing brought up out of the curd.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *navanītam*
- it once more, slowly
- *śarkarā*, then *navanītam*

Before you move on

What does नवनीतम् mean? (“fresh butter”.) Say it once more.

40.4 शाकम् (śākam) — a vegetable, a green

Before the new word: what did *navanītam* mean?

You'll want to know: शाकम्

शाकम् (*śākam*) — “a vegetable, a green”.

शाकम् is a vegetable, and especially a leaf one — the cooked greens that a Hindi menu calls साग.

Where पत्रम् is the leaf on a लता, शाकम् is the leaf in a pot.

No cousin outside India has been agreed for it. The word stayed home, and it is doing the same work today it was doing three thousand years ago.

What you've built

Leaves on the plant, and leaves in the pot.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śākam*
- it once more, slowly
- *navanītam*, then *śākam*

Before you move on

What does शाकम् mean? (“a vegetable, a green”.) Say it once more.

40.5 मोदकः (modakaḥ) — a sweet dumpling

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *navanītam* mean, and what did *śākam* mean?

You'll want to know: मोदकः

मोदकः (*modakaḥ*) — “a sweet dumpling”.

मोदकः is a sweet — the round steamed dumpling put before a guest, and before a god.

It is built on *mud*, “to be glad”, so the name of the sweet is the name of the gladness it makes. आनन्दः, the joy you offered at a first meeting, reaches for the same idea by a different root.

Set one in front of an अतिथिः and the word does its own explaining.

What you've built

Five things from a kitchen: curd, sugar, butter, greens, a sweet.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *modakah*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *dadhi* and *modakah* together

Before you move on

What does मोदकः mean? (“a sweet dumpling”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 41

Things People Make

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a wheel, a water-pot, a boat, a mirror and a parasol in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C41-parasol and demonstrate the chapter promise.

41.1 चक्रम् (cakram) — a wheel

Before the new word: what did *modakaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: चक्रम्

चक्रम् (*cakram*) — “a wheel”.

चक्रम् is a wheel, a disc, a circle of anything.

It is an old root for turning, *k^wel-, said twice — and the same doubling gives Greek *kuklos*, which English keeps in *cycle* and *cyclone*. English *wheel* is the same word by the Germanic road.

English later borrowed the Sanskrit itself, unworn, as *chakra*, so the word now sits in the language twice over.

What you've built

A wheel, and a root that turns in three languages at once.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cakram*
- it once more, slowly
- *modakaḥ*, then *cakram*

Before you move on

What does चक्रम् mean? (“a wheel”.) Say it once more.

41.2 कलशः (kalaśaḥ) — a water-pot

Before the new word: what did *cakram* mean?

You’ll want to know: कलशः

कलशः (*kalaśaḥ*) — “a water-pot”.

कलशः is the round-bellied water-pot — the one set at a द्वारम् with leaves and a coconut on top, and any pot of that shape.

Fill it with पानीयम् and it is doing its everyday job; put it at a doorway and it is doing its other one.

Greek *kalux*, a husk or a cup, has been offered as a cousin, and Latin *calix*, which English keeps in *chalice*, names the same swelling shape.

What you’ve built

The pot that holds water and welcomes people.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kalaśaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *cakram*, then *kalaśaḥ*

Before you move on

What does कलशः mean? (“a water-pot”.) Say it once more.

41.3 प्लवः (plavaḥ) — a boat, a raft

Before the new word: what did *kalaśaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: प्लवः

प्लवः (*plavaḥ*) — “a boat, a raft”.

प्लवः is a boat, and more exactly a float — a raft, a hull, anything that swims rather than sinks.

From *plu*, “to float, to swim”, and the family is enormous: Greek *plein*, “to sail”, Latin *pluere*, “to rain”, English *flow*, *float* and *fleet*.

Where there is no सेतुः across the नदी, there is a प्लवः.

What you've built

What carries you over when there is no bridge.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *plavaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *kalaśaḥ*, then *plavaḥ*

Before you move on

What does प्लवः mean? (“a boat, a raft”.) Say it once more.

41.4 दर्पणः (darpaṇaḥ) — a mirror

Before the new word: what did *plavaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: दर्पणः

दर्पणः (*darpaṇaḥ*) — “a mirror”.

दर्पणः is a mirror — a disc of metal polished bright, centuries before glass could do the job.

It stands on *dr̥p*, “to be proud”, so the object is named for what people do in front of it rather than for what it is made of. That is a small joke three thousand years old.

Hindi *darpaṇ* is the same word, unchanged.

What you’ve built

A mirror, named for vanity rather than for glass.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *darpaṇaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *plavaḥ*, then *darpaṇaḥ*

Before you move on

What does दर्पणः mean? (“a mirror”.) Say it once more.

41.5 छत्रम् (chatram) — a parasol

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *plavaḥ* mean, and what did *darpaṇaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: छत्रम्

छत्रम् (*chatram*) — “a parasol”.

छत्रम् is a parasol: the shade held over a *rājā*, and the umbrella carried in the rain.

From *chad*, “to cover”. The covering is the whole of it — what the छत्रम् covers you from, sun or water, the word does not say.

It went east as well as up in the world: Hindi *chātā*, the umbrella anyone carries, is this word worn smooth.

What you’ve built

Five things made by hand: a wheel, a pot, a boat, a mirror, a parasol.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *chatram*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *cakram* and *chatram* together

Before you move on

What does छत्रम् mean? (“a parasol.”) Say it once more.

Chapter 42

Five More Replies

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say sometimes, suddenly, mostly, a little and much in Sanskrit, and use any of the five on its own as a reply.

Complete SA-C42-much and demonstrate the chapter promise.

42.1 कदाचित् (kadācit) — sometimes

Before the new word: what did *chatram* mean?

You'll want to know: कदाचित्

कदाचित् (*kadācit*) — “sometimes”.

कदाचित् answers “when?” with “now and then”.

Both pieces are yours already: कदा, the *when* you ask questions with, and a small *cit* fastened on the end. कदाचित् is *when* gone vague — at some time or other, and no promise which.

It is also the polite way to leave a door open: not yes, not no, perhaps sometimes.

What you've built

A reply that answers *when* without saying when.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kadācit*
- it once more, slowly
- *chatram*, then *kadācit*

Before you move on

What does कदाचित् mean? (“sometimes”.) Say it once more.

42.2 सहसा (sahasā) — suddenly

Before the new word: what did *kadācit* mean?

You’ll want to know: सहसा

सहसा (*sahasā*) — “suddenly”.

सहसा is “all at once, without warning”.

Underneath it is *sahas*, “force, a sudden strength”, put into the shape that means *by means of*: by force, and so at a rush. कृपया, the please you already say, is made the very same way out of *kṛpā*.

It carries a shade of judgement with it — a thing done सहसा is a thing done without thinking first.

What you’ve built

One thing happening at a rush, and a mild opinion about it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sahasā*
- it once more, slowly
- *kadācit*, then *sahasā*

Before you move on

What does सहसा mean? (“suddenly”.) Say it once more.

42.3 प्रायः (prāyaḥ) — mostly, for the most part

Before the new word: what did *sahasā* mean?

You’ll want to know: प्रायः

प्रायः (*prāyaḥ*) — “mostly, for the most part”.

प्रायः is “for the most part, in the main, usually”.

Say it when something holds most of the time and you would rather not promise more than that. It is *pra-*, “forward”, with the going-piece you met in विहगः: what runs out in front, what happens in the main.

Beside सर्वम्, which claims everything, प्रायः claims almost everything and keeps its hedge.

What you’ve built

A reply that is honest about not being certain.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *prāyaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *sahasā*, then *prāyaḥ*

Before you move on

What does प्रायः mean? (“mostly, for the most part”.) Say it once more.

42.4 किञ्चित् (kiñcit) — a little, somewhat

Before the new word: what did *prāyaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: किञ्चित्

किञ्चित् (*kiñcit*) — “a little, somewhat”.

किञ्चित् is “a bit, somewhat, a small amount”.

It is किम्, the *what* you have been asking with since your first questions, wearing the same little *cit* that softened कदाचित्. *What* gone vague is *something* — and *something* said of a quantity is *a little*.

अल्पम् describes a small thing; किञ्चित् measures a small amount of it.

What you've built

A small helping of an answer.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kiñcit*
- it once more, slowly
- *prāyaḥ*, then *kiñcit*

Before you move on

What does किञ्चित् mean? (“a little, somewhat”.) Say it once more.

42.5 बहु (bahu) — much, many

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *prāyaḥ* mean, and what did *kiñcit* mean?

You'll want to know: बहु

बहु (*bahu*) — “much, many”.

बहु is “much” of one thing and “many” of several — the far end of the answer किञ्चित् starts.

Greek *pakhus*, “thick, stout”, is its cousin, and thickness is the sense underneath: plenty as bulk rather than as a count.

Hindi *bahut*, “very, a lot”, is बहु with an ending on it, and it is one of the commonest words anyone says today.

What you've built

Five replies about how much and how often: sometimes, suddenly, mostly, a little, much.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bahu*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *kadācit* and *bahu* together

Before you move on

What does बहु mean? (“much, many”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 43

Good Manners

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name hospitality, good conduct, humility, trust and plain dealing in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C43-honest and demonstrate the chapter promise.

43.1 आतिथ्यम् (ātithyam) — hospitality

Before the new word: what did *bahu* mean?

You'll want to know: आतिथ्यम्

आतिथ्यम् (*ātithyam*) — “hospitality”.

आतिथ्यम् is hospitality: not the guest, but everything owed to one.

The अतिथिः you already know is stretched into the treatment that guest receives, so the word names a duty rather than a person.

Classically it runs in an order, and you have the words for all of it: an आसनम् first, then पानीयम्, then अन्नम्. आतिथ्यम् is that whole sequence in one word.

What you've built

The guest word, turned into what is owed to the guest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ātithyam*
- it once more, slowly
- *bahu*, then *ātithyam*

Before you move on

What does आतिथ्यम् mean? (“hospitality”.) Say it once more.

43.2 विनयः (vinayaḥ) — good conduct, training

Before the new word: what did *ātithyam* mean?

You’ll want to know: विनयः

विनयः (*vinayaḥ*) — “good conduct, training”.

विनयः is the bearing of someone well brought up — modest, disciplined, easy to be near.

Its pieces are *vi-*, “away, apart”, and the leading doing-word नयति: to have विनयः is to have been led away from what was rough in you. Training and good manners are one word here, because the second is thought to come out of the first.

The Buddhist books of monastic training carry this word as their name.

What you’ve built

Manners understood as training rather than as polish.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vinayaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *ātithyam*, then *vinayaḥ*

Before you move on

What does विनयः mean? (“good conduct, training”.) Say it once more.

43.3 नम्रता (namratā) — humility

Before the new word: what did *vinayaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: नम्रता

नम्रता (*namratā*) — “humility”.

नम्रता is humility — bendingness, the quality of one who bows.

It stands on *nam*, “to bow”, which is the *nam* that opens नमस्ते on your first page and sits inside प्रणामः. Those two are single acts; नम्रता is the same bow turned into a settled habit.

Hindi *namratā* is the word people still use of someone who carries success lightly.

What you’ve built

The bow you already make, become a habit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *namratā*
- it once more, slowly
- *vinayaḥ*, then *namratā*

Before you move on

What does नम्रता mean? (“humility”.) Say it once more.

43.4 विश्वासः (viśvāsaḥ) — trust, confidence

Before the new word: what did *namratā* mean?

You'll want to know: विश्वासः

विश्वासः (*viśvāsaḥ*) — “trust, confidence”.

विश्वासः is trust — and the picture inside it is breathing out.

It is *vi-* with *śvas*, “to breathe”: to trust someone is to let the breath go, to stop holding it. English says much the same thing when it calls a friend a confidant, from Latin for *with faith*.

Hindi *viśvās* is unchanged, and *viśvāsgḥāt*, a betrayal, is the same word with the breaking of it attached.

What you've built

Trust, described as the moment you stop holding your breath.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viśvāsaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *namratā*, then *viśvāsaḥ*

Before you move on

What does विश्वासः mean? (“trust, confidence”.) Say it once more.

43.5 सरलः (saralaḥ) — straightforward, honest

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *namratā* mean, and what did *viśvāsaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: सरलः

सरलः (*saralaḥ*) — “straightforward, honest”.

सरलः is straight: of a मार्गः, of a piece of दारु, and of a person who says the thing plainly.

The pine is called *sarala* because it grows straight up, and the same word does duty for a road with no bends and for someone with no side to them.

English runs the metaphor the same way — *straight, upright, a straight answer* — which is worth noticing, because the two languages arrived at it separately.

What you've built

Five words for how a person carries themselves: hospitality, conduct, humility, trust, plain dealing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *saralaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *ātithyam* and *saralaḥ* together

Before you move on

What does सरलः mean? (“straightforward, honest”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 44

Colours

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say white, dark, yellow, green and blue in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C44-blue and demonstrate the chapter promise.

44.1 श्वेतः (śvetaḥ) — white

Before the new word: what did *saralaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: श्वेतः

श्वेतः (śvetaḥ) — “white”.

श्वेतः is white, and bright along with it.

English *white* is the same word by the Germanic road, and Russian *svet*, “light”, is another of its brothers — brightness and whiteness were one idea for a long time.

हिमम् is श्वेतम्, and so is दधि.

What you've built

White, and the brightness that comes with it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- śvetaḥ

- it once more, slowly
- *saralaḥ*, then *śvetaḥ*

Before you move on

What does श्वेतः mean? (“white”.) Say it once more.

44.2 श्यामः (śyāmaḥ) — dark, black

Before the new word: what did *śvetaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: श्यामः

श्यामः (*śyāmaḥ*) — “dark, black”.

श्यामः is dark — black, but also the blue-black of a rain cloud and the deep green of standing water.

It is the darkness of a thundercloud rather than of soot, which is why the god whose name means “the dark one” is also called *Śyām* with affection.

No European cousin has been agreed. The word stayed home, and *Śyām* and *Śyāmā* are ordinary names in India today.

What you’ve built

Dark, with a rain cloud in it rather than ash.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śyāmaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *śvetaḥ*, then *śyāmaḥ*

Before you move on

What does श्यामः mean? (“dark, black”.) Say it once more.

44.3 पीतः (pītaḥ) — yellow

Before the new word: what did *śyāmaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: पीतः

पीतः (*pītaḥ*) — “yellow”.

पीतः is yellow — turmeric, ripe grain, a marigold, the silk a bridegroom wears.

Its older force is “made yellow”, so a पीतम् वस्त्रम् is a cloth that has been dyed rather than one that grew that colour.

Hindi *pīlā* is the same word with an ending on it, and it is the yellow of every wall and every taxi.

What you've built

Yellow, understood as a thing that was dyed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pītaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *śyāmaḥ*, then *pītaḥ*

Before you move on

What does पीतः mean? (“yellow”.) Say it once more.

44.4 हरितः (haritaḥ) — green

Before the new word: what did *pītaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: हरितः

हरितः (*haritaḥ*) — “green”.

हरितः is green — and before it settled it covered yellow-green and gold as well.

English *yellow* and *gold* are its cousins, from **ǵhel-*, a root that runs across the whole band from green to yellow. One family, one word, two colours pulled apart by different daughters.

तृणम् is हरितम्, and so is a young पत्रम् on a तरुः.

What you've built

Green, from a root that could not decide between green and gold.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *haritaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *pītaḥ*, then *haritaḥ*

Before you move on

What does हरितः mean? (“green”). Say it once more.

44.5 नीलः (nīlaḥ) — blue

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *pītaḥ* mean, and what did *haritaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: नीलः

नीलः (*nīlaḥ*) — “blue”.

नीलः is blue, and dark blue at that — the blue of the समुद्रः rather than of the आकाशः at noon.

The indigo plant is *nīlī*, and when Europe began buying that dye the word travelled with the cargo: Arabic *nīl*, Portuguese *anil*, and the *aniline* English still uses for the dyes that replaced it.

So a Sanskrit colour word is sitting inside a modern chemistry term, carried there by trade.

What you've built

Five colours: white, dark, yellow, green and blue.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nīlaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *śvetaḥ* and *nīlaḥ* together

Before you move on

What does नीलः mean? (“blue”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 45

Times of the Day

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name morning, noon, evening, a month and a year in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C45-year and demonstrate the chapter promise.

45.1 प्रातः (prātaḥ) — morning

Before the new word: what did *nīlaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: प्रातः

प्रातः (prātaḥ) — “morning”.

प्रातः is early morning: the stretch before the sun stands high, and the hour the first greeting of the day belongs to.

You have said *pra-* at the front of a word twice already, in प्रणामः and in प्रसन्नः, where it carries the sense “forward, out in front”. प्रातः is the front end of the day.

Greek *prōi*, “early”, is the same small piece put to the same work, and Latin *prae* is its cousin; English carries it as the *pre-* in front of a thousand words.

What you’ve built

The first part of the day, named.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *prātaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *nīlaḥ*, then *prātaḥ*

Before you move on

What does प्रातः mean? (“morning”.) Say it once more.

45.2 मध्याह्नः (madhyāhnaḥ) — noon

Before the new word: what did *prātaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: मध्याह्नः

मध्याह्नः (*madhyāhnaḥ*) — “noon”.

मध्याह्नः is midday, the sun at the top of its climb.

It is two pieces joined: *madhya*, “middle”, and *ahan*, a day. Sanskrit keeps more than one word for a day, and this is the other one — दिनम् is the day you count, *ahan* the day you are standing in. English *mid* is *madhya*’s own worn-down cousin.

So noon is the middle of the day said in one breath, which is what noon is in most languages once you take the word apart.

What you’ve built

The top of the day, between its two ends.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *madhyāhnaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *prātaḥ*, then *madhyāhnaḥ*

Before you move on

What does मध्याह्नः mean? (“noon”.) Say it once more.

45.3 सायम् (sāyam) — evening

Before the new word: what did *madhyāhnaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: सायम्

सायम् (*sāyam*) — “evening”.

सायम् is evening: the end of the working day, when a thing is set down rather than picked up.

Put it beside प्रातः and you hold the two ends of the daylight — the greeting at one end and the leave-taking at the other. *sāyami prātaḥ*, “evening and morning”, is one of the oldest paired phrases the language has.

It rests on a piece meaning “to finish, to let go”, so evening is named as the slackening of the day rather than as its darkness.

What you’ve built

Both ends of the daylight, and the middle between them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sāyam*
- it once more, slowly
- *madhyāhnaḥ*, then *sāyam*

Before you move on

What does सायम् mean? (“evening”.) Say it once more.

45.4 मासः (māsaḥ) — a month

Before the new word: what did *sāyam* mean?

You'll want to know: मासः

मासः (*māsaḥ*) — “a month”.

मासः is a month, and it is the moon's own word.

You have चन्द्रः for the moon overhead. मासः is that same moon counted: the stretch from one to the next.

Latin *mēnsis*, Greek *mēn*, English *month* and *moon* are all one word travelled west, and this is among the securest cousins in the whole family. Ends in -अः.

What you've built

A stretch of time measured by the moon you already know.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *māsaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *sāyam*, then *māsaḥ*

Before you move on

What does मासः mean? (“a month”.) Say it once more.

45.5 संवत्सरः (saṁvatsaraḥ) — a year

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *sāyam* mean, and what did *māsaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: संवत्सरः

संवत्सरः (*saṁvatsaraḥ*) — “a year”.

संवत्सरः is a year: the whole round of months, come back to where it started.

The *saṁ-* in front is the piece meaning “together, complete” that also opens the name of the language itself. The *vatsara* behind it is kin to Latin *vetus*, “old”, and to Greek *etos*, a year — a year being what leaves a thing one year older. English *veteran* sits on that same piece.

Beside मासः, the small round, संवत्सरः is the large one. Ends in -अः.

What you've built

Five stretches of time: morning, noon, evening, a month, a year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *saṃvatsaraḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *prātaḥ* and *saṃvatsaraḥ* together

Before you move on

What does संवत्सरः mean? (“a year”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 46

Sun and Shade

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the sun, a ray, light, shade and heat in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C46-heat and demonstrate the chapter promise.

46.1 रविः (raviḥ) — the sun

Before the new word: what did *saṁvatsaraḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: रविः

रविः (raviḥ) — “the sun”.

रविः is the sun: the disc itself, not the light it sends.

You have आकाशः for the open sky and चन्द्रः for the moon. रविः is the third thing overhead, and the one the other two are measured against.

Sanskrit keeps several sun-words and this one has no agreed cousin outside India, so its history stops at the border. Its life since then has not: Hindi still calls Sunday *ravivār*, so the word gets said once a week by people who have never studied it.

What you've built

The third thing overhead, beside the sky and the moon.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *raviḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *saṁvatsaraḥ*, then *raviḥ*

Before you move on

What does रविः mean? (“the sun”.) Say it once more.

46.2 रश्मिः (raśmiḥ) — a ray

Before the new word: what did *raviḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: रश्मिः

रश्मिः (*raśmiḥ*) — “a ray”.

रश्मिः is a ray: one line of light, reaching down from रविः.

The same word means a rein or a cord held in the hand, and the two senses share one picture — something long and thin, stretched from a holder to the thing it holds. A ray reaches out of the sun the way a rein reaches out of a fist.

That doubling is worth noticing, because it shows how Sanskrit builds: not two words for two things, but one shape lent to both.

What you’ve built

The sun, and the line of light it lets down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *raśmiḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *raviḥ*, then *raśmiḥ*

Before you move on

What does रश्मिः mean? (“a ray”.) Say it once more.

46.3 प्रकाशः (prakāśaḥ) — light

Before the new word: what did *raśmiḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: प्रकाशः

प्रकाशः (*prakāśaḥ*) — “light”.

प्रकाशः is light: brightness itself, and the state of a thing being visible at all.

You met a piece meaning “to shine, to be seen” once before, sitting inside आकाशः, the open sky. प्रकाशः is that very piece with *pra-*, “forward”, in front of it — light as shining sent out.

So the sky and the light in it are built out of one word, parting only at the small piece each carries at the front. Ends in -अः.

What you’ve built

Light, and the piece it shares with the sky.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *prakāśaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *raśmiḥ*, then *prakāśaḥ*

Before you move on

What does प्रकाशः mean? (“light”.) Say it once more.

46.4 छाया (chāyā) — shade, a shadow

Before the new word: what did *prakāśaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: छाया

छाया (*chāyā*) — “shade, a shadow”.

छाया is shade, and equally the shadow a thing throws.

You have छत्रम् for the parasol. छाया is what the parasol makes: the cool patch, not the object holding it up. One is the tool and the other is the result, and now you can name both.

Greek *skiā*, “shadow”, is the same word, and English *shine* is usually put in the family too — brightness and the dark it casts named from one root. Feminine, ending in -आ.

What you've built

The thing the parasol makes, told apart from the parasol.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *chāyā*
- it once more, slowly
- *prakāśaḥ*, then *chāyā*

Before you move on

What does छाया mean? (“shade, a shadow”.) Say it once more.

46.5 तापः (tāpaḥ) — heat

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *prakāśaḥ* mean, and what did *chāyā* mean?

You'll want to know: तापः

तापः (*tāpaḥ*) — “heat”.

तापः is heat: the warmth of the sun on a back, and by an easy stretch the heat of trouble.

It stands on *tap*, “to be hot, to burn” — the same root under *tapas*, the heat a person is said to build up by hard practice. Sanskrit treats effort and warmth as one thing.

Latin *tepēre*, “to be warm”, is that root gone west, and English took *tepid* straight from it. Ends in -अः.

What you’ve built

Five things about light and warmth: the sun, a ray, light, shade, heat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tāpaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *raviḥ* and *tāpaḥ* together

Before you move on

What does तापः mean? (“heat”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 47

Parts of a House

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a wall, a window, a stair, a pillar and the floor in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C47-floor and demonstrate the chapter promise.

47.1 भित्तिः (bhittih) — a wall

Before the new word: what did *tāpaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: भित्तिः

भित्तिः (*bhittih*) — “a wall”.

भित्तिः is a wall: the built side of a room.

You know पुरम्, the town with a wall around it. भित्तिः is one such wall brought down to the size of a house — the thing itself rather than the place it encloses.

It stands on *bhid*, “to split, to break apart”, which is exactly what a wall does to a space: inside on one hand, outside on the other. Latin *findere*, “to cleave”, is the same root, behind English *fissure*, and English *bite* belongs to it as well.

What you've built

One wall, told apart from the walled town.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bhittih*
- it once more, slowly
- *tāpaḥ*, then *bhittih*

Before you move on

What does भित्तिः mean? (“a wall”.) Say it once more.

47.2 वातायनम् (vātāyanam) — a window

Before the new word: what did *bhittih* mean?

You’ll want to know: वातायनम्

वातायनम् (*vātāyanam*) — “a window”.

वातायनम् is a window, and the word says plainly what a window is for.

It is *vāta*, wind, joined to *ayana*, a going: a window is the wind’s way in. You already say वायुः for wind, and *vāta* is its near relative from the same root, “to blow”.

Set it against भित्तिः and the pair makes sense of a room: the wall shuts, the window opens. Neuter, ending in -अम्.

What you’ve built

The opening in the wall, named for what comes through it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vātāyanam*
- it once more, slowly
- *bhittih*, then *vātāyanam*

Before you move on

What does वातायनम् mean? (“a window”.) Say it once more.

47.3 सोपानम् (sopānam) — a stair

Before the new word: what did *vātāyanam* mean?

You’ll want to know: सोपानम्

सोपानम् (*sopānam*) — “a stair”.

सोपानम् is a stair, a flight of steps.

The usual way of taking it apart reads it as “the means of going up” — a small joining word in front, and behind it the sense of rising. The word carries its purpose on its face, the way वातायनम् does.

It stayed home and stayed itself: Hindi and Marathi both keep *sopān* for a stair. Neuter, ending in -अम्.

What you’ve built

The way up, added to the wall and the window.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sopānam*
- it once more, slowly
- *vātāyanam*, then *sopānam*

Before you move on

What does सोपानम् mean? (“a stair”.) Say it once more.

47.4 स्तम्भः (stambhaḥ) — a pillar

Before the new word: what did *sopānam* mean?

You'll want to know: स्तम्भः

स्तम्भः (*stambhaḥ*) — “a pillar”.

स्तम्भः is a pillar, a post: the upright that carries a roof.

It rests on *stambh*, “to prop, to make firm”. Where भित्तिः splits a space, स्तम्भः holds one open — a wall you can walk past.

English *staff* and *stamp* sit near it, and the picture under all three is one thing: something planted hard and standing. Ends in -अः.

What you've built

What holds the roof up, beside what closes the room in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *stambhaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *sopānam*, then *stambhaḥ*

Before you move on

What does स्तम्भः mean? (“a pillar”.) Say it once more.

47.5 तलम् (talam) — the floor

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *sopānam* mean, and what did *stambhaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: तलम्

तलम् (*talam*) — “the floor”.

तलम् is the floor: the flat under a room, and the underside of anything at all.

The palm of a hand is a *tala*, and so is the sole of a foot. The word names a flat bottom rather than a room in particular, which is why it reaches from a building to a body without changing shape.

Latin *tellūs*, “the ground”, is a cousin of it. Neuter, ending in -अम्.

What you've built

Five parts of a building: a wall, a window, a stair, a pillar, the floor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *talam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *bhittiḥ* and *talam* together

Before you move on

What does तलम् mean? (“the floor”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 48

More Animals

Modes: 🔄 voice (5) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a lion, a wolf, a goat, a monkey and a goose in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C48-goose and demonstrate the chapter promise.

48.1 सिंहः (simhaḥ) — a lion

Before the new word: what did *talam* mean?

You'll want to know: सिंहः

सिंहः (*simhaḥ*) — “a lion”.

सिंहः is a lion.

You have been handed this word twice without being told it. *Simhapura*, the lion town, is what *Singapore* was worn down from; and *Narasimha*, the man-lion, sets it beside नरः, the man you can already say. Here is the word on its own at last.

Its own parentage is unsettled — no cousin outside the family has been agreed on. How far it travelled is not in doubt: the language and the people of Sri Lanka are called Sinhala after it. Ends in -अः.

What you've built

A word you had already met twice, now yours to say.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *simhaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *talam*, then *simhaḥ*

Before you move on

What does सिंहः mean? (“a lion”.) Say it once more.

48.2 वृकः (vr̥kaḥ) — a wolf

Before the new word: what did *simhaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: वृकः

वृकः (*vr̥kaḥ*) — “a wolf”.

वृकः is a wolf.

Where सिंहः stops at the border, this one runs the whole way: Latin *lupus*, Greek *lykos*, English *wolf*, Russian *volk*. One animal that kept one name from the Ganges to the Atlantic.

The Sanskrit word is used of a tearing thing more generally too, which fits the root sense of tearing. Ends in -अः.

What you’ve built

Two animals, one with cousins abroad and one without.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vr̥kaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *simhaḥ*, then *vr̥kaḥ*

Before you move on

What does वृकः mean? (“a wolf”.) Say it once more.

48.3 छागः (chāgaḥ) — a goat

Before the new word: what did वृकाḥ mean?

You’ll want to know: छागः

छागः (chāgaḥ) — “a goat”.

छागः is a goat.

Like सिंहः and unlike वृकः, it has no agreed cousin outside India: the goat words of Europe and this one do not line up. Two animals out of the same field, and only one of them carried its name across the family.

That is worth holding on to, because it is what makes वृकः remarkable rather than ordinary. Ends in -अः.

What you’ve built

Three animals, and two different fates for a name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- chāgaḥ
- it once more, slowly
- वृकाḥ, then chāgaḥ

Before you move on

What does छागः mean? (“a goat”.) Say it once more.

48.4 वानरः (vānaraḥ) — a monkey

Before the new word: what did chāgaḥ mean?

You'll want to know: वानरः

वानरः (*vānaraḥ*) — “a monkey”.

वानरः is a monkey.

Two words you own are sitting inside it: वनम्, the forest, and नरः, the man. Sanskrit's own commentators read वानरः as the forest-man, and that reading has held for two thousand years, whatever later scholars have made of it.

So the word costs you one new shape and pays back two old ones. Ends in -अः.

What you've built

A word built out of two you had already.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vānaraḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *chāgaḥ*, then *vānaraḥ*

Before you move on

What does वानरः mean? (“a monkey”.) Say it once more.

48.5 हंसः (haṁsaḥ) — a goose

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *chāgaḥ* mean, and what did *vānaraḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: हंसः

हंसः (*haṁsaḥ*) — “a goose”.

हंसः is a goose, and in poetry a swan.

Another secure cousin, as far-travelled as वृकः: Latin *ānser*, Greek *khēn*, German *Gans*, English *goose* and *gander*. The bird held on to its name as faithfully as the wolf did.

In Sanskrit poetry it is the bird that can take milk out of water, so the word came to carry a sense of a mind that sorts things — and दुग्धम् is already yours to put beside it. Ends in -अः.

What you've built

Five animals: a lion, a wolf, a goat, a monkey, a goose.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *hamisah*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *simhah* and *hamisah* together

Before you move on

What does हंसः mean? (“a goose”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 49

Five Small Answers

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say then, as, only, again and again and oh in Sanskrit, and use any of the five on its own as a reply.
Complete SA-C49-oh and demonstrate the chapter promise.

49.1 तर्हि (tarhi) — then, in that case

Before the new word: what did *hamisah* mean?

You’ll want to know: तर्हि

तर्हि (*tarhi*) — “then, in that case”.

तर्हि — “then, in that case”.

Said on its own it answers a condition. Somebody tells you how matters stand; तर्हि is your “then, all right”.

It is built on the same *t-* that points for you in तत् and in तत्र. Those two point at a thing and at a place; तर्हि points at a moment — at that time, and so, therefore.

What you’ve built

A one-word answer to how things stand.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tarhi*
- it once more, slowly
- *hamisah*, then *tarhi*

Before you move on

What does तर्हि mean? (“then, in that case”.) Say it once more.

49.2 यथा (yathā) — as, in the way that

Before the new word: what did *tarhi* mean?

You’ll want to know: यथा

यथा (*yathā*) — “as, in the way that”.

यथा — “as, in the way that”.

You already say तथा, “so, in that way”. यथा is its partner, and the two travel together: *yathā ... tathā*, “as ... so”. Holding one of the pair, you now hold both.

Said back to somebody on its own, it works as “just so, as you say” — an agreement rather than a description.

What you’ve built

The other half of a pair you already had half of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *yathā*
- it once more, slowly
- *tarhi*, then *yathā*

Before you move on

What does यथा mean? (“as, in the way that”.) Say it once more.

49.3 केवलम् (kevalam) — only, merely

Before the new word: what did *yathā* mean?

You'll want to know: केवलम्

केवलम् (*kevalam*) — “only, merely”.

केवलम् — “only, merely, nothing but”.

Put it in front of what you are naming and it narrows the claim: केवलम् दुधम्, “only milk”. It is the ordinary Sanskrit “only”, not a poetic one.

It also stands alone. Asked how much of a thing there is, केवलम् on its own is a complete and slightly rueful answer.

What you've built

A word that narrows whatever it stands in front of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kevalam*
- it once more, slowly
- *yathā*, then *kevalam*

Before you move on

What does केवलम् mean? (“only, merely”.) Say it once more.

49.4 मुहुः (muhuh) — again and again

Before the new word: what did *kevalam* mean?

You'll want to know: मुहुः

मुहुः (*muhuh*) — “again and again”.

मुहुः — “again and again, over and over”.

You have पुनः for “again”, meaning one more time. मुहुः is the stronger one: not once more but repeatedly, and doubled as *muhur muhuh* it is stronger still.

It belongs with *muhūrta*, a short measured stretch of time. The picture underneath is a thing happening moment after moment after moment.

What you've built

A stronger “again” than the one you had.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *muhuh*
- it once more, slowly
- *kevalam*, then *muhuh*

Before you move on

What does मुहुः mean? (“again and again”.) Say it once more.

49.5 अहो (aho) — oh!

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *kevalam* mean, and what did *muhuh* mean?

You'll want to know: अहो

अहो (*aho*) — “oh!”.

अहो — “oh!”.

It is the sound of being struck by something: delight, surprise or dismay, with the tone deciding which. अहो on its own is a whole reply, and one of the few you can give without knowing what comes next.

It is two small cries stuck together rather than a word with parts, which is why there is no history to trace under it. Sanskrit wrote its exclamations down, and this one has been in the language for as long as anything in it.

What you've built

Five more replies: then, as, only, again and again, and oh.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aho*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *tarhi* and *aho* together

Before you move on

What does अहो mean? (“oh!”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 50

Sound and Song

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a sound, a question, the voice, a song and a verse in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C50-verse and demonstrate the chapter promise.

50.1 शब्दः (śabdah) — a sound

Before the new word: what did *aho* mean?

You'll want to know: शब्दः

शब्दः (śabdah) — “a sound”.

शब्दः is a sound, and by an easy stretch a word said aloud.

This one has been handed to you three times without ever being named. *kāla-śabdāḥ* were the time ones; *ka-śabdāḥ* were the question ones; *saṅkhyā-śabdāḥ* were the number ones. The *-śabdāḥ* ending each of those three names is this very word, said of more than one thing at a time.

So you have been reading it since long before this page. Now the piece itself is yours. Ends in -अः.

What you've built

The piece three earlier names were built out of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śabdaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *aho*, then *śabdaḥ*

Before you move on

What does शब्दः mean? (“a sound”.) Say it once more.

50.2 प्रश्नः (praśnaḥ) — a question

Before the new word: what did *śabdaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: प्रश्नः

प्रश्नः (*praśnaḥ*) — “a question”.

प्रश्नः is a question: the thing asked, rather than the asking of it.

You already say पृच्छति, “asks”. प्रश्नः stands on that same root, held still as a thing instead of running as an action — and the pair is worth saying together, because Sanskrit does this everywhere.

The root reaches a long way west: Latin *precārī*, “to beg”, behind English *pray* and *precarious*, and German *fragen*, “to ask”. Ends in -अः.

What you’ve built

The asking, and the thing asked, from one root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *praśnaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *śabdaḥ*, then *praśnaḥ*

Before you move on

What does प्रश्नः mean? (“a question”.) Say it once more.

50.3 वाणी (vāṇī) — the voice

Before the new word: what did *praśnaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: वाणी

वाणी (*vāṇī*) — “the voice”.

वाणी is the voice: speech as a thing heard, rather than speech as a thing meant.

It rests on a piece meaning “to sound”. Beside शब्दः, which is any sound at all, वाणी is the sound a person makes on purpose.

Capitalised, *Vāṇī* is a name of the goddess of speech, so the word carries a good deal more weight in poetry than its plain sense suggests. Feminine, ending in *-ī*.

What you’ve built

A sound narrowed down to the human one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vāṇī*
- it once more, slowly
- *praśnaḥ*, then *vāṇī*

Before you move on

What does वाणी mean? (“the voice”.) Say it once more.

50.4 गीतम् (gītām) — a song

Before the new word: what did *vāṇī* mean?

You'll want to know: गीतम्

गीतम् (*gītām*) — “a song”.

गीतम् is a song: the thing sung.

It stands on *gai*, “to sing”. The *Bhagavad Gītā* is this same word wearing a feminine ending — “the song”, and nothing more mysterious than that.

No secure western cousin has been agreed for it, but it kept its ground at home: Hindi *gīt* and Bengali *gīt* are still the everyday word for a song. Neuter, ending in -अम्.

What you've built

What the voice does when it is not talking.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *gītām*
- it once more, slowly
- *vāṇī*, then *gītām*

Before you move on

What does गीतम् mean? (“a song”). Say it once more.

50.5 श्लोकः (ślokaḥ) — a verse

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *vāṇī* mean, and what did *gītām* mean?

You'll want to know: श्लोकः

श्लोकः (*ślokaḥ*) — “a verse”.

श्लोकः is a verse: two lines, balanced against each other.

Its older sense is “sound, and what is heard of a person” — fame, in other words. So a verse is named as a thing that carries a sound outward. Beside शब्दः, which is any sound, श्लोकः is a sound cut to a shape that can be remembered.

Nearly the whole of the long Sanskrit story-poems is in this one shape, which is how the word came to mean the shape as well as the fame. Ends in -ॐ.

What you've built

Five things the ear takes in: a sound, a question, the voice, a song, a verse.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ślokaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *śabdaḥ* and *ślokaḥ* together

Before you move on

What does श्लोकः mean? (“a verse”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 51

More of the Family

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a husband, a wife, a grandfather, a grandmother and a mother’s brother in Sanskrit.

Complete SA-C51-uncle and demonstrate the chapter promise.

51.1 पतिः (patih) — a husband

Before the new word: what did *ślokaḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: पतिः

पतिः (*patih*) — “a husband”.

पतिः is a husband, and more widely the master of a household.

It is one of the oldest words the family holds: Latin *potis*, “able, in command”, behind English *possible* and *power*, and Greek *posis*, a husband. The *-pati* that ends a great many Indian names and titles is this word doing the same work.

Beside *kuṭumbam*, the household you can already name, पतिः is the one who answers for it. Ends in *-ih*.

What you’ve built

One end of a household, named.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *patiḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *ślokaḥ*, then *patiḥ*

Before you move on

What does पतिः mean? (“a husband”). Say it once more.

51.2 पत्नी (patnī) — a wife

Before the new word: what did *patiḥ* mean?

You’ll want to know: पत्नी

पत्नी (*patnī*) — “a wife”.

पत्नी is a wife, the mistress of the household.

It is पतिः with a feminine ending laid on it, and the two have travelled together since before Sanskrit was Sanskrit: Greek *potnia*, “lady”, is the very same formation made in the very same way.

So the second word costs almost nothing once the first is yours. Feminine, ending in *-ī*.

What you’ve built

The pair that a household is built on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *patnī*
- it once more, slowly
- *patiḥ*, then *patnī*

Before you move on

What does पत्नी mean? (“a wife”.) Say it once more.

51.3 पितामहः (pitāmahaḥ) — a grandfather

Before the new word: what did *patnī* mean?

You’ll want to know: पितामहः

पितामहः (*pitāmahaḥ*) — “a grandfather”.

पितामहः is a grandfather — and, precisely, the father’s father.

Both halves are already yours. पिता is the father, and महत् is big; the ending shifts a little in the joining, but the sense does not. A grandfather is the great father.

Sanskrit keeps the two sides of a family apart, so this word does not stretch to the mother’s side. Ends in -अः.

What you’ve built

A new word made of two old ones.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pitāmahaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- *patnī*, then *pitāmahaḥ*

Before you move on

What does पितामहः mean? (“a grandfather”.) Say it once more.

51.4 मातामही (mātāmahī) — a grandmother

Before the new word: what did *pitāmahaḥ* mean?

You'll want to know: मातामही

मातामही (*mātāmahī*) — “a grandmother”.

मातामही is a grandmother — and, precisely, the mother's mother.

It is built exactly as पितामहः is, with माता standing in front instead of पिता. Having watched the joining once, you can read this one before it is explained.

The pair also shows the line Sanskrit draws down the middle of a family: one word for each side, and no word covering both. Feminine, ending in -ī.

What you've built

The same joining, worked a second time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mātāmahī*
- it once more, slowly
- *pitāmahaḥ*, then *mātāmahī*

Before you move on

What does मातामही mean? (“a grandmother”.) Say it once more.

51.5 मातुलः (mātulaḥ) — a mother's brother

Before the last word of the chapter: what did *pitāmahaḥ* mean, and what did *mātāmahī* mean?

You'll want to know: मातुलः

मातुलः (*mātulaḥ*) — “a mother's brother”.

मातुलः is a mother's brother.

Sanskrit has no single word covering both uncles, and this is the one for the mother's side, with माता standing plainly inside it. The line drawn by पितामहः and मातामही is drawn here too.

Latin drew it in the same place: *avunculus* was the mother’s brother, and it is the word English wore down into *uncle*. Two languages, one distinction, one border apart. Ends in -अः.

What you’ve built

Five more of a household: a husband, a wife, a grandfather, a grandmother, a mother’s brother.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mātulaḥ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order, then *patiḥ* and *mātulaḥ* together

Before you move on

What does मातुलः mean? (“a mother’s brother”.) Say it once more.

The Devanagari script and Sanskrit sounds — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words. This page gathers the system, with the points a Devanagari reader still needs for *Sanskrit*.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** क *ka*, न *na*, म *ma* — left to right under a connecting top line.
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** का *kā*, कि *ki*, की *kī*, कु *ku*, के *ke*, को *ko*. A standalone (word-initial) vowel has its own letter: अ *a*, आ *ā*, इ *i*...
3. **A halant removes the vowel**, and the bare consonant joins the next as a **conjunct**: स् + त → स्त, न + य → न्य.

What Sanskrit needs even from a Devanagari reader

- **The visarga ृ (ḥ).** A soft breathed echo of the preceding vowel at a word’s end — *namaskārah*, *rāmah*. It usually marks the masculine-singular ending, so it is grammatical as well as phonetic.
- **The anusvāra ̣ (ṁ/ṅ).** A dot above the line nasalising the vowel or standing for a nasal consonant before another — very frequent in Sanskrit.
- **The vocalic ॠ ऋ (as in ṛgveda, ”Rg Veda”).** Sanskrit treats ॠ as a *vowel* — it is the ॠ of *māṭṛ* “mother” and *pitr* “father,” the words

that proved Sanskrit's kinship with Latin *māter/pater* and English *mother/father*.

- **Sandhi.** Sanskrit fuses words at their seams by fixed sound-rules: *su* + *āgata* → *svāgata*. The lessons flag each fusion where it happens.

Sanskrit in the family

Sanskrit is the classical language of India — the tongue of the Vedas, of Kālidāsa, of Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain learning — and the ancestor of the modern Indo-Aryan languages (Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi, Bengali, and more). It is a senior branch of **Indo-European**, sister to Greek, Latin, and the Germanic languages including English. That is why this book treats it, with Latin, as a *taproot*: its words reach both east into South Asia and west into Europe, and the lessons trace both directions.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

अभिनन्दनम् *abhinandanam*
congratulation, a greeting of delight
Introduced in Chapter 37.

अद्य *adya*
today
Introduced in Chapter 17.

आगच्छति *āgacchati*
he, she, or it comes — the same verb as “goes” with a prefix pointing it homeward
Introduced in Chapter 7.

अग्निः *agniḥ*
fire
Introduced in Chapter 38.

अहम् *aham*
I
Introduced in Chapter 3.

अहं संस्कृतं वदामि *aham saniskṛtam vadāmi*
I speak Sanskrit
Introduced in Chapter 5.

अहो *aho*
oh!
Introduced in Chapter 49.

आकाशः *ākāśaḥ*
the sky, open space
Introduced in Chapter 31.

अक्षि *akṣi*
eye — unbroken from Sanskrit to English, and the reason eyes get their own grammatical number
Introduced in Chapter 12.

अलम् *alam*

enough

Introduced in Chapter 27.

अल्प *alpa*

small

Introduced in Chapter 15.

आम् / न *ām / na*

yes / no (*ām / na*)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

आनन्दः *ānandaḥ*

joy — and “meeting you is a joy”

Introduced in Chapter 2.

अञ्जलिः *añjaliḥ*

the two hands cupped together

Introduced in Chapter 30.

अन्नम् *annam*

food, grain — literally “the eaten thing,” built on the very root खादति left uneaten

Introduced in Chapter 10.

अपि *api*

also, too

Introduced in Chapter 36.

आसनम् *āsanam*

a seat

Introduced in Chapter 30.

आशीर्वादः *āśīrvādaḥ*

a blessing

Introduced in Chapter 37.

अष्ट *aṣṭa*

eight

Introduced in Chapter 19.

अस्थि *asthi*

a bone

Introduced in Chapter 34.

अस्ति *asti*

is

Introduced in Chapter 2.

अस्ति • भवति *asti • bhavati*

is, and becomes — the two be-verbs Sanskrit keeps apart, and the root-plus-class system behind every Sanskrit verb

Introduced in Chapter 7.

अस्तु *astu*

so be it, all right

Introduced in Chapter 27.

अतिथिः *atithiḥ*

a guest

Introduced in Chapter 26.

आतिथ्यम् *ātithyam*

hospitality

Introduced in Chapter 43.

अत्र *atra*

here — where I am

Introduced in Chapter 14.

अवगच्छति • बुध्यते *avagacchati • budhyate*

he, she, or it understands — “goes down into” a thing, or wakes up to it

Introduced in Chapter 8.

बहु *bahu*

much, many

Introduced in Chapter 42.

बाहुः *bāhuḥ*

an arm

Introduced in Chapter 34.

बालः *bālaḥ*

child, boy

Introduced in Chapter 20.

भगिनी *bhaginī*

sister — not built on English “sister”’s root at all, but on “one with a share”

Introduced in Chapter 11.

भस्म *bhasma*

ash

Introduced in Chapter 38.

भवान् / त्वम् *bhavān / tvam*

you (respectful / familiar)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

भवान् कथम् अस्ति? *bhavān katham asti?*

how are you? (respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

भित्तिः *bhittiḥ*

a wall

Introduced in Chapter 47.

भ्राता *bhrātā*

brother — unbroken from Sanskrit to English, worn down two different ways

Introduced in Chapter 11.

चक्रम् *cakram*

a wheel

Introduced in Chapter 41.

चन्द्रः *candraḥ*

the moon

Introduced in Chapter 31.

छागः *chāgaḥ*

a goat

Introduced in Chapter 48.

छत्रम् *chatram*

a parasol

Introduced in Chapter 41.

छाया *chāyā*

shade, a shadow

Introduced in Chapter 46.

चिन्तयति *cintayati*

he, she, or it thinks — the tenth class, which plants a whole syllable अय between root and ending

Introduced in Chapter 8.

दधि *dadhi*

curd

Introduced in Chapter 40.

दहति *dahati*

he, she or it burns

Introduced in Chapter 22.

दन्तः *dantaḥ*

tooth

Introduced in Chapter 25.

दर्पणः *darpaṇaḥ*

a mirror

Introduced in Chapter 41.

दारु *dāru*

wood, timber

Introduced in Chapter 32.

दश *daśa*

ten

Introduced in Chapter 19.

देहः *dehaḥ*

the body

Introduced in Chapter 34.

धन्यः *dhanyaḥ*

fortunate, blessed

Introduced in Chapter 29.

धन्यवादः *dhanyavādaḥ*

thank you (dhanyavādaḥ)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

धेनुः *dhenuḥ*

a cow

Introduced in Chapter 39.

दिनम् *dinam*

day

Introduced in Chapter 17.

दीपः *dīpaḥ*

a lamp

Introduced in Chapter 24.

दुग्धम् *dugdham*

milk

Introduced in Chapter 35.

दुहिता *duhitā*

daughter

Introduced in Chapter 23.

द्वारम् *dvāram*

a door, a gate

Introduced in Chapter 30.

एक द्व त्रि चतुर् पञ्च *eka dva tri catur pañca*

one to five — Old Indo-Aryan ancestors preserved in Sanskrit, and cousins of the English ones

Introduced in Chapter 6.

एतत् *etat*

this one — the thing near me

Introduced in Chapter 14.

एवम् *evam*

thus, so

Introduced in Chapter 27.

गच्छामि *gacchāmi*

I go (a way to take leave)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

गच्छति *gacchati*

he, she, or it goes — the verb whose present stem you could never guess from its root

Introduced in Chapter 7.

गीतम् *gītam*

a song

Introduced in Chapter 50.

ग्रामः *grāmaḥ*

village

Introduced in Chapter 16.

गृहम् *gṛham*

house, home

Introduced in Chapter 16.

गृह्णाति *gr̥hṇāti*

he, she, or it takes, seizes — the ninth class again, and the root English grabs with

Introduced in Chapter 9.

ग्रीवा *grīvā*

the neck

Introduced in Chapter 34.

गुरुः *guruḥ*

a teacher, and the word for heavy

Introduced in Chapter 26.

हंसः *haṁsaḥ*

a goose

Introduced in Chapter 48.

हरितः *haritaḥ*

green

Introduced in Chapter 44.

हसति *hasati*

he, she or it laughs

Introduced in Chapter 21.

हस्तः *hastāḥ*

hand

Introduced in Chapter 25.

हिमम् *himam*

snow, frost

Introduced in Chapter 31.

हृदयम् *hṛdayam*

heart — the oldest, most secure cousin this book has shown, and kept whole two chapters east

Introduced in Chapter 13.

ह्यः *hyaḥ*

yesterday

Introduced in Chapter 17.

इदानीम् *idānīm*

now

Introduced in Chapter 28.

जलम् *jalam*

water (the stuff, not the drink)

Introduced in Chapter 24.

जनः *janah*

people, folk

Introduced in Chapter 20.

जानाति *jānāti*

he, she, or it knows — the root ज्ञा, the class that plants a syllable inside the verb, and the chapter's six roots gathered up

Introduced in Chapter 7.

कदा *kadā*

when?

Introduced in Chapter 18.

कदाचित् *kadācit*

sometimes

Introduced in Chapter 42.

कः *kaḥ*

who? — asking about a person

Introduced in Chapter 14.

कलशः *kalaśaḥ*

a water-pot

Introduced in Chapter 41.

कर्णः *karṇaḥ*

ear — a word Sanskrit itself never settled the origin of

Introduced in Chapter 12.

करोमि *karomi*

I do, I make (कार्यं करोमि, “I work”)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

कथम् *katham*

how

Introduced in Chapter 3.

कति *kati*

how many?

Introduced in Chapter 18.

केशः *keśaḥ*

hair (of the head)

Introduced in Chapter 25.

केवलम् *kevalam*

only, merely

Introduced in Chapter 49.

खादति *khādati*

he, she, or it eats — the everyday eat-verb, which is not the one English is related to

Introduced in Chapter 7.

किम् *kim*

what

Introduced in Chapter 2.

किमर्थम् *kimartham*

why?

Introduced in Chapter 18.

किञ्चित् *kiñcit*

a little, somewhat

Introduced in Chapter 42.

क्रीडति *krīḍati*

he, she or it plays

Introduced in Chapter 22.

कृपया *kṛpayā*

please

Introduced in Chapter 29.

क्षम्यताम् *kṣamyatām*

pardon me; let it be forgiven

Introduced in Chapter 29.

क्षीरम् *kṣīram*

milk — an origin scholars still argue over, and the dessert word it left behind

Introduced in Chapter 10.

कुशलम् *kuśalam*

well-being — and the reply “अहं कुशली अस्मि”

Introduced in Chapter 3.

कुतः *kutaḥ*

from where?

Introduced in Chapter 18.

कुत्र *kutra*

where? — asking about a place

Introduced in Chapter 14.

कुटुम्बम् *kuṭumbam*

family, household — a word Sanskrit itself borrowed, before other languages borrowed it back

Introduced in Chapter 11.

लता *latā*

a creeper, a climbing plant
Introduced in Chapter 32.

लवणम् *lavaṇam*

salt
Introduced in Chapter 35.

लिखति *likhati*

he, she, or it writes — a root that means “scratch,” and the chapter’s four verbs
gathered up
Introduced in Chapter 8.

मधु *madhu*

honey
Introduced in Chapter 35.

मध्याह्नः *madhyāhnaḥ*

noon
Introduced in Chapter 45.

महत् *mahat*

big
Introduced in Chapter 15.

माला *mālā*

a garland
Introduced in Chapter 30.

मम *mama*

my
Introduced in Chapter 2.

मम नाम ... अस्ति *mama nāma ... asti*

my name is...
Introduced in Chapter 2.

मन्दम् *mandam*

slowly, gently
Introduced in Chapter 36.

मार्गः *mārgaḥ*

road, path
Introduced in Chapter 16.

मासः *māsaḥ*

a month
Introduced in Chapter 45.

माता *mātā*

mother
Introduced in Chapter 23.

मातामही *mātāmahī*

a grandmother

Introduced in Chapter 51.

मत्स्यः *matsyaḥ*

a fish

Introduced in Chapter 39.

मातुलः *mātulaḥ*

a mother's brother

Introduced in Chapter 51.

मित्रम् *mitram*

friend — the word behind a covenant-god's name, naming a person while itself being neuter

Introduced in Chapter 11.

मोदकः *modakaḥ*

a sweet dumpling

Introduced in Chapter 40.

मृत्तिका *mṛttikā*

soil

Introduced in Chapter 38.

मुहुः *muhuḥ*

again and again

Introduced in Chapter 49.

मुखम् *mukham*

mouth, face — a word so old, scholars still argue which family it belongs to

Introduced in Chapter 12.

न चिन्ता *na cintā*

no worry / it's nothing / you're welcome

Introduced in Chapter 3.

नदी *nadī*

a river

Introduced in Chapter 33.

नगरम् *nagaram*

city

Introduced in Chapter 16.

नाम *nāma*

name

Introduced in Chapter 2.

नमस्कारः *namaskāraḥ*

hello (lit. “the making of a bow”) (namaskāraḥ)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

नमस्ते *namaste*

hello (lit. “a bow to you”) (namaste)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

नम्रता *namratā*

humility

Introduced in Chapter 43.

नरः *naraḥ*

man, person

Introduced in Chapter 20.

नारी *nārī*

woman

Introduced in Chapter 20.

नासिका *nāsikā*

nose — kin to two modern words, but the parent of neither

Introduced in Chapter 13.

नव *nava*

new

Introduced in Chapter 15.

नवन् *navan*

nine

Introduced in Chapter 19.

नवनीतम् *navanītam*

fresh butter

Introduced in Chapter 40.

नयति *nayati*

he, she or it leads

Introduced in Chapter 22.

नीलः *nīlaḥ*

blue

Introduced in Chapter 44.

नृत्यति *nṛtyati*

he, she or it dances

Introduced in Chapter 21.

ओदनः *odanaḥ*

cooked rice

Introduced in Chapter 24.

पादः *pādaḥ*

foot

Introduced in Chapter 25.

पानीयम् *pānīyam*

water — “the thing to be drunk,” and the exact word your neighbors’ पानी grew from

Introduced in Chapter 10.

परश्वः *paraśvaḥ*

the day after tomorrow

Introduced in Chapter 28.

पर्वतः *parvataḥ*

a mountain

Introduced in Chapter 33.

पश्यति *paśyati*

he, she, or it sees — a verb assembled from two different roots, one of which you already met

Introduced in Chapter 7.

पठति *paṭhati*

he, she, or it reads — reading as reciting aloud, and the two ways a Sanskrit word survives into a modern language

Introduced in Chapter 8.

पतिः *patiḥ*

a husband

Introduced in Chapter 51.

पत्नी *patnī*

a wife

Introduced in Chapter 51.

पत्रम् *patram*

a leaf

Introduced in Chapter 32.

फलम् *phalam*

fruit (and the result of anything)

Introduced in Chapter 24.

पिता *pitā*

father

Introduced in Chapter 23.

पीतः *pītaḥ*

yellow

Introduced in Chapter 44.

पितामहः *pitāmahaḥ*

a grandfather

Introduced in Chapter 51.

प्लवः *plavaḥ*

a boat, a raft

Introduced in Chapter 41.

प्रकाशः *prakāśaḥ*

light

Introduced in Chapter 46.

प्रणामः *praṇāmaḥ*

a bow, a respectful salutation

Introduced in Chapter 29.

प्रसन्नः *prasannaḥ*

pleased, gracious, clear

Introduced in Chapter 37.

प्रश्नः *praśnaḥ*

a question

Introduced in Chapter 50.

प्रातः *prātaḥ*

morning

Introduced in Chapter 45.

प्रायः *prāyaḥ*

mostly, for the most part

Introduced in Chapter 42.

पृच्छति *prcchati*

he, she, or it asks — the root that became Latin *prayer* and German *fragen*

Introduced in Chapter 9.

पुनः *punaḥ*

again

Introduced in Chapter 4.

पुनर्दर्शनाय *punardarśanāya*

until we meet again (lit. “for seeing again”)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

पुरम् *puram*

a town, a walled town

Introduced in Chapter 33.

पुरातन *purātana*

old — of a thing, not of a person

Introduced in Chapter 15.

पुष्पम् *puṣpam*

a flower

Introduced in Chapter 30.

पुस्तकम् *pustakam*

a book

Introduced in Chapter 35.

राजा *rājā*

a king

Introduced in Chapter 26.

रक्तम् *raktam*

blood

Introduced in Chapter 34.

रश्मिः *raśmih*

a ray

Introduced in Chapter 46.

रात्रिः *rātrih*

night

Introduced in Chapter 17.

रविः *raviḥ*

the sun

Introduced in Chapter 46.

शब्दः *śabdaḥ*

a sound

Introduced in Chapter 50.

सदा *sadā*

always

Introduced in Chapter 17.

सादरम् *sādaram*

respectfully, with respect

Introduced in Chapter 37.

साधु *sādhū*

well done, good

Introduced in Chapter 27.

सहसा *sahasā*

suddenly

Introduced in Chapter 42.

साहाय्यं करोति *sāhāyyam karoti*

he, she, or it helps — a noun plus “does,” and help named as going along with someone

Introduced in Chapter 9.

शाकम् *śākam*

a vegetable, a green

Introduced in Chapter 40.

समुद्रः *samudraḥ*

the sea

Introduced in Chapter 33.

संवत्सरः *saṁvatsaraḥ*

a year

Introduced in Chapter 45.

सम्यक् *samyak*

rightly, properly, exactly so
Introduced in Chapter 36.

शान्तिः *śāntiḥ*

peace, stillness
Introduced in Chapter 37.

सप्त *sapta*

seven
Introduced in Chapter 19.

सरलः *saralāḥ*

straightforward, honest
Introduced in Chapter 43.

शर्करा *śarkarā*

sugar
Introduced in Chapter 40.

सर्पः *sarpaḥ*

a snake
Introduced in Chapter 39.

सर्वम् *sarvam*

all, the whole of it
Introduced in Chapter 36.

षट् *ṣaṭ*

six
Introduced in Chapter 19.

सत्यम् *satyam*

true; the truth
Introduced in Chapter 27.

सायम् *sāyam*

evening
Introduced in Chapter 45.

शय्या *śayyā*

a bed
Introduced in Chapter 35.

सेतुः *setuḥ*

a bridge, a causeway
Introduced in Chapter 33.

सिकता *sikatā*

sand
Introduced in Chapter 38.

शिला *śilā*

a stone, a slab of rock
Introduced in Chapter 38.

सिंहः *simhaḥ*

a lion

Introduced in Chapter 48.

शिरः *śiraḥ*

head

Introduced in Chapter 25.

शिष्यः *śiṣyaḥ*

a student, a disciple

Introduced in Chapter 26.

श्लोकः *ślokaḥ*

a verse

Introduced in Chapter 50.

स्मरति *smarati*

he, she or it remembers

Introduced in Chapter 21.

स्निह्यति · प्रियम् *snihyati · priyam*

he, she, or it loves, and what is dear — affection named as stickiness, and the word behind English friend

Introduced in Chapter 9.

सोपानम् *sopānam*

a stair

Introduced in Chapter 47.

शृणोति *śṛṇoti*

he, she or it hears

Introduced in Chapter 22.

स्तम्भः *stambhaḥ*

a pillar

Introduced in Chapter 47.

शुभम् *śubham*

good, auspicious

Introduced in Chapter 28.

शुनकः *śunakaḥ*

a dog

Introduced in Chapter 39.

सूनुः *sūnuḥ*

son

Introduced in Chapter 23.

स्वागतम् *svāgatam*

welcome (lit. “well come”) (svāgatam)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

श्वः *śvaḥ*

tomorrow — and “see you tomorrow”
Introduced in Chapter 4.

स्वस्ति *svasti*

well-being (may it go well)
Introduced in Chapter 28.

श्वेतः *śvetaḥ*

white
Introduced in Chapter 44.

श्यामः *śyāmaḥ*

dark, black
Introduced in Chapter 44.

तलम् *talam*

the floor
Introduced in Chapter 47.

तापः *tāpaḥ*

heat
Introduced in Chapter 46.

तारा *tārā*

a star
Introduced in Chapter 31.

तर्हि *tarhi*

then, in that case
Introduced in Chapter 49.

तरुः *taruḥ*

a tree
Introduced in Chapter 32.

तत् *tat*

that one — the thing over there
Introduced in Chapter 14.

तथा *tathā*

so, in that way, likewise
Introduced in Chapter 36.

तत्र *tatra*

there — where I am not
Introduced in Chapter 14.

तव नाम किम्? *tava nāma kim?*

what’s your name?
Introduced in Chapter 2.

तिष्ठति *tiṣṭhati*

he, she or it stands
Introduced in Chapter 21.

तृणम् *tṛṇam*

grass, a blade of grass
Introduced in Chapter 32.

उपकारः *upakāraḥ*

a favour, a good turn
Introduced in Chapter 29.

उत्तम *uttama*

good
Introduced in Chapter 15.

वदामि *vadāmi*

I speak (from वद्, to speak)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

वैद्यः *vaidyah*

a physician
Introduced in Chapter 26.

वनम् *vanam*

forest, wood
Introduced in Chapter 16.

वानरः *vānaraḥ*

a monkey
Introduced in Chapter 48.

वाणी *vāṇī*

the voice
Introduced in Chapter 50.

वसामि *vasāmi*

I live, I dwell (from वस्, to dwell)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

वस्त्रम् *vastram*

cloth, a garment
Introduced in Chapter 24.

वातायनम् *vātāyanam*

a window
Introduced in Chapter 47.

वायुः *vāyuh*

wind, air
Introduced in Chapter 31.

विहगः *viḥagaḥ*

a bird
Introduced in Chapter 39.

विनयः *vinayah*

good conduct, training
Introduced in Chapter 43.

विश्वासः *viśvāsaḥ*

trust, confidence

Introduced in Chapter 43.

वृद्धः *vṛddhaḥ*

an old person, an elder

Introduced in Chapter 20.

वृकः *vṛkaḥ*

a wolf

Introduced in Chapter 48.

यथा *yathā*

as, in the way that

Introduced in Chapter 49.

यात्रा *yātrā*

a journey

Introduced in Chapter 28.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 6

6.1 *The Sanskrit numbers are English cousins*

Were the Latin and Sanskrit number forms borrowed from one another?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 6

6.1 *The Sanskrit numbers are English cousins*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no they were not; they are inherited cousins; inherited cousins

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

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a blessing आशीर्वादः (āśīrvādaḥ)

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explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

hello (lit. “the making of a bow”)

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The Mind and the Palm Leaf

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 67

the moon चन्द्रः (candraḥ)

Chapter 31, p. 243

the neck ग्रीवा (grīvā)

Chapter 34, p. 261

The People You'd Introduce

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 95

The River and the Road

chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 255

The Sanskrit numbers are English cousins

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 43

the sea समुद्रः (samudraḥ)

Chapter 33, p. 255

The Sky and Its Lights

chapter topic; Chapter 31, p. 243

the sky, open space आकाशः (ākāśaḥ)

Chapter 31, p. 243

the sun रविः (raviḥ)

Chapter 46, p. 333

The Tree and What Grows

chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 249

the two hands cupped together अञ्जलिः (añjaliḥ)

Chapter 30, p. 237

the voice वाणी (vāṇī)

Chapter 50, p. 357

then, in that case तर्हि (tarhi)

Chapter 49, p. 351

there — where I am not तत्र (tatra)

Chapter 14, p. 117

Things People Make

chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 303

Things You Ask For

chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 199

this one — the thing near me एतत् (etat)

Chapter 14, p. 117

thus, so एवम् (evam)

Chapter 27, p. 219

Time — Day, Night, and When Things Happen

chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 153

Times of the Day

chapter topic; Chapter 45, p. 327

today अद्य (adya)

Chapter 17, p. 153

tomorrow — and “see you tomorrow” श्वः (śvaḥ)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 29

tooth दन्तः (dantaḥ)

Chapter 25, p. 207

true; the truth सत्यम् (satyam)

Chapter 27, p. 219

trust, confidence विश्वासः (viśvāsaḥ)

Chapter 43, p. 315

U**until we meet again (lit. “for seeing****again”)** पुनर्दर्शनाय (punardarśanāya)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 29

V

Verbs of Mind and Motion

chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 187

village ग्रामः (grāmaḥ)

Chapter 16, p. 141

W

water (the stuff, not the drink) जलम् (jalam)

Chapter 24, p. 199

water — “the thing to be drunk,” and the exact word your neighbors’ पानी grew from पानीयम् (pānīyam)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 10, p. 87

welcome (lit. “well come”) (svāgatam) स्वागतम् (svāgatam)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

Welcoming a Guest

chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 237

well-being — and the reply “अहं कुशली अस्मि” कुशलम् (kuśalam)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 21

well-being (may it go well) स्वस्ति (svasti)

Chapter 28, p. 225

well done, good साधु (sādhu)

Chapter 27, p. 219

what किम् (kim)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 11

what’s your name? तव नाम किम्? (tava nāma kim?)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 11

What You’d Ask For

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 87

when? कदा (kadā)

Chapter 18, p. 163

where? — asking about a place कुत्र (kutra)

Chapter 14, p. 117

white श्वेतः (śvetaḥ)

Chapter 44, p. 321

who? — asking about a person कः (kaḥ)

Chapter 14, p. 117

why? किमर्थम् (kimartham)

Chapter 18, p. 163

wind, air वायुः (vāyuh)

Chapter 31, p. 243

woman नारी (nārī)

Chapter 20, p. 177

wood, timber दारु (dāru)

Chapter 32, p. 249

Y

yellow पीतः (pītaḥ)

Chapter 44, p. 321

yes / no (ām / na) आम् / न (ām / na)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

yesterday ह्यः (hyaḥ)

Chapter 17, p. 153

you (respectful / familiar) भवान् / त्वम् (bhavān / tvam)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 11

Other

अ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 35

-अम् · -अः (-am · -aḥ) — the two noun endings, side by side

grammar topic; Chapter 16, p. 141

आ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 11

इ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 28, p. 225

उ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 15, p. 129

ए — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 11, p. 95

ओ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 24, p. 199

क — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 51

क-शब्दाः (ka-śabdāḥ) — every question begins with k-

grammar topic; Chapter 18, p. 163

कालशब्दाः (kāla-śabdāḥ) — where a time word stands

grammar topic; Chapter 17, p. 153

ख — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 51

ग — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 16, p. 141

- च — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 51
- छ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 17, p. 153
- ज — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 16, p. 141
- झ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 43
- ट — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 14, p. 117
- ठ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 12, p. 105
- ड — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 22, p. 187
- ण — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 16, p. 141
- त — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 9, p. 77
- थ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 14, p. 117
- द — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
- ध — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 111
- न — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
- प — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 4, p. 29
- फ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 24, p. 199
- ब — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 15, p. 129
- भ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 11
- म — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 3, p. 21
- य — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 35
- र — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 4, p. 29
- ल — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 14, p. 117
- व — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 67

श — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 17, p. 153

ष — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 15, p. 129

स — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 10, p. 87

सङ्ख्याशब्दाः (saṅkhyā-śabdāḥ) — **the numbers, and what they
prove**

grammar topic; Chapter 19, p. 169

ह — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 11, p. 95